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Happening today

● **THE SECOND EDITION** of India's premier multinational air exercise 'Tarang Shakti' begins in Jodhpur. The exercise will bring global air forces together for 'high-octane joint tactical manoeuvres', the IAF has said.

● **TWO JEWEL-EMBEDDED** ivory pen cases, claimed to have been commissioned by Mughal emperor Jahangir, will be displayed in the US for the first time.

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THE BIG PICTURE



A MOTHER'S BATTLE TO BRING HER SON HOME FROM UKRAINE [PAGE 11](#)

THE WORLD



TRUMP, XI WRAP UP SUMMIT WITH TEA — MINUS ANY BREAKTHROUGH

RUSSIAN STRIKES SHUT UKRAINE STEELMAKER, FIVE KILLED

NATION

WRESTLERS MOVE COURT AGAINST BRIJ BHUSHAN ACQUITTAL

Union Minister to join Naga peace negotiations; encouraging: NSCN (IM)

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 25

IN A significant step forward in the Naga peace process, the Centre has agreed to include "a Union Minister or a group of Union-level Ministers" in the talks, meeting a longstanding demand of the NSCN-IM for political representation in the negotiations.

This development comes seven months after former Joint Intelligence Committee chief Ajit Lal was appointed as the Centre's pointsman for the talks.

In a statement Thursday,

AS OPP DIALS UP HEAT ON ELECTION COMMISSION

NDA partners to EC: Clarify, problematic if people begin to doubt electoral process

CEC must dispel misgivings: Chirag; transparency will help boost public confidence: TDP

Santosh Singh, Nikhila Henry & Jatin Anand
Patna, Hyderabad, New Delhi, September 25

MEMBERS OF the ruling BJP-led NDA on Friday said Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar must "dispel misgivings in the minds of the people" and the Election Commission (EC) must issue a clarification on internal differences over Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The statements from the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), the Telugu Desam Party, and the Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) came as the Opposition sought answers on the rift in the EC. *The Indian Express* on September 23 reported that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and to glaring gaps in processes.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



FOR HOMELESS, FIGHT TO STAY ON THE ROLLS: Residents of a night shelter run by the Delhi government at Sarai Kale Khan fill Form-6 to register as electors during a special SIR camp. AMIT MEHRA

[PAGE 3](#)

Divide within Election Commission unites bitter Bengal rivals TMC, CPM

Mamata speaks to M A Baby, urges Rahul to call INDIA bloc meeting next week

Manoj CG

New Delhi, September 25

BITTER RIVALS in West Bengal for decades, the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress

(TMC) and the CPI(M) have opened communication channels amid the Opposition's concerns over revelations in *The Indian Express* about the divide in the Election Commission

(EC) over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The two parties are founding members of the Opposition INDIA bloc but had eschewed any formal communication or contact until now.

Sources said Mamata Banerjee and CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby spoke over the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Form probe team, move against CEC: Petitioner to Supreme Court

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

A PETITION has been filed in the Supreme Court, urging it to declare as illegal "all decisions, guidelines, directives and software modifications initiated, approved, or implemented" under Chief Election Commissioner



CEC Gyanesh Kumar

Gyanesh Kumar "without full Commission concurrence".

The petition filed by Delhi-based lawyer Shailendra Mani Tripathi has sought a probe by an independent, high-powered judicial inquiry commission or a special investigation team headed by a retired judge of the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



ARAGHCHI MEETS TRUMP ENVOYS WITKOFF, KUSHNER

Iran proposes 7-day plan to end war, reopen Strait of Hormuz, revive n-talks

Offer being looked at by US, Qatar plays mediator on UNGA margins

Farnaz Fassihi & Pranav Baskar

New York, September 25

IRAN'S FOREIGN Minister Abbas Araghchi said Thursday that Tehran had proposed to Washington a seven-day plan to cease hostilities, reopen the Strait of Hormuz and then begin comprehensive talks on his country's nuclear programme.

Araghchi told reporters at a press briefing at the United Nations General Assembly that the proposal closely mirrored the commitments laid out in a so-called memorandum of understanding that was struck between the United States and Iran in June but quickly unravelled.

He said Iran was ready to begin putting the plan into effect as soon as Washington agreed to it.

"We have introduced a plan to the United States through the intermediaries that if certain conditions are met, the Strait of Hormuz would be open on the end of the seventh



The Strait of Hormuz has been largely shut since the war broke out in February. AP FILE

day and talks would restart," Araghchi said.

He said "it would be better" if a deal was reached before the US midterm elections.

An American official familiar with the talks said that the administration was having positive and constructive discussions through mediators, but that the United States was not going to rush into a deal.

The Iranian proposal came even as President Trump and Iran's President, Masoud Pezeshkian, delivered mutually hostile speeches at the United Nations. Trump threatened Iran with "annihilation" if it did not strike a deal, while a defiant

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Off-ramp window

The new proposal, which shrinks the 60-day timeline to 7 days, offers an off-ramp to both sides at a time when the US is headed to midterm elections and Iran has been severely impacted by the crisis in West Asia. The near closure of the Strait of Hormuz has sent global energy and food prices soaring and pressure has been mounting for a quick end to the war.

NATION

[PAGE 7](#)

AT UNGA, JAISHANKAR FLAGS RISING ATTACKS ON SHIPS, SEAFARERS

EXPRESS special

Key trade pacts in mind, Delhi looks at multi-nation visit by PM in December

India-Canada economic pact, India-EU Free Trade Agreement on the table

Divya A

New Delhi, September 25

KEEPING THE focus on sealing key trade agreements, Delhi is looking to schedule a multi-nation visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in December. *The Indian Express* has learnt. Destinations may include the US, Canada and at least two European countries, according to diplomatic sources.

While the India-Canada Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) is likely to be finalised and signed in December, it is learnt that the India-EU Free Trade Agreement will also be signed in Brussels the same month. Delhi and Washington, meanwhile, remain engaged on the Bilateral Trade Agreement, and hope to finalise it by December.

Although there is no official announcement yet from the Ministry of External Affairs on



Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

the Prime Minister's likely visit to North America and Europe, it is expected that he will travel to Miami for the summit of the G20 leaders on December 14-15. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio has formally invited Modi to the summit and this has been confirmed by US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor.

Sources said if the Prime Minister does attend the G20 summit, it opens a window for

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Omar brings J&K statehood resolution

J&K CM Omar Abdullah and other NC MLAs react as BJP legislators protest against a resolution moved by the CM seeking restoration of statehood, in the Assembly in Srinagar, Friday. PTI

[PAGE 6](#)

● **FIRST GOLD IN SHOOTING AND THE COUNTRY'S SECOND AT THE ASIAN GAMES IN JAPAN**

Lock, load, gold: Suruchi and Kamaljeet make most of second chance, set record



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 25

AFTER SHE returned to her hotel Wednesday, Suruchi Phogat slept for 13 hours straight. The next day, Kamaljeet Singh, too, would lay awake, tossing and turning. He went to bed around 1am and awoke at 5am, managing just four hours of sleep.

The two shooters dealt with disappointment differently,

but shared the same feeling after their individual events at the Asian Games: The sinking realisation that a competition they had worked towards for years had slipped away.

On Friday, they found a way to turn that feeling around.

Paired at the last minute in the 10m air pistol mixed team event, the Haryana shooters combined for 484.6 points in the final to win gold and set an Asian Games record. South Korea's pair of Choo Gaeun and Hong Suhyeon finished second with 478.0 points, while Iran took bronze with 415.8.

After days of near-misses, it

was India's first shooting gold at the Games and second overall, after the women's cricket team's victory. For Suruchi and Kamaljeet, however, the victory was more personal. It was a chance to leave behind the individual performances that had threatened to define their Games. "Maybe that was not our day. And maybe today was," Suruchi said.

For the 20-year-old, it was an unusually difficult outing. She began shooting at 13, travelling with her father — who initially wanted her to wrestle — from their home in Haryana's Sasoli to an academy in Bhiwani. By 2025, she had won



Suruchi Phogat and Kamaljeet Singh celebrate after winning gold in the 10-m air pistol mixed team final in Japan, Friday. PTI

three consecutive World Cup gold medals and set a junior world record, establishing her-

self as one of India's leading young shooters. In Nagoya, her first major tournament expo-

sure, she stumbled at the first block.

Suruchi's qualification began to unravel after a couple of 8s during warm-up. The shots unsettled her, and she became too cautious. She would raise her pistol and hesitate, unable to release the trigger. A round that normally took around 35 minutes stretched to 73.

"In the individual series I was under a lot of tension. I was looking at the scores. In my mind the scores were going round and round, and because of that I wasn't able to release the trigger. I was shooting late," she said. "I cannot remember the last time I shot that bad."

Kamaljeet's individual cam-

paign followed a different course but ended in frustration. The 23-year-old started strongly and briefly led qualification after the third series of 100 out of 100. A couple of poor shots, however, threw him off. He finished with 580 points, one short of the 581 required to reach the final. "I had started very well, but two or three shots in between affected me and I wasn't able to get stable mentally," he said.

For Kamaljeet, who had rebuilt his career after a serious injury, the setback was particularly difficult. In 2023, an auto-rickshaw carrying him back to his village after training was involved in an accident that killed

two co-passengers and left him with a fractured thigh bone. He spent a month in hospital as his family borrowed money for treatment, before rebuilding his career in pistol shooting.

'Second chance'

The prospect of leaving Japan without a medal remained until India changed its combination on match eve, replacing Kedarling Uchagave with Kamaljeet because of the form he showed in qualification. "I got a second chance, and I wanted to make the most of it," he said.

Suruchi took a different approach. She did not spend the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath at International Trade Show in Greater Noida. PTI

BrahMos made in UP giving sleepless nights to Pakistan, says Shah

Press Trust of India
Noida, September 25

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Friday said BrahMos missiles manufactured in a now-transformed Uttar Pradesh were giving "sleepless" nights to Pakistan, while the AK-203 assault rifle manufactured in Amethi has become a weapon against "Naxalites and terrorists".

He was speaking during the inauguration of the fourth edition of the Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show (UPITS) in Greater Noida. Shah, who is also the Union cooperation minister, rejected critics' claims about the state of the economy and asserted that India has not only maintained but "strengthened" its economic growth under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership despite global upheavals. "Amid such an atmosphere of upheaval and unrest across the world, despite numerous hurdles, India has maintained its growth rate. Not only has it maintained it, but it has taken it forward," he said.

Speaking about the transformation in Uttar Pradesh under the BJP rule after 2017, he said, "Today, BrahMos made in Uttar Pradesh gives Pakistan

Those with twisted outlook disputing GDP figures: Shah

Taking a veiled swipe at Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said "vakradrashtas" — those with a twisted outlook — keep disputing the GDP figures. He said India recorded 7.8 per cent growth in the last quarter. "Despite the turmoil in the world and despite many hurdles, India has maintained its development and has taken it forward," Shah said. "Some 'vakradrashtas'... Those whose thinking itself is dead cannot see vibrancy; they see dead everywhere." PTI

sleepless nights. This is the biggest sign of change," he said, recalling how India had effectively used BrahMos missiles during Operation Sindoor to avenge the dastardly civilian killings in Pahalgam.

He said the Modi government has signed FTAs with Mauritius, the UAE, Austria, a four-country European grouping, the UK, Oman, New Zealand and the EU, which has expanded export opportunities for Indian entrepreneurs.

Church notices caution non-Christians before entry in Chhattisgarh

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 25

OUTSIDE The 125-year-old Sunderganj Mennonite Church in Chhattisgarh's Dhamtari district, an unusual notice has been catching the eye of passers by for the past few days.

"According to rules, only Christians are allowed to enter this church for prayers. If others come of their own freewill, they would be held responsible (for their choice)," states the notice written in Hindi.

This church is not the only one in the district to have displayed such a notice. In the last one month, over 10 churches in Dhamtari have put up similar warnings. In fact, the banners are not just confined to church buildings. "As a precautionary measure, we have asked our community members to put up the banners outside their homes

where people come for prayers," Dr Diamond Filus, general secretary of the Dhamtari District Christian Forum, said.

The immediate trigger behind the move, a community leader said, is the steady flow of applications submitted to the district administration by non-Christians, stating they were going to the churches voluntarily. This, the leader said, has irked "right-wing members".

The applications follow a stringent anti-conversion law coming into force in Chhattisgarh last month. According to one of the law's provisions, a person who desires to convert from one faith to another must submit a declaration to the competent authority. Though it does not say anything about people casually visiting the churches, the community does not want to take its chances. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

PM

a bilateral meeting with President Donald Trump on the sidelines. They last met in June this year on the margins of the G7 Summit in Evian, France.

Earlier this week, ahead of his visit to the US for the G20 Trade Ministerial in Milwaukee, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said the proposed trade pact between India and the US was "done and

dusted", but its execution was awaiting a competitive advantage for Indian exporters over its competitors.

On Wednesday, in the first official discussion between Delhi and Washington after Trump signed the Russia sanctions Bill empowering the US to levy tariffs up to 100 per cent on Moscow's energy buyers, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar conveyed India's economic and strategic concerns to Rubio.

After their meeting on the sidelines of the UN General As-

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

NDA partners to EC: Clarify...

"Being part of the government, I will not defend anyone. If questions are being raised about the Election Commission, which is an independent constitutional body, responsibility lies with it, especially the CEC, to clarify their stand with firmness. It is problematic if people begin to doubt the electoral process itself. The EC needs to present its stance, not to Rahul Gandhi, but to the public ... it must dispel misgivings in the minds of people," Union Minister and LJP (RV) chief Chirag Paswan told reporters in Patna.

The TDP's Lok Sabha floor leader, Lavu Srikrishna Deva- rayalu, said the SIR was "conducted in a transparent manner" in Andhra Pradesh, but added, "At the same time, the Election Commission of

India is a constitutional institution entrusted with a crucial responsibility in our democracy. Therefore, whenever questions are raised by anyone, providing appropriate clarification and maintaining transparency will only help strengthen public confidence in the institution."

RLM chief and Rajya Sabha MP Upendra Kushwaha told The Indian Express, "What has transpired so far is that there is surely an issue with the EC's functioning. Whatever may be the case, the EC must clarify its position ... it must clarify the questions being raised and concerns being flagged."

"A great deal of confusion has arisen among the public regarding the controversy related to SIR. The matter needs to be addressed. To dispel the confusion,

the Election Commission should immediately issue a clarification on the correct position," he posted on X, tagging the EC's account.

JD(U) spokesperson Rajiv Ranjan Prasad asked why the Opposition had not filed any official complaint "if the allegations are true".

"The EC has explained its position. We are not going into what and wherefore of it," he said, adding, "The RJD was aware that it was going to be defeated. They kept trying to blame the Election Commission repeatedly. But the Election Commission of India sought a clarification when allegations of irregularities in the SIR were raised, and submitted that if there are so many accusations, why is there no of-

ficial complaint."

Responding to the *Express* investigation on September 23, the EC acknowledged the two Commissioners' written notes but described them as part of the panel's "decision-making process". However, it neither responded to any of the concerns raised by the Commissioners nor stated whether or how it addressed them. "Differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution," the Commission said in a press note signed by Deputy Director P Pawan. "They are a part of the decision-making process before a final decision is taken." The "written notes, observations, technical suggestions and internal checks-and-balances" by its members, it said, were "standard, ongoing practices", and "the suggestions given by the Commissioners were for further improving the electoral processes".

TMC, CPM

phone on Friday and discussed the need for Opposition parties to come together and launch a campaign to protect the credibility of the EC, the electoral process, and democracy. Banerjee also spoke to Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and urged him to convene a meeting of the INDIA bloc immediately, if possible on Monday or Tuesday next week, the sources said.

The telephonic conversation between Banerjee and Baby came two days after the CPI(M) general secretary wrote to her and other leaders of the INDIA bloc and non-BJP parties, urging all to come together for a meeting to discuss the developments related to the poll panel. Springing a surprise, Banerjee replied to Baby on Thursday and agreed with him that a "truly extraordinary situation" had developed.

"As you are aware, the expose on the Election Commission of India (ECI) that appeared in The Indian Express on 23 September 2026 is explosive. It reveals the authoritarian manner in which the ECI is functioning. This is a truly extraordinary situation in which the credibility of the ECI and our democracy is at stake. The ECI has been overriding all the objections we have raised regarding its functioning and pushing through the SIR process. More than 13 crore voters are being denied their right to vote," Baby wrote on September 23.

Baby said it would be prudent for the Opposition to meet and deliberate "with the urgency that the situation warrants". The CPI(M) leader said people were looking at the Opposition to defend the values of democracy, secularism, and the right to vote. The parties could decide on a mutually convenient date and

place to meet and discuss how to respond to "this extraordinary situation", he wrote.

Sources said Baby also wrote to non-INDIA bloc parties such as BRS, AAP, DMK, Tamil Nadu's ruling party TVK, BJD, and the Cuckooch Janta Party.

Banerjee is learnt to have told Baby that the INDIA bloc parties must meet immediately and forge a joint strategy. The former CM of West Bengal and her party have been at loggerheads with the EC for some years now.

Sources said INDIA bloc leaders have been in touch since *The Indian Express* investigation revealed the divide within the EC. The investigation revealed that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes. The EC responded to the investigation on

September 23, acknowledging the Commissioners' written notes but described them as part of the panel's "decision-making process". However, it neither responded to any of the concerns raised by the Commissioners nor stated whether or how it addressed them.

The Opposition parties have demanded the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, an impartial probe into the functioning of the EC to be supervised by the Supreme Court, and a halt to the SIR exercise. On Thursday, the parties also decided to give a fresh notice in Parliament seeking Kumar's removal.

The conversation between Banerjee and Baby comes at a time when the TMC — routed in the Assembly elections months ago — is facing an existential crisis. After its legislative and Parliamentary wings split, the party faced another setback when the EC froze its symbol and name earlier this month.

SC petition

Supreme Court in the wake of *The Indian Express* report on objections by two Election Commissioners to decisions taken by the Election Commission without their knowledge.

Tripathi has urged the court to issue appropriate directions to the competent statutory authority to register complaints and initiate prosecution under Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 against Gyanesh Kumar, Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Ma- neesh Garg and Director General (Information Technology) Seema Khanna and all other officers found guilty of deliberate breach of official duty.

The petition refers to "unprecedented constitutional fractures and illegalities committed within the Election Commission of India under Chief Election Commissioner Shri Gyanesh Kumar as exposed by documentary records published on September 23, 2026".

It said "these official files re-

veal that over a 10-month period (November 2025-August 2026), the other two Election Commissioners — Dr Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Dr. Vivek Joshi — formally recorded written dissents and objections on at least 14 separate occasions (including four times on a single day) against unilateral, unauthorized, and illegal decisions taken and executed in the name of the Commission".

"These illegal acts include: Unilateral & Illegal Alteration of Statutory Form 6... Centralisation and Usurpation of Statutory Powers: Depriving decentralised Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) of their statutory authority under Section 13B, 22, and 23 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and centralizing electoral roll management under the Director General of IT (DG-IT) in Delhi... Disenfranchisement Due to Software Failures... Unauthorized Subversion in West Bengal" by "filing over 16.10 lakh unauthorised appeals in the name of the ECI to purge citizens restored by 700 Judicial Officers, without the knowledge, authorization, or sanction of the

other two Election Commissioners or the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of West Bengal... Bureaucratic Usurpation and Subversion of Oversight" and "Subversion of Multi-Member Decision Making".

The plea said the alleged "act of... Kumar deliberately manipulating the electoral roll bears no 'reasonable nexus' or legal connection to his official duties; such an act falls squarely outside the ambit of official immunity and constitutes distinct, personal criminal liability."

It said that "in the absence of this legal nexus, the statutory protection available under Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners Act, 2023 becomes entirely ineffective. Although Section 16 bars courts from entertaining or continuing civil or criminal proceedings against the Chief Election Commissioner, this protective shield is restricted strictly to acts performed in the discharge or purported discharge of official duty."

Tripathi said that "from a constitutional standpoint, the

Chief Election Commissioner enjoys no personal immunity from criminal prosecution... Article 324 merely grants the Chief Election Commissioner security of tenure (subject to removal by impeachment), not immunity from personal criminal liability."

He urged the court to quash "the unauthorised modifications made to Form 6 on the ECI-Net/ERONet portal requiring ancestry/last-SIR declarations, and directing the immediate restoration of statutory Form 6 as prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 and permit all eligible adults to register as voters on the basis of original statutory requirements".

The petition said an SIT should be constituted to "conduct an end-to-end technical, forensic, and administrative audit of ECI-Net and ERONet databases, investigate the institutional circumstances under which 13 crore names were deleted across 30 States/UTs under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR)" and "identify individual culpability for the unauthorised filing of 16.10 lakh appeals and work-allocation subversions".

7-day plan to end war

Pezeshkian told world leaders his country would not be bullied.

Though Iran's proposal contains many of the same conditions of the deal that fell apart, the behind-the-scenes diplomacy suggested that both sides may see much to gain from finding an off-ramp from the war.

Iranian officials said that while the proposal was effectively the same as the memorandum of understanding made in June, it was designed to move at a much faster pace. In the earlier agreement, a 60-day time frame was set for reaching nuclear negotiations.

Under the conditions that Iran has set for the agreement, according to Araghchi, during the seven days all hostilities would end, including in Lebanon; the US would release Iran's frozen assets — estimated to be at least \$12 billion — waive sanctions on Iranian oil and lift the naval blockade on Iran. Then, on the last day, the Strait of Hormuz would be opened.

In the afternoon, Bahrain led 80 nations in condemning Iran's attacks in the strait and the Houthis for their actions in Yemen and attacks in Saudi Arabia and the Red Sea, and they called for the immediate reopening of the strait without tolls.

After the seven days, Araghchi said, comprehensive negotiations over Iran's nuclear programme would immediately begin. Trump has said that his top goal is for Iran not to have a nuclear weapon, and that he would either achieve that through a diplomatic deal or with more attacks.

The United States and Iran have been at war for nearly seven months. It began in late February when the United States and Israel launched airstrikes that killed Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and the military chain of command. Trump initially said the war would take only a few weeks.

The war has had widespread global repercussions including on oil, energy and food prices.

The Iranian proposal came as US negotiators have tried to jump start diplomacy with Iran on its nuclear programme through talks on the sidelines of the United Nations assembly. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said a three-hour meeting, mediated by Qatar, between US and Iranian officials did not end in a breakthrough.

Araghchi, who will be in New York until next Monday, met on Tuesday with US envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, a son-in-law of Trump's. It was mediated by Qataris passing messages between the twosides, and Araghchi described it as "productive" and said the messaging continued.

Ismael Baghaei, the spokesman for Iran's Foreign Ministry who is also in New York, said that it was possible that there would be more mediated meetings in the coming days.

Iran's economy is under serious strain, and Iranians are suffering from skyrocketing inflation on basic food items, a shortage of medicine and disruptions to commerce.

Analysts said Trump would have to weigh the benefits of reaching a deal with Iran before the midterms against keeping a chokehold on its economy in the hope of getting more concessions from Tehran.

"This is a smart move," said Ali Vaez, the Iran director of the International Crisis Group. "They know it's very tempting for President Trump because it ends an unpopular war and brings down energy prices in the run-up to the midterms. But it also restores a deal that was largely favourable to the Iranians. A compressed timeline to get to the nuclear issue should be appealing to an impatient President."

— THE NEW YORK TIMES

Prashant Kishor

election to the Rajya Sabha.

"The Jan Suraj Party is now looking to build a presence in Delhi, especially among the city's sizeable Purvanchali population," a source said.

Many Purvanchali supporters of the JSP, who trace their roots to Bihar, are likely to attend the party's Sunday meeting to be held at Lok Kala Manch or Janpath's Western Court.

"The people in Delhi are tired of the BJP and the AAP. Moreover, they have seen Kishor's vision for Bihar and Bankipur. We are hopeful of doing well in the national capital," a party insider said.

The JSP is zeroing in on a site for its Delhi office, with sources saying a couple of locations have been shortlisted and that only formalities relating to lease and rent have yet to be finalised.

The proposed JSP steering committee would be a precursor to the party's Delhi unit. According to sources, those likely to be part of this panel include advocate Tathagath Harshwardhan, son of ex-Buxar MP K K Tiwari, who was the party's Buxar candidate in the 2025 polls; Prof Shantanu Kumar of Deshbandhu College, Delhi University; J P Singh, a former Additional Director General of Police of Himachal Pradesh who contested the Chhapra seat on a party ticket.

Other JSP leaders expected to be inducted in the committee include Kunwar Chandresh, the Bihar party unit's intellectual cell head and former IES officer; advocate Abu Affan Farooque, Bihar unit's minority wing chief and ex-AMU Students' Union

president; Priyanka Singh from the party's Bihar Mahila wing; businessman Ajay Singh; and former ONGC director Badi Ud Doja, a prominent Seemanchal figure and son of former Bihar minister B Doja.

The JSP steering committee will be mandated to put in place the structure and office-bearers of the party in Delhi, sources said.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Shantanu Kumar said: "Despite not having a party organisation in place in Delhi, we have been reaching out to people taking Kishor's message and vision to them. The response has been positive."

Kumar said the JSP would contest all the coming elections in Delhi, ranging from the 2027 Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) polls to the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and the 2030 Assembly polls.

"Ours is an inclusive party, as people have seen in Bihar. We have no special focus on any particular community and will take along people from all economic and social strata of society, including Purvanchalis, which constitute around 25% of the electorate," Kumar said.

He said the JSP's USP would be to provide "out-of-the-box solutions" to the problems plaguing the people of Delhi.

"For instance, take the issue of air pollution and cleaning of Yamuna. There are mechanisms in place to tackle these issues but they are hardly effective. We will try to give innovative solutions to deal with them effectively," he added.

This puts pressure on the IM," an officer said.

The patience of people in Nagaland also appeared to be wearing thin over the inordinate delay in concluding the peace process. "That is building popular pressure on the NSCN-IM," the officer said.

The hardline stance of the Eastern Flank could make it difficult for the NSCN-IM to compromise on some of its core demands, including a Naga flag and its own Constitution, demands that Delhi has said will not be met.

On Friday, a day after its statement, the External Publicity Wing (EPW) of the NSCN-IM issued another statement asserting that the ongoing political negotiations were based on "sovereignty" between the government and the NSCN. It also described the "Nagalim national flag and Nagalim national constitution" as "non-negotiable".

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Asiad

intervening hours dissecting her individual performance or making technical adjustments. She rested and focused on the next competition. "I rested after the match. I just focused on the next match," she said. "That day when I came home, I slept for 13 hours. I got up feeling fresh."

By Friday, both had managed to put the previous day behind them.

Their coach, Samresh Jung,

resisted making any radical changes to their technique. His role was more of a mental coach. "They aren't sanyasis that they can simply erase the memories from a day ago, but my task was to replace the negative thoughts with positive ones," Jung, one of India's finest pistol shooters, said.

If there were nerves, the duo hid them well. They topped the qualification with a total of 587 and carried that form into the final. In the medal rounds, they took control early and maintained their advantage over South Korea. The 6.6-point win-

ning margin reflected a performance far removed from the uncertainty of their individual events.

For Kamaljeet, the gold brought relief as much as triumph. "It feels good. It's the Asian Games, and before coming here, I was sure I would return home with a medal. I didn't know it would be gold, but I was confident of winning one," the junior world champion said.

For Suruchi, it was reassurance that one difficult competition need not become a defining one.

Naga peace talks

And for the first time, the NSCN-IM also welcomed Lal's appointment as "interlocutor" for the talks even though he was appointed Adviser (North East) in the Ministry of Home Affairs in February. "This appointment is a 'significant and encouraging development' that reflects the GoI's renewed resolve to advance the peace process with seriousness and urgency," the outfit's statement said.

The tone and tenor of the statement is very different from the statements issued in the years when former IPS officer R N Ravi functioned as the Naga interlocutor. Following disagreements over the 2015 Framework Agreement for the Naga peace talks, heated exchanges between Ravi and the NSCN-IM prompted the latter to harden its stance and virtually pushed the

talks into a stalemate.

The NSCN-IM had accused Ravi of "mischievous" and attempts to "segregate Naga society", while Ravi called the NSCN an "armed gang" and accused it of running a "parallel government" engaged in extortion.

Even after Ravi was replaced by former Intelligence Bureau Additional Director A K Mishra, the talks failed to make much headway.

A Central security establishment officer said, "The NSCN-IM had always wanted the negotiations to be political with the involvement of political representatives. This is a positive development for the talks."

In its statement, the NSCN-IM also thanked the Nagaland government led by Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio for its "sincere participation and active facilitation"

of the political dialogue. "We acknowledge that the constructive engagement of the Nagaland government has been instrumental in sustaining the peace process and ensuring that the voices of the Naga people remain central to the negotiations," the statement said.

The government has been holding talks with the NSCN-IM since 1997 to resolve the decades-long insurgency in the Naga hills with the signing of a peace accord. On August 3, 2015, a Framework Agreement was signed between the government and the NSCN (I-M) in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. But little was achieved thereafter, and the public altercations between Ravi and the NSCN-IM in the early 2020s made a settlement appear even more distant.

Sources said the latest development was the result of multiple factors, including Lal's good relations with the Nagas —

SPECIAL SIR CAMP AT A SARAI KALE KHAN NIGHT SHELTER

‘We need IDs in case something happens’: For the homeless, a fight to stay on the voter rolls

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 25

AT 5.30 PM on Wednesday, the Sarai Kale Khan night shelter in Delhi was in its usual evening rhythm — children running around, teenage boys gathered around motorcycles, dinner being prepared in the common kitchen. Working men and women streamed in, tired after a day of physical labour.

Near one of the ship containers that serve as rooms, a special voter camp was underway. Five Booth Level Officers (BLOs) — teachers and bank officials — sat at two tables. They were half an hour behind schedule, held up by traffic and late lunches.

Meena Devi, 40, was among the first to approach them with a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) notice that said she had not provided details of herself or a relative to establish a link to the previous rolls.

She had to appear for a hearing on September 14 between 12 pm and 2.30 pm. “But I couldn’t go because I didn’t get off from work,” Meena, who is a sweeper in the Delhi Metro, said.

The officers told Meena that only her assigned BLO could conduct the hearing. Meena persisted, asking if there was anything they could do to help. There wasn’t.

“*Kya kare hum, humre liye voter ID zaruri hai kal ko koi hume Bangladeshi bolke kuchh karde* (What can we do, we need the voter ID in case someone does something... saying we are Bangladeshis),” she said.

Originally from West Bengal’s Malda district, Meena shifted to her husband’s place in Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh, after their wedding. The couple came to Delhi around a decade ago and have been living at the shelter ever since.

2-day camps in city

The camp was one of several being held at night shelters across Delhi to “make the electoral roll more inclusive”, according to the office of the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO). Organised from 5 pm to 9 pm on Wednesday and Thursday, the camps allowed residents to access the facilities after work.

One-third, or around 33.1



The SIR process underway at the night shelter in Sarai Kale Khan, New Delhi. AMIT MEHRA

lakh electors, on the draft roll have received notices to prove their eligibility to stay on the electoral roll: 13.79 lakh got notices because they could not link themselves to the electoral roll of the last intensive revision, 19.33 lakh were picked out for “logical discrepancies” in their enumeration forms.

The final electoral roll will be published on November 4.

The burden of proof

As the evening progressed, more residents, hearing that the “election *wale* officer” had come, drifted towards the tables

clutching Aadhaar cards, PAN cards and voter IDs.

“*Kya idhar pehchan patra banana? Kaunse kaagaz lagenge? Kiska ban sakta hai* (Will a voter ID be made here? Which documents are required? Who can get one)?” they asked.

Nearby, Gudia, 30, had an inkling that she might be deleted from the rolls. She had not received the enumeration form that others had, and believed the BLO had come when neither she nor her husband, Chotelal, was at their designated bed.

When her turn came, a BLO scanned the QR code on her

Voter ID card — the same one she had used to vote last year — and it showed up as deleted. “This voter ID was the only proof of our address in this shelter. If this gets deleted, someone might kick us out from here,” she said.

Gudia and her husband, who works as an e-rickshaw driver, have been living at the shelter for the past 12 years after their slum, just around 100 m across the road, was demolished for the Delhi Development Authority’s Baansera Park.

Their life now revolves around the daily schedule of the

shelter. They get a cup of tea in the morning, brunch at noon, dinner at 7 pm, and two beds — one for their three daughters and a son, one for themselves. The shelter, run by the Delhi government, can house around 350 homeless people.

“We got a place to stay here. We used to avail treatment at the mohalla clinic; all because so many of us voted for Kejriwal,” she added.

The mohalla clinic was now locked and deserted.

Gudia needs to reapply but a letter from the shelter caretaker is required as address proof to fill Form 6, the application for a fresh elector. But the caretaker was not there. She hoped to get the letter by Thursday morning so she could submit the form the following evening.

Logistical issues

By then, it had grown dark around the tables. With no additional lighting, the BLOs used their phone flashlights to illuminate the forms as they worked.

Authorities had not made arrangements for basic stationery supplies: glue to paste photographs on the Form 6s, a stapler to attach the forms to Aadhaar photocopies and a thumbpad for people who did not know how to sign. The BLOs had to request the shelter administration for the same.

Standing at one of the tables, Shyam Kumar, 30, said he did not want to miss an opportunity to get his voter ID made: he uses a walker to move around ever since a road accident during the Covid-19 pandemic left him severely injured.

“I thought this is a golden opportunity for me since I can’t go very far,” he said.

After a volley of questions, his Form 6 was filled.

Kumar, who used to work as an office peon before his accident, said he was looking forward to voting: “I see videos of Modi ji building roads and railways, now I can support him.”

By around 8 pm, the crowd had thinned. Nine Form 6s had been filled.

The five BLOs packed up. For most, the special camp was their third shift of the day — after their regular school or bank work and their BLO duties.



PM joins ‘Bhajan Clubbing’

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday took part in ‘Bhajan Clubbing’, where youngsters gather in concert-like settings to sing, clap and dance to devotional songs. The PM attended the event on the 110th birthday anniversary of Deendayal Upadhyay at a park opposite the BJP national headquarters in Delhi. Seated on front row, he was seen clapping and playing a tambourine-like instrument to a bhajan dedicated to Lord Ram. PTI

AASTHA KUNJ PARK GANGRAPE

Men led teen into bushes, assaulted at knifepoint: FIR

Pragynesh
New Delhi, September 25

THE THREE men arrested for allegedly gangraping a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park in South Delhi on Monday led her into the bushes and sexually assaulted her at knifepoint after claiming that they were policemen, according to the FIR lodged in the case.

The girl was at the park celebrating her birthday with a male friend, also 17 years old, when the men allegedly confronted them, took their phones and slapped her friend.

According to the FIR, the men told the two they were not allowed to be there. One of them then took her friend to another corner of the park, leaving her with the other two.

When the girl pleaded to speak to her mother, the FIR said, one of the men called out, “*Asif bhai, gun nikal* (Asif bhai, take out your gun).”

“The man showed a black gun. Then he kept it back in his pocket. Then both of them took out knives and then took me to a dark place,” the girl said in her statement, according to the FIR.

The sequence of events detailed in the FIR preceded the alleged assault.

Earlier that evening, the girl, celebrating her birthday, went to Kalkaji Mandir with her friend.

“I wanted to offer prayers at Kalkaji Mandir so I told my friend to take me there. My mother... was at work so I told my elder sister I was going there with my friend. We left around 5 pm in an auto and reached there around 5.45 pm,” she said.

Around 7 pm, as per the FIR, the two went to the park to sit for a while before going to ISKCON temple.

“We sat on a bench and opened a packet of chips. Suddenly, three men, aged between 30 and 35, caught hold of my friend and slapped him. When we asked who they were, they said they were policemen,” the girl said, as per the FIR.



At Aastha Kunj Park in South Delhi. FILE

The girl recalled the names the men used for one another — Asif, Hemu and Dipu. Hemu and Dipu were later identified as brothers, Hemant and Mukesh. *The Indian Express* had earlier reported that Asif was an alleged police informant.

According to the FIR, Asif raped her on a bench while holding a knife to her neck and asked Hemant to keep watch. She alleged that Hemant then raped her on another bench, followed by Mukesh.

She described Asif as the “healthiest (heavy set)” among the three in the FIR.

The accused allegedly then brought her friend back. “They gave us our phones and told us to go away quickly or they’d kill us. They told us to not tell anyone and took us out of the park. I told my friend about the rape and he called the PCR. After that, police arrived,” the FIR said.

As per an officer, after the assault, Asif initially went to the Okhla mandi, where he sold vegetables, before heading towards his home.

Sources in the police said that realising he would be arrested, he switched off his phone and attempted to flee on his bike. Police said they arrested him in a shootout on Tuesday.

An officer said that Mukesh and Hemant, on the other hand, went to an eatery before going back to their home in Srinivaspuri. They were arrested the same day.

Two arrested for ‘harassing’ Hindu College students, SUV seized

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

TWO DELHI University (DU) students, Abhinav and Abhimanyu, were arrested on Friday in connection with the alleged harassment faced by two Hindu College students in Northwest Delhi’s Mukherjee Nagar on Thursday.

While Abhinav was arrested from Laxmi Nagar in Delhi, Abhimanyu was apprehended from Gurugram in Haryana. They study at a college in North Campus, police said.

Police had earlier identified the accused driver as Naman, also a DU student, and said two to three persons were accompanying him at the time of the incident. The arrests come after a first-year postgraduate student of Hindu College alleged that a group of men in an SUV followed her and her friend and attempted to pull them into the vehicle around 9.30 pm on Wednesday.

The SUV allegedly used in the crime has been seized, police said. As per the complainant, she and her friend were walking when a white SUV approached them and the men inside allegedly passed comments at them. When the women objected, the men allegedly abused them and started following them.

The student alleged that when she and her friend stopped to record the incident, the men also stopped the vehicle and attempted to pull them inside. The accused fled when the complainant’s friend started filming the car.

Based on the complaint, an FIR was filed at the Mukherjee Nagar police station under sections 78 (stalking), 79 (word, gesture or act intended to insult the modesty of a woman) and 3(5) (common intention) of the BNS.

DCP (Northwest) Akansha Yadav said police traced the vehicle used in the incident. As per police, they are looking into the allegation that the two students had approached multiple police stations before the complaint was registered.

Eye on first-time voters, SIR camps for students next week

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

AS THE Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) focuses on maximising enrolment of young electors in the 18 to 25 age group, special camps are set to be held across colleges and universities in the Capital next week amid the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, according to an official statement on Friday. These special camps will be held on September 29 and 30.

Those who have turned 18 by October 1 but are not on the

draft roll can file Form 6 with supporting documents during the camps.

“In case name is not present in the Draft Electoral Roll, those who have completed or will be completing 18 years of age as on 01.10.2026 may file Form 6 along with supporting documents during these camps,” read the official statement, adding that the booth level officers or BLOs will be present at the camps. Form 6 is an application for registration as a new elector.

The Delhi poll body will also hold a special camp on September

27 at all polling station locations in the city for enrolment of eligible electors who were left out of the draft electoral roll. The September 27 camp will be the second such exercise after the first special camp was held on September 20, as per the statement.

The move comes after similar camps were organised at Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) night shelters and other locations for vulnerable communities such

as homeless persons, transgender persons and sex workers.

Delhi had 1.45 electors before the SIR exercise began. Of these, 97.5 lakh made their way to the draft roll published on August 31. Over 33 lakh electors received notices to prove eligibility, and 47.5 lakh electors were struck off the rolls after being marked “uncollectible” in the ASDD (Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate entries) list, or due to other reasons.

One-third, or around 33.1 lakh electors, on the draft roll have since received notices to prove their eligibility to stay on the electoral roll. 13.79 lakh elec-

tors got notices because they could not link themselves to the electoral roll of the last intensive revision, and 19.33 lakh were picked out for “logical discrepancies” in their enumeration forms.

Meanwhile, since August 31, only 1.21 lakh electors have filled the Form 6, according to Delhi CEO office’s data.

While claims and objections can be filed by people until September 30, notices will be sent until October 29. The final electoral roll is scheduled for publication on November 4.

• QALEEN BHAIIYA'S PIECES ARE COMBINED WITH CALLIGRAPHY, PAINTINGS AND GOLD DETAILING, OFTEN DESIGNED FOR A PARTICULAR SPACE

Studio in Okhla takes carpets off the floor, turns them into walls, ceilings and art

Anusree KC
New Delhi, September 25

IN THE June heat at Mushk Cafe, a rooftop cafe in Old Delhi, artists worked on scaffolding, fixing a carpet to the ceiling. Nearby, designs, cut from carpets, were being fitted on the cafe’s walls. It was an unusual sight — after all, a carpet belongs to the floor.

The installations were one of the projects undertaken by Qaleen Bhaiyya, a small studio in the busy Okhla market, which turns carpets into wall and ceiling installations, mirror frames and artworks. Its pieces are combined with calligraphy, paintings and gold detailing, often designed for a particular space.

“When we opened the store in February last year, we started out as a small store in the basement. Then we moved to a

bigger store on the ground floor before moving into this store. We did not want it to be just another carpet and rug store,” says 30-year-old Taha Khan.

Taha, who studied law before joining the business, points to a carpet on one of the walls of his office. It has been redesigned as a map of Afghanistan, with Urdu verses embossed on it.

“Kashmiri carpets came to Kashmir from Iran and still carry Persian influences,” says Taha, pointing to the Persian influence that runs through the work. Outside his office room, professionally cut pieces of a carpet have been used around a mirror on the wall.

The studio uses imported Iranian carpets for many of its artworks, particularly because of their intricate detailing. One carpet depicting the Kaaba, for instance, costs around Rs 3 lakh



as a raw carpet and took nearly a year to hand-weave. According to Taha, the studio only curate carpets that are distinct and unique.

For framed calligraphic works, the studio does not rely

on printed lettering. “The calligraphy is handwritten by the calligraphers in our team, which is then converted into digital files and printed onto fine MDF (Medium-Density Fiberboard) or HDMR (High-Density Moist-



The carpet fitted on the ceiling and walls at Mushk Cafe in Old Delhi; (above) Taha Khan, the owner of Qaleen Bhaiyya. INSTAGRAM/MUSHKCAFE & EXPRESS

ure Resistant) boards. These are cut using CNC machines and used in the final artwork,” Taha says. The core artists who make these pieces came together almost by chance.

Manaal (24), an illustrator

and graphic artist, first came to the studio as a customer after finding it on Instagram. “After my first visit, I kept coming back. I was thinking of trying something different,” she says. She is now one of the team’s main painters.

Calligrapher Abdu Rahman approached the studio for work after seeing its stall at a Jamia Millia Islamia fest. He later brought in Ruqayya (23), who had been learning Tazhib — a traditional decorative art form that involves hand-painting and gilding of manuscripts, calligraphic texts, and miniatures with intricate gold and colorful patterns — since she was young.

Tazhib is central to the visual identity of the team. “Though in

the actual Tazhib artworks, real gold is used for gilding, we use gold foils instead. We use acrylic colours to paint on the wall as it dries quickly and we can mix it well,” Ruqayya says. Both Manaal and Ruqayya studied Applied Arts at Jamia.

“None of this was planned. We are just some like-minded people who love art and create something different,” Taha says.

Much of the work is created for a particular space. “Once we see the work site, ideas are discussed and developed. If there is any mistake or there is something we don’t like, we paint it over and redo it. The freedom to work at our pace is very important to us,” Taha says.

For wall and ceiling installa-

tions, the process is more measured. “The surface is first measured and a sketch prepared. The carpet is then cut according to the design, its exact position marked on the wall or ceiling. Adhesive is applied to both surfaces before the carpet is bonded into place,” says Abdu.

The Mushk Cafe project was particularly demanding. Manaal spent hours on the scaffolding. “I wanted to give up halfway, but we wanted to prove we could think out-of-the-box and complete the project,” says Manaal. The team’s growing reach has largely been driven by social media. Instagram has brought the studio clients from across India and abroad. Its framed works have gone to the US, Canada, France and Australia, while site projects have taken the team to Hyderabad, Kolkata and Surat.

HAD BEEN ON THE RUN SINCE JUNE

Medical supplies fraud accused surrenders before anti-graft branch

Alok Singh
New Delhi, September 25

RAJIV RANGILA, 50, one of the alleged masterminds of the Rs 700-crore medical equipment procurement fraud, was arrested on Thursday after he surrendered before the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB), official sources said. He had been absconding since June and was reported to have fled to the United States after former Directorate General of Health Services chief Dr Vatsala Aggarwal and other key accused were arrested in the case, sources added.

His arrest comes nearly a week after the ACB filed a chargesheet against Rangila and others in the case. He was produced before a court on Friday and was sent to four days of police custody. A pharmaceutical trader, Rangila was summoned for questioning by the ACB in July in connection with the alleged fraud linked to DGHS, which looks after health-care delivery across the Capital; and the Central Procurement Agency (CPA), the nodal agency that supplies medicines, vaccines and medical equipment to government hospitals. After he failed to appear before the agency despite being served multiple notices, ACB officials launched searches for him across Delhi-NCR and Uttarakhand. During its probe, the ACB found that Rangila owned properties in Delhi, Haryana and Uttarakhand. He had also contested the 2014 Assembly election from Karnal in Haryana as an Independent but lost. Sources said a court had declared him a proclaimed offender and that the agency was planning to seize his properties in the first week of October.

Role under lens

Rangila is accused of being



Rajiv Rangila was arrested on Thursday.

the “main beneficiary” of the alleged fraud, which came to light in May after the Vigilance department conducted raids at the CPA offices.

A resident of East Delhi, he allegedly created fake firms in a bid to manipulate government tenders. The people allegedly shown as firm owners included his servants and tea vendors. Rangila was also accused of colluding with medical equipment manufacturers to fix supply rates and arrange for kickbacks to be paid back in cash.

The ACB converted Vigilance department complaint into an FIR on June 2. Sources said the agency would question him about shell companies and the people who allegedly helped him. He may also be questioned about missing department files.

Rangila allegedly prepared restrictive specifications in collusion with manufacturers, after which the documents were routed to Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, Head of Office, CPA, who placed them before the tender committee. Ranga was the first person to be arrested in the case on June 18. Members of the tender committees were allegedly coerced into approving these tailor-made specifications, as per the FIR. Dr Aggarwal, arrested on June 27, allegedly gave the final approval to the skewed tender conditions.

AFTER SATYA NIKETAN BUILDING COLLAPSE KILLED 7

Can't trace building plans of 70% of 2,453 PGs, MCD tells HC

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, September 25

AFTER IDENTIFYING over 2,400 buildings housing paying guest (PG) accommodation across the Capital, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) told a division bench of the Delhi High Court on Friday that it is unable to trace the building plans for over 70% of them.

The bench was hearing a batch of public interest litigations raising various concerns about regulating PG accommodations for university students

in the city, in the aftermath of the building collapse at Satya Niketan that killed seven people, including five students.

A survey of PG buildings by the MCD was undertaken following court orders, and it led to the identification of 2,453 PG buildings across the city with 32,247 rooms and approximately 50,529 occupants.

However, according to the MCD, it has traced building plans or verified the sanctioned plans from the “records presently available” for only 730 of these buildings.

When the bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia inquired about what had been done regarding the remaining two-thirds of the identified PG buildings, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, along with advocate Tushar Sannu, representing the MCD, said, “We are tracing them, they are not traceable.... Some of the buildings are 50-60 years old, tracing is a difficult task... Ownerships have also changed several hands.”

As per MCD, of these 2,453 buildings, only four have been

deemed “dangerous”.

In the past 17 days, the civic body has demolished 543 properties and sealed another 178 for unauthorised construction, it said.

The MCD survey also found, after covering 3.99 lakh properties in residential areas, that “more than 21,099 cases of commercial activities in residential areas have been noticed,” and that “about 30-40 properties have been sealed where such violations are found.”

The court will hear the

matter next on October 14.

According to an affidavit filed by the MCD before the Delhi HC, a detailed inspection of around 300 properties in Satya Niketan was carried out, and of these, 101 were found to be running as PG accommodation. The findings include:

■ Three of these buildings have been declared “dangerous” and vacated after the MCD initiated proceedings under the Delhi Municipal Corporation (DMC) Act. The owners moved the Delhi HC, challenging these notices under the DMC Act.

While staying the notices in separate proceedings, the HC has directed that “no PG shall be allowed to run in these properties until the buildings are found structurally safe”.

■ Ten other buildings have been found to be “vulnerable”, and their owners/occupiers have been directed to carry out the required strengthening, renovation, and major repairs as recommended in the structural audit report.

■ Fourteen other properties were found to require “minor repairs”.

‘Luggage hindered movement, emergency exit did not open’: Police probe safety lapses after fire in bus kills nine in Greater Noida

Drishti Jain
Noida, September 25

A NON-FUNCTIONAL emergency exit, luggage packed into the aisle and under the seats, and passengers in a rush to de-board may have left them with few options to escape after the AC sleeper bus caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida late Wednesday, killing nine people.

Police said they are now examining these possible safety lapses as part of the investigation into the fire, which engulfed the bus travelling from Delhi to Uttar Pradesh’s Mahoba within minutes.

The bus had three doors – two at the front and an emergency exit near the last seat. But according to police, the emergency exit was non-functional and passengers were unable to open it. “The door did not open as it was not functional. The bus was also overloaded with luggage. Bags and sacks were kept on the roof, under passenger seats, stacked in the aisle and in the vehicle’s storage space,” a senior police officer said.

Police said they are investigating whether the luggage further obstructed movement and access to the emergency exit as passengers tried to flee.

The fire started in the



Firefighters at the site after a sleeper bus caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida. PTI

driver’s cabin and spread rapidly towards the rear of the bus, police said. The luggage also caught fire, with the flames quickly engulfing the vehicle. According to the preliminary investigation, the fire is suspected to have started after a spark or blast in the bus’s AC system, which caused the engine lubricating oil to catch fire.

“Many passengers were carrying electrical items, including black wires and switchboards, which may have aggravated the fire,” the officer said.

Further, according to the police, several elderly passengers were sleeping on the upper berths. “When the smoke engulfed the bus, they tried to come down. But passengers

sleeping on the lower berths also started moving, and they could not move forward. Their bodies were found stacked on top of one another,” the officer said.

Moreover, police said they are probing whether the passengers’ warnings about a burning smell were ignored by two drivers and the conductor, who have been arrested.

According to their statements, some passengers alerted the driver and conductor about 2-3 km before the bus caught fire, after smelling something burning. “They went inside the cabin, but he did not stop. We are trying to verify these claims,” the officer said. The drivers and the conductor allegedly refused to stop the bus despite being

alerted about a burning smell and told passengers, “die if you want to, but we won’t stop the bus,” according to the FIR lodged in the case. By Friday evening, more than 36 hours after the fire, all nine bodies had been identified following multiple rounds of identification by relatives. Police are conducting DNA sampling to confirm the identities as the bodies were charred beyond recognition.

While seven of the deceased were from Uttar Pradesh, Devendra Sahay Bharadwaj was from Hisar in Haryana, and Shruti Rawat was from Chhatarpur in Madhya Pradesh, police said. Police said they are investigating the role of the bus owner, whose travel company operates around 30-35 buses.

The bus had all India permit issued in Muzaffarpur, Bihar, and other required documents, they said. “It had around 20 pending challans for traffic violations, including speeding and jumping signals. Some of the challans were between Rs 18,000 and Rs 26,000,” an officer said. “The three arrested men – the two drivers and the conductor – do not have any criminal cases against them in the city, but we are checking their records in other cities,” the officer added.

Day after man killed in knife attack, raids held to trace accused

Police: Bag with Rs 15 lakh stolen from e-rickshaw

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

A DAY after a man travelling in an e-rickshaw was killed in a knife attack during a robbery in North Delhi’s Kashmere Gate, police teams on Friday conducted raids at various locations to trace the three-four assailants who allegedly fled with Rs 15 lakh in cash.

While Prabhat died, his nephew Sachin and the e-rickshaw driver, Akash, sustained injuries in the attack.

Prabhat and Sachin, both residents of Morena in Madhya Pradesh, worked as collection agents for a transport company. They had collected more than Rs 30 lakh and were travelling from Gandhi Nagar towards Chandni Chowk in the e-rickshaw, carrying the cash in two bags, said police.

Sources in the police said the assailants appeared to know that the passengers were carrying a large amount of cash.

The attack took place around 7.30 pm near Yamuna Bazaar and the Marghat Wale

Baba flyover on Thursday.

The assailants allegedly intercepted the e-rickshaw and tried to snatch one of the bags. When the passengers resisted, they attacked Prabhat, Sachin and Akash with knives before fleeing with a bag containing Rs 15 lakh. They failed to take the second bag, which contained another Rs 15-20 lakh, the police sources said.

The attack took place in full public view. Mobile phone videos recorded afterwards showed a pool of blood on the road beside the e-rickshaw.

The three were rushed to the Trauma Centre in Civil Lines, where Prabhat died during treatment. Sachin suffered serious injuries and was referred to RML Hospital, while Akash was discharged after treatment later that night.

On Friday morning, after the postmortem examination, Prabhat’s body was handed over to his family.

Police said they suspect the accused may be residents of the area.

They are examining CCTV camera footage from the area and questioning eyewitnesses to identify the assailants. Several teams are conducting raids at suspected locations, while technical and human intelligence is being used to trace them, they added.

OFFICE OF THE DEPUTY INSPECTOR
GENERAL OF POLICE, WIRELESS

No.1, M. G. Road, Bengaluru-560001.
Phone: +91-80-22942324, Email: spwireless@ksp.gov.in

Tender No: KSP/2026-27/IND0658

Date: 25/09/2026

Tender Notification (Through e-procurement Portal)

Deputy Inspector General of Police, Wireless, Bengaluru invited tender for supply, installation, commissioning and comprehensive maintenance of High-End GPU Servers With Graphic Cards and associated Infrastructure for Cyber Crime Helpline-1930 through e-procurement portal. Estimated Bid value: Rs. 150 Lakhs. Pre-bid meeting on 28/09/2026 at 12.00 Hrs. The Last date and time for tender submission 09/10/2026 at 17.30 Hrs. Further details can be obtained by visiting e-procurement portal <https://eproc.karnataka.gov.in>. For more information, please contact the above office.

Sd/- Deputy Inspector General of Police,
Wireless, Bengaluru.

DIPR/CP/2959/SSC/2026-27

राजस्थान सरकार

कार्यालय जिला रसद अधिकारी, सवाई माधोपुर, (राज०)

Email:- dsoswm@gmail.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

E-Bids for Selection of Transporter For Handling and Transportation of Food grains Under PDS from FCI Depots To FPS in District sawai madhopur are invited Online Tender through e-proc from interested bidders up to 14.10.2026 For Complete details of downloading/uploading/ submitting of tender form and all other conditions of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> or <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>) of the state, The approximate value of the procurement is 04.00 cr. for One year.

UBN CODE: FCC2627SLRC00113

हस्ता/-

DIPR/C/16574/2026 कार्यालय जिला रसद अधिकारी, सवाई माधोपुर

BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION

Office of the Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture,
Mahadevapura / K.R. Pura Zone,
Vengaihan Lake ECO Park, K.R. Pura, Bengaluru-560036.

No: SADH(S)TENDER/202/2026-27

Date: 25-09-2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT) - (SHORT TERM)

(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPP Portal only)

The Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture (Mahadevapura / K.R. Pura Zone), BECC, Bengaluru (Referred to as Employer in these documents) invites Tenders to Implement Works in accordance with KPPP Rules 2000, from eligible and experienced Person / Agencies / Firms (Referred to as Tenderers in these documents) registered in Labour Department for Development of Parks.

(Standard Tender Document - KW-3)

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Beautification and Landscape Development, with Borewell Drilling and Other Civil Works in A. Narayanapura Bande Park (East Side) in Ward No. 20, K.R. Pura Constituency. Amount Put to Tender (Excluding GST) (in Rs.): 1,50,00,000/-, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 2,25,000/-

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender documents can be downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from 28-09-2026. 2) Last Date for Queries: 03-10-2026. 3) Date of Pre Bid Meeting: 03-10-2026. 4) Date of Tender Closing: 06-10-2026. 5) Date of Opening of Technical Bid: 08-10-2026. 6) Date of Opening of Financial Bid: After Approval of Technical Bid. Further details can be had from the above office.

Sd/- Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture
Mahadevapura / K.R. Pura Zone, BECC.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Javed @ Zabir S/o Abid Ali R/o Gali Sitara Masjid, Mustafabad, Ghaziabad (U.P.), has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 193/2015, U/S 363/174(A) IPC, PS Kamla Market, Central Distt., Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Javed @ Zabir cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Javed @ Zabir has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that Javed @ Zabir the said accused of FIR No. 193/2015, U/S 363/174(A) IPC, PS Kamla Market, Central Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 27.10.2026

By Order
Sh. Aakash Mohan Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-12,
Central Distt., Court No.-264,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/13701/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Deepak Kumar, S/o: Brij Bihari Shrivastav, R/o: H.No. 6B, R-Block, Gali No. 02, Vikas Nagar, Uttam Nagar, Delhi, Kanjhawala, Rohini, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 607/2021, U/s: 33/38/58(2) Delhi Excise Act, Police Station Kanjhawala, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Deepak Kumar cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Deepak Kumar has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Deepak Kumar of Police Station Kanjhawala, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.10.2026.

By Order
Sh. Apoorv Bhardwaj
MM-02, First Floor, Room No. 113,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13613/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person Abhinav, S/o: Rajpal R/o: 498, Gali Dr. Chawla Wali, Subzi Mandi, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 188/20, U/s: 379/356/34 IPC PS: Roop Nagar Delhi, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Abhinav, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Abhinav, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person Abhinav, of FIR No. 188/20, U/s: 379/356/34 IPC PS: Roop Nagar Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 05.11.2026.

By Order
Rashi Raheja
Judicial Magistrate First Class-13
(Central) Room No.33, Ground Floor
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/13488/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Arun Kumar S/o Jaldhar Ravi Dass R/o H. No. 303, Gali No. 1, X-Block, Braham Puri, Delhi-110053 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 956/22 U/s 279/337/338 IPC, PS Jahangir Puri, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Arun Kumar cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Arun Kumar has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that Arun Kumar in FIR No. 956/22 U/s 279/337/338 IPC, PS Jahangir Puri, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 18.11.2026.

By order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North, Court No. 6, Ground Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13598/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Samad, S/o Idrish R/o Mustafabad Near Chand Masjid, Ikram Nagar, Loni, Ghaziabad, U.P. has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.375/2023 u/s 379/511 IPC, P.S. Welcome, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Samad cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Samad has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Samad of FIR No.375/2023 u/s 379/511 IPC, P.S. Welcome, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 28.10.2026.

By Order,
Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No.14, First Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/12871/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person Gaurav Lamba S/o Sh. Harish Kumar Lamba R/o: H.No. 407/1, 407/2, Kh. No. 1320, Gali No. 13, B-Block, Swaroop Vihar, Nathupura, Burari, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CC No. 404/2022, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Subhash Place, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Gaurav Lamba, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Gaurav Lamba, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Gaurav Lamba, of CC No. 404/2022, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Subhash Place, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.10.2026.

By Order
Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04 (North West)
Room No. 112
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/13440/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Namely: Rajesh, S/o: Hari Om, R/o.: WZ-73, Gali No.1, Sudama Puri, Babarpur, Delhi (Mob.No.9268530028) has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide FIR No. 279/2014 U/S 392/394/34 IPC registered at P.S Jyoti Nagar, North East District, Delhi and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said Rajesh could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused Rajesh is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Rajesh, accused of FIR No. 279/2014 U/S 392/394/34 IPC, P.S Jyoti Nagar, North East District, Delhi is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before 27.10.2026.

By Order, Rahul Saini
Judicial Magistrate First Class-08,
Room No. G-06, New Court Building,
Shahdara District,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/13651/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely Rampal S/o Gyan Chand R/o H. No. B - 18 Gali No. 2 Hardev Nagar, Burari, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case FIR No. 578/2016 U/s 323/341/34 IPC PS: Burari, Delhi. and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Rampal cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Rampal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Rampal accused of FIR No. 578/2016 U/s 323/341/34 IPC PS: Burari, Delhi. is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 27.10.2026.

By Order
Ms. Poyal Singal
JMFC-09, Room No. 286
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/13679/N/2026
(Court Matter)

epaper.indianexpress.com



“ Today, Bharat is the third-largest solar power-generating nation in the world. Our non-fossil fuel energy capacity has tripled. Bharat was the first G20 country to meet the Paris Agreement goals ahead of schedule.

Shri Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



Foundation Stone

Laying Ceremony

150 TPD e-METHANOL PLANT

In Deendayal Port Authority, Kandla

An Initiative Towards India's Green Energy Transition

Assam Petro-Chemicals Limited, Namrup, Assam & Deendayal Port Authority (DPA), Kandla, Gujarat

11 AM on 26 September 2026 DPA Exhibition Ground, Gandhidham, Gujarat



KEY FEATURES

WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU

- 150 TPD capacity** – among India's largest e-Methanol facilities
- ₹2,300 crore investment**, structured as scalable modules in phases
- Located at Deendayal Port Authority, Kandla** – on India's busiest western trade route
- Fuels ships** on the Singapore–Rotterdam corridor, positioning India as a global green-fuel supplier, not just a buyer
- Brings together** Assam's industrial strength (APCL) and Gujarat's port gateway (DPA)

- Jobs at home** – over 3,500 direct and indirect jobs for youth, engineers and skilled workers
- Cleaner air, cleaner seas** – less dependence on imported fossil fuel, less pollution from shipping
- A more self-reliant India** – every tonne of e-Methanol made here is a tonne we don't import
- Stronger local economy** – new industry, new business for transporters, suppliers and traders around Kandla
- National pride** – India moves from being a fuel importer to a fuel exporter for the world's ships

Foundation Stone to be laid by

Shri Bhupendra Patel
Hon'ble Chief Minister of Gujarat

Shri Sarbananda Sonowal
Hon'ble Union Minister of Ports, Shipping & Waterways, Government of India

Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma
Hon'ble Chief Minister of Assam

In august presence of

Shri Shantanu Thakur
Hon'ble Minister of State for Ports, Shipping & Waterways

Shri Vinod Chavda
MP Kachchh, Gujarat

Smt. Maltiben Kishor Maheshwari
MLA, Gandhidham

Shri Vijay Kumar, IAS
Secretary
Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways

Shri Bikul Deka
Chairman
Assam Petro-Chemicals Ltd (APCL)

Shri Sushil Kumar Singh, IRSME
Chairman
Deendayal Port Authority (DPA)

Shri Hemanta Gogoi
Vice Chairman, APCL

From Assam's Industrial Strength to Gujarat's Global Gateway Towards a Greener, Stronger and Self-Reliant India

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Seva Watch

THE BHARATIYA Janata Yuva Morcha is keeping a close eye on its ongoing Vadnagar to Varanasi and Varanasi to Vadnagar Seva Sankalp Yatra, which is being organised to mark Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 25 years in public service. Monitored round the clock through a central dashboard, the Seva Yatra App clocks everything from the distance covered to the number of halts on the way. According to BJYM chief Hemang Joshi, public service initiatives bearing no party insignia or reference and connecting potential beneficiaries with the Central government schemes are the chief aims of the yatra. Sources in the BJYM say special emphasis is being given to keep track of the number of trees planted, cleanliness drives undertaken and public participation in such tasks.

App, Down

THE MOBILE application of the National Green Tribunal (NGT), launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Tribunal's international conference last Saturday, is giving tough times to the users, including lawyers. The NGT already had a mobile application for the purpose of providing information on cases and order details. However, users would complain that it seldom worked. Even after its high-profile "launch" at the conference, the app's functioning remains the same, it is learnt — throwing up 'server is busy' or 'slow down' messages every time a user tries to open it.

Tibetan govt-in-exile objects to Sonam Wangchuk remarks

Srinagar: A day after Ladakh activist Sonam Wangchuk compared the situation in Ladakh to China's treatment of Tibet in a speech in Leh, the Central Tibetan Administration expressed "concern" over his remarks. Tenzin Lekshay, spokesperson for the CTA, said on Friday that comparing the situation in Ladakh with that of Tibet was "misplaced and inaccurate". "His statement doesn't reflect the real situation inside Tibet..."

On this, Wangchuk on Friday said, "I don't blame them, for they don't know what happened that day in Leh..." ENS



Police personnel deployed outside the Election Commission of India building in New Delhi on Friday. AMIT MEHRA

Poll panel puts off CEC's youth outreach events

Damini Nath & Lalmani Verma
New Delhi, September 25

THE ELECTION Commission of India (ECI) has postponed two youth-focused voter awareness programmes scheduled in Uttar Pradesh's Meerut on Thursday and Varanasi on September 28 that Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar was to address, officials said on Friday.

This comes two days after *The Indian Express* reported differences within the ECI over the conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) and two Election Commissioners (ECs), Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, writing to the Cabinet Secretary about the conduct of an EC officer. On Thursday, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi called for the CEC to resign.

The youth pressure group,

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), also called for his resignation, saying they would launch a protest if he did not do so within 48 hours.

The CEC was to visit Meerut on Thursday to address a regional conference on Electoral Literacy Clubs (ELCs), the ECI's platform to spread awareness among school and college students, and ECINET, the ECI's portal and application for voter services. On September 28, he was to interact with the youth at a programme in Varanasi.

On the postponement, an EC officer said, "Adjustments in dates of events are an ongoing process which is necessitated by factors such as availability of venues, schedules of higher authorities, natural factors, etc. There have been many occasions when the ELC conferences have been postponed/dates changed earlier, such as in Himachal Pradesh, Ladakh,

and Uttarakhand. Moreover, the decision to postpone these two particular conferences was taken on September 21."

Sources say the programmes have been postponed indefinitely. "In both cities, the CEC had to address the ELCs with a gathering of nearly 1,500 people including students, teachers, and other representatives from educational institutions. He had a dedicated session of interaction with nearly 500 BLOs from several assembly constituencies," said an officer in Uttar Pradesh. "Preparations had started for these events in both the cities, and venues had been identified. But the ECI on September 21 communicated that the CEC's visit has been postponed."

So far, the ECI has had five conferences of the revamped ELCs, (ELC 2.0), and ECINET, with the last one being in Ahmedabad on September 11.

"Addressing the participants comprising students and teachers from schools, colleges and universities across Gujarat, CEC Shri Gyanesh Kumar described students as the future of the nation, stating that the ELCs are imperative in carrying forth the understanding of electoral processes and enriching democracy," an ECI statement on September 11 had said.

"He underlined the need for students and young electors to familiarise themselves with India's electoral system, democratic values, electoral registration, polling and counting processes, and the role and functioning of the ECI," it said.

The ELCs comprise all students from classes 9-12 in schools and all 18-to 21-year-olds in colleges. The ELC programme includes classroom activities and games in the participating schools and colleges focused on voter awareness.

'Just the beginning': Cong stages protests seeking CEC's removal

Protests in Delhi, Lucknow, Bhopal, Patna, Guwahati, Chandigarh and other state capitals

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

IN THE wake of *The Indian Express* report that two election commissioners objected on record 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken by the poll panel, the Congress on Friday held protests in state capitals across the country, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Protests were held in Delhi, Chandigarh, Lucknow, Bhopal, Patna, Guwahati, and other state capitals. Several leaders were detained during the protests, including the party's Assam unit chief Gaurav Gogoi in Guwahati and Uttar Pradesh unit chief Ajay Rai in Lucknow.

Police used force against the protesters at many places. Congress workers clashed with the police in Lucknow after they were stopped from marching towards the UP Chief Electoral Officer's office in Hazratganj.

The Congress is planning protests at the district level in all states on Monday, and a Congress Working Committee meeting will be held in Delhi on Tuesday to discuss further strategy on the demand for CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said: "Gyanesh will go, it's a matter of time... Congress will make it happen. The protests held by our leaders and workers across the country demanding his removal are just the beginning. There will be a massive outpouring of the defenders of democracy against the 'deshdrohis'."



Assam Pradesh Congress Committee president Gaurav Gogoi being detained by police in Guwahati on Friday. PTI

Yogendra Yadav, Prashant Bhushan among protesters detained in Delhi

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

AT LEAST 60 people, including All India Students' Association (AISA) leader Neha Bora, political analyst Yogendra Yadav, social activist Anjali Bhardwaj, Advocate Prashant Bhushan and CPI(M) leader Dipankar Bhattacharya, were detained near Jantar Mantar on Friday while protesting against the SIR and demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

According to Delhi Police, protesters had not taken permission for the assembly, and Section 163 was imposed in New Delhi district, prohibiting the gathering of five or more people.

The call for the protest was given by AISA, and police had put up barricades around Jantar Mantar. As protesters started gathering near Parliament Street, police did not allow them to enter Jantar Mantar. Police took the detained protesters in buses to different police stations in north and northwest Delhi and later released them.

Omar moves statehood resolution in J&K House; BJP protests, says unacceptable

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, September 25

THE JAMMU and Kashmir Assembly witnessed chaotic scenes on Friday as BJP MLAs, led by Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma, entered the well of the House in protest against a statehood resolution moved by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah.

On the fourth day of the autumn session, the chief minister moved a resolution calling upon the Government of India "for the immediate and urgent restoration of full statehood to Jammu and Kashmir and resolves that this Resolution be forwarded to the Government of India".

The document states that Friday's resolution is in addition to resolutions passed by the J&K Assembly on June 26, 2000, and November 6, 2024. The BJP opposed this and raised slogans against the ruling National Conference, terming



CM Omar Abdullah in the Assembly on Friday. PTI

the resolution "anti-national."

The June 2000 resolution is the 'Autonomy Resolution' passed by the J&K House with Farooq Abdullah as chief minister. It called upon the Government of India to revert to the pre-1953 constitutional position, which meant a return to the pre-1953 era — including the reintroduction of the designations Wazir-e-Azam and Sadr-e-Ri-

sayat for its top political leaders.

After the first elections for the J&K Assembly as a UT were held in 2024, the first session of the new Assembly passed a resolution in November 2024 seeking a dialogue for "restoration of special status and constitutional guarantees" to the UT and urging that "constitutional mechanisms" be worked out for the same. The resolution was passed

by a voice vote, with all parties barring the BJP supporting it. Both resolutions found mention in Omar's resolution on Friday.

Omar said this resolution simply calls on the Government of India to fulfil its commitment and restore full statehood to J&K. "Sometimes I hear about getting 'half state' or statehood without law and order. We do not want that. We were promised a full state, and we want that returned." He also urged the Speaker to designate time for a discussion in the House.

LoP Sunil Sharma said that the autonomy resolution was "rejected and torn up" by the BJP. To bring that and the 'special status' resolution of 2024 afresh into the House, the LoP said, is "controversial and unacceptable" to the BJP. "We will not tolerate it," Sharma said.

As the ruckus continued, Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather adjourned the House for the day.

BJP wins mayoral polls in Jaipur, Kota & Jodhpur

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, September 25

THE BJP on Friday clinched the closely contested mayoral posts in Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota, with its candidates defeating their Congress rivals through a combination of BJP councillors, independents and additional support. The results came amid clashes, protests, and cross-voting.

In Jaipur, BJP's Sunil Kothari was elected mayor after securing 89 votes against Congress's Sunita Mawar, who received 60 votes. In Jodhpur, BJP's Prasanachand Mehta defeated Congress candidate Rajendra Singh Solanki in the 100-member municipal corporation. Mehta secured 53 votes against Solanki's 47. In Kota, BJP's Anusuiya Goswami was elected mayor after securing 65 votes, defeating Congress candidate Sunita Suman, who received 35 votes.

Gyanesh Kumar should get Padma Bhushan, says Bengal BJP chief

Express News Service
Kolkata, September 25

AMID OPPOSITION'S demand for the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, West Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya on Friday defended him, saying he deserves the Padma Bhushan for handling the Assembly polls in the state earlier this year.

The Opposition plans to move a motion in Parliament to remove the CEC after *The Indian Express* reported that the two ECs raised objections to SIR-related decisions made without their knowledge.

"The people of West Bengal are delighted that, after so long, intimidation was kept at bay. There were no incidents of murder, and people were actually allowed to cast their votes. Furthermore, in a border



West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya

state like this, Gyanesh Kumar took the initiative to remove the names of Bangladeshi infiltrators from the voter lists," the senior BJP leader said, adding, "Gyanesh Kumar deserves to be awarded, at the very least, with the Padma Bhushan."

He lauded the SIR of electoral rolls, claiming it successfully purged deceased, fictitious, and illegal Bangladeshi voters. "The people of Bengal have rarely witnessed an election like this..."

AAP's army of women: Welfare Sakhis build party's network in Punjab villages



NORTHERN LIGHTS
BY MANRAJ GREWAL
SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON POLITICS AND POWER SHIFTS IN PUNJAB, HARYANA AND HIMACHAL PRADESH

THE DAY has barely begun, but Salamati Chauhan (44), is already out and about. "I am always on the move," she smiles, lowering the volume of the Zoom call she is attending.

Salamati is an elected panch of the AAP from Machhli Kalan village on the border of Mohali and Fatehgarh Sahib districts. Her ward, she says, had always voted Congress. Yet, this time she won and she believes women played a decisive role.

There is a reason: Salamati is the lead Mahila Sarkar Sakhi in this village of 2,500 voters. She was tasked with registering women for the Maavan Dheeyan Satkar Yojana, under which every eligible woman gets Rs 1,000 a month and Dalit women get Rs 1,500. The Bhagwant Mann government claims 97% of the women in Punjab are now covered by the scheme.

The scheme was one of the AAP government's guarantees when it came to power in 2022. But it was implemented only in July this year, when three months' money was transferred in advance to beneficiaries on July 1. "The women were given Rs 3,000 for July, August, and September. Now the CM saab has promised the second instalment, with money for October, November and December," says Salamati. Mann has been telling women in his "Lok Milnis" — public outreach events that their phones would once again go "toon toon" on October 1.

As Punjab heads towards the next Assembly elections,

the significance of this outreach goes beyond the money itself.

Salamati says initially the plan was for party workers to fan out across villages to register women. Then the strategy changed. She was asked to rope in over a dozen non-party member women from the village as Sakhis. She selected 12 women between 20 and 50 years old, all of whom got codes and households. Every constituency has around 200 such Sakhis.

The payment was simple: Rs 100 for every registration. "CM Mann has said if re-elected, we will get Rs 200 more per registration," she says.

Kanwar Sandhu, a veteran editor and former AAP MLA, points to the political arithmetic behind this scheme. "The state spends about Rs 9,600 crore a year to cover around 68 lakh women, while paying Da ar-rears to 6.25 lakh employees would cost over 14,191 crore. No wonder the state has approached the apex court to clear the arrears in instalments."

But the story in Machhli



Sakhis like Salamati Chauhan in Machhli Kalan village are turning welfare schemes into a new kind of political power. JASBIR MALHI

Kalan is not only about cash.

Salamati is also the Nasha Mukti coordinator for nine villages, a position and the accompanying identity card, she says, gives her access to the SDM and deputy commissioner. "The nasha hasn't stopped," she laments, while adding that the police do respond when approached. The problem, she says, is that those arrested are often released on bail.

Tarsem Lal, caretaker of the Vishwakarma Bhawan in the village, describes it simply as "*paal-son da khel*" (a game of money).

Salamati is also involved in hiring MGNREGA workers. She claims she has managed to provide work to over 75 women.

"There was no work for the last two years, but this year we have been getting steady work," says Jasbir Kaur, 65, the oldest of the women cutting tall weeds

along the roadside at Choor-majra. They work from 9 am to 1 pm and then from 2 pm to 5 pm, most wearing gloves and arm covers against the bristly weeds.

Last month, many of these women travelled to Amritsar on a state government-sponsored teerath yatra. Salamati went with them. "We went by an air-conditioned luxury bus and spent three days there, visiting the Golden Temple, Durgiana temple and Ram Tirath temple," she says. They were provided AC accommodation and taken for sightseeing to the Wagah border as well. Since April, the village has seen three tours, two to Amritsar and one to Vrindavan.

It is this repeated contact that may be more politically significant than any single scheme.

Salamati has recently been given the role of "BLO 2", she says, with responsibility for identifying new voters and keeping track of votes that have been deleted. She believes the Sakhi scheme has been a huge hit. "None of these women were part of the Aam Aadmi Party,

But now they are very sympathetic towards it," she says.

There are other signs of a social change under way. Amreek Singh, secretary of the Teachers Democratic Front, Mohali, who has frequented the village as a booth-level officer (BLO), says she has seen a significant shift. For one, the village has a number of working women. While educated women find jobs in nearby Mohali, Dalit women work in colleges and households as helpers and cooks.

"There are households in which I see a reversal of roles, with the husband staying home to look after the animals and the women working outside," he says. More importantly, he adds, women are increasingly taking decisions about their children's education.

Women played an important role in the 2022 elections, when their turnout was close to that of men at the state level. In parts of Doaba, women even outnumbered men at the polling booths. Yet political representation has not kept pace, even though the

state provides 50% reservation for women in panchayat seats, raised from one-third to 50% in March 2018 under the then Congress government led by Amarinder Singh.

The AAP government later removed the practice of "sar-panch patis" by mandating that women themselves attend all official meetings. Punjab has had only one woman chief minister, Rajinder Kaur Bhattal, and elected 13 women MLAs in 2022, 11 of them from AAP. This was double the number in the 2017 polls. The highest number of 14 women legislators were elected in 2012. At present, the state has one woman minister.

Salamati shrugs off these numbers. "We should instead look at how they vote. Earlier they would follow the dictat of the men, now they will vote the way they want."

In the end, that is the quieter revolution. The ballot is still secret. The woman casting it is not.

Manraj Grewal Sharma is National Editor, North, *The Indian Express*

Jaishankar: Attacks on seafarers are indefensible

Press Trust of India
United Nations,
September 25

INDIA ON Friday said that repeated attacks on seafarers that disrupt maritime commerce and cost innocent lives are “indefensible” and “unacceptable”, as Delhi launched a landmark maritime initiative with Liberia focused on safety and security of sea personnel and shipping.

“From the Black Sea to the Red Sea to the Gulf, attacks on civilian shipping have become a growing cause of concern. These actions that disrupt maritime commerce and cost innocent lives are simply indefensible. We are here to not just highlight this dangerous trend, but to urge the international community to close ranks and deter such attacks,” External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said.

Jaishankar, along with Liberia’s Minister for Foreign Affairs Sara Beysolow Nyanti, launched the ‘Group of Friends on Safety & Security of Shipping & Seafarers’ here on the margins of the high-level UN General Assembly session.

India and Liberia will serve as co-chairs of the Group of Friends, which would focus on various aspects of maritime trade, safety, and security. As an inclusive platform, Jaishankar said the endeavour has been to bring all relevant stakeholders together.

The group consists of major ship-owning member states, countries with the largest number of ship registries, and those that provide the maximum numbers to seafaring.

Addressing the inaugural meeting of the group, Jaishankar listed recent attacks against maritime vessels and seafarers that resulted in the death of Indian shipping personnel as well as damage to the containers.

He said that just two days ago, an Antigua and Barbuda-flagged bulk carrier MV Cape



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar

Dao was attacked in the Gulf of Oman, in which an Indian sailor lost his life.

Earlier, a Panama-flagged oil tanker El Gaia was struck while transiting the Strait of Hormuz. An Indian crew member went missing after that incident.

“These, regrettably, are no longer exceptional occurrences,” Jaishankar said.

Given that India is a major source country for seafarers and Liberia hosts the largest shipping registry by tonnage, the two countries have joined hands on the initiative aimed at drawing greater global attention to issues pertaining to the seafarers and the commercial shipping industry.

Jaishankar noted that nearly two million seafarers operate the world’s merchant fleet, “often navigating choppy waters, both literally and metaphorically”.

With maritime shipping accounting for four-fifths of the global trade of USD 35 trillion last year, Jaishankar emphasised that the group will be an “inclusive, voluntary, and action-oriented platform aimed at deepening cooperation among member states and other stakeholders.”

“It will promote exchange of views, sharing of experiences and practical cooperation, complement and strengthen the existing international frameworks, mandates, and instruments in these areas,” he said.

Seafarer killed in missile strike joined ship one month ago

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 25

AROUND 1 PM on Wednesday, Suraj Yadav made a video call to his family from the commercial ship he was working on, excited to show them what life on board was like.

The 22-year-old proudly showed them around the vessel — which was sailing off Oman’s eastern coast on its way back to India — pointing out where he worked and slept and the food he was served on board.

Thirty minutes later, a missile struck the ship near the Strait of Hormuz. Suraj was killed. His family, in Uttar Pradesh’s Deoria, received the devastating news of his death hours later.

“Everyone in the house was thrilled to see the ship. Suraj was the first person from our family, and indeed the whole village, to ever travel on a commercial vessel. Our neighbours had gathered too, watching as he showed us around,” said Suraj’s uncle, Awadhesh Yadav. “We were stunned to learn that the incident had occurred just after our call ended.”

Awadhesh said senior officials from the Mumbai-based shipping company broke the news to the family.

“They said on Wednesday, around 1.30 pm, the ship’s staff were alerted to an incoming missile, following which they jumped into the sea. There were 28 people aboard the ship. A portion of the vessel was damaged in the blast and the debris struck Suraj’s head, killing him.”

Suraj’s father, Om Prakash Yadav, has been working in Kuwait for the past three months. Suraj was the eldest of three



Suraj Yadav

brothers and was unmarried. His two younger brothers, aged 12 and 9, live with their mother in Karmajeetpur village.

The family said Suraj had joined the ship on August 19. “He joined the ship from Oman last month, and from there, travelled to Dubai and Berlin. The ship was heading to Surat when the incident occurred,” Awadhesh said.

The family is making efforts to bring his body back home. The Indian Embassy in Oman said the merchant vessel, MV Cape Dao, came under attack while transiting towards India on Wednesday.

Union Ports, Shipping and Waterways Minister Sarbajit Sonowal said all surviving crew members, including the 19 Indian nationals, have been safely evacuated.

In June, another seafarer from Deoria, Shivanand Chaurasia, was killed in an attack on a tanker off the Oman coast.

Following repeated attacks on merchant vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, a high-level review chaired by Sonowal launched the ‘Seafarer-First’ initiative to protect Indian sailors in conflict zones like the Strait of Hormuz.

Case against CMO staff for revealing Jamui victim’s identity

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 25

FOLLOWING OUTRAGE over a photo of the Jamui harassment victim and her family shared on the official X handle of Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, the Patna Police registered a case against employees of the CM’s office on Friday.

Though the picture, which shows the CM meeting the girl and three of her family members, was removed after a few minutes of being posted, it was enough for the Opposition to seize upon the issue.

Sharing a screenshot of the alleged post, RJD national working president Tejashwi Yadav wrote that the CM was “violating the POCSO Act” by publishing a photograph of the minor victim with her family.

On Friday evening, RJD Lok Sabha MP Misa Bharti said she has sought registration of a case against the CM under Section 23 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, and Section 74 of the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015, over the alleged disclosure of the minor’s identity.

She alleged that “the station house officer refused to register the FIR”.

“The case was registered after the police received information that a photograph of the victim’s family had been uploaded on X,” the social media cell of the Patna Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) said in a statement.

The police said an investigation had begun and that the matter would be examined impartially and in accordance with law.

It was not immediately clear as to which employees have been named in the FIR and the charges against them.

The post shared by CM Choudhary on Thursday had stated, “Met the victim girl from Jamui and her family at Loksevak Awas... assured the family of speedy justice.”

Arunachal’s Subansiri Upper hydel project gets panel nod

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, September 25

EVEN AS it expressed concern over the felling of a “substantial” number of trees for the Subansiri Upper Hydroelectric Project (SUHEP), an Expert Appraisal Committee (EAC) of the Environment Ministry recommended environmental clearance for the run-of-the-river project on Subansiri basin in Arunachal Pradesh.

The final environmental clearance, however, will be subject to a Stage-1 forest clearance (an in-principle approval given by the Centre under the Forest Conservation Act), as the project requires the diversion of 2,733 hectares of forest land and the felling of approximately 1,35,733 trees, as per the minutes of the EAC meeting.

The EAC observed that the proposed tree felling may have implications for forest structure, habitat continuity, biodiversity, wildlife movement and associated ecosystem services, the minutes show.

It also advised National Hydroelectric Power Corporation Limited (NHPC), the project proponent, to formulate a comprehensive, site-specific and timebound Ecosystem Restoration and Biodiversity Management Plan.

Even though the forest clearance proposal remains under scrutiny, compensatory afforestation has also been proposed across as many as 14 districts of Madhya Pradesh.

Normally, when forest land is diverted for non-forest purposes, an equivalent patch of non-forest land must be found locally for afforestation.

Since Arunachal Pradesh already has a high forest cover, specific guidelines by the Environment Ministry allow it to fulfill their compensatory afforestation obligations on non-forest land in other states which have lower forest cover.

However, the FCA says that if no equivalent non-forest land is available, then a plantation twice the size of the diverted forest land has to be raised on degraded land. In the SUHEP case, about 5,466 hectares of degraded forest land in Madhya Pradesh has been identified for compensatory afforestation, documents related to the project reveal.

Incidentally, until February 2026, Arunachal Pradesh had not complied with compensatory afforestation conditions for the Subansiri Lower project, also implemented by NHPC downstream, and the Environment Ministry had sent six reminders about it, *The Indian Express* had reported in February.

While appraising the SUHEP, the EAC noted the Supreme Court’s August 2009 di-

rective that “any proposal on the upper stream of the Subansiri River would be considered independently on its own merit by the Standing Committee as and when submitted by the proponents.”

Earlier, the standing committee of the National Board for Wildlife had given a wildlife nod for the Subansiri Lower project on the condition that there would be no upstream projects in the future. However, the SC modified this condition based on a plea by the Arunachal Pradesh government.

The EAC also noted that the water discharge due to glacial lake outburst flood was assessed, along with peak flood discharge and scenarios of impact of dam breach on the downstream Subansiri Lower hydel project, as per the minutes of the meeting.

Power generation and flood moderation are the two stated objectives of the 1,605 MW plant, planned near Menga. It envisages the construction of a 237m-high storage dam.

PUBLIC NOTICE

APPLICATION FOR REGISTRATION OF THE RESIDENTIAL PLOTTED COLONY UNDER NILP POLICY-2022 NAMEDLY "4S ESTATE"

SITUATED IN SECTOR- 88B, VILLAGE HARSARU, GURUGRAM SUBMITTED

IN THE HARYANA REAL ESTATE REGULATORY AUTHORITY, GURUGRAM BY M/S/ NEEM SECURE PVT. LTD.

It is for the information of the public in general and allottees of license no. 09 of 2022 dated 31.01.2022 and 61 of 2023 dated 27.03.2023, if any, that M/s Neem Secure Pvt. Ltd. has applied for the registration of its project, "4S Estate" under Section 4 of the Act of 2016 in the Authority over an area measuring 10.075 acres under License no. 109 of 2026 dated 02.06.2026.

The Department of Town and Country Planning, Haryana has granted license no. 109 of 2026 dated 02.06.2026 in favour of M/s Neem Secure Pvt. Ltd. for Residential Plotted Colony under NILP Policy-2022 over an area measuring 10.075 acres after migration from license no. 09 of 2022 dated 31.01.2022 & 61 of 2023 dated 27.03.2023 granted for affordable group housing colony valid upto 01.06.2031.

It is also informed that license no. 09 of 2022 dated 31.01.2022 was granted by DTCP, Haryana in favour of Blossom Properties Pvt. Ltd., Mendell Developers Pvt. Ltd., Vaibhav Warehouse Pvt. Ltd., Vatika Ltd., Feldon Developers Pvt. Ltd., Ignacio Developers Pvt. Ltd. in collaboration with Vatika Ltd. for an affordable group housing colony for an area measuring 6.675 acres (part migration of 6.675 acres from license no. 94 of 2013 dated 31.10.2013 for residential plotted colony over an area measuring 100.88 acres) valid upto 30.01.2027. Further, the permission of change of developer from Vatika Ltd. to Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. was granted vide DTCP, office endst. No. LC-4527/Asstt. (MS)/2022/8977 dated 01.04.2022.

Afterwards the same has been registered with the Authority vide RC No. 51 of 2023 dated 03.04.2023 for the project namedly "Mahira Homes 88B".

Further, the promoter has obtained an additional license no. 61 of 2023 dated 27.03.2023 by DTCP, Haryana in favour of Bacon Developers Pvt. Ltd. in collaboration with Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. for affordable group housing colony over an additional area measuring 3.403 acres (in addition to License no. 09 of 2022 dated 31.01.2022).

In addition to above, license no. 09 of 2022 for an area measuring 6.675 acres wherein the said license was changed from Vatika Ltd. to Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. and further license no. 61 of 2023 in contiguous to license no. 09 of 2022 was also granted to Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. for an area measuring 3.4 acres, **thus total area of colony becomes 10.075 acres has been transferred by Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. in favour of Neem Secure Pvt. Ltd. and permission for change of developer was granted by DTCP, Haryana from Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd. to Neem Secure Pvt. Ltd. in respect of the aforesaid licenses vide Memo no. LC-4527/IE(51)/2025/10852 dated 02.04.2026.**

Now, the Directorate of Town and Country Planning, Haryana, has approved the Layout plan for a Residential Plotted Colony under NILP Policy-2022 over an area measuring 10.075 acres in Sector 88B, Village Harsaru, Gurugram, vide no. DTCP-12448 dated 03.06.2026.

Meanwhile, the promoter has submitted an affidavit sworn by the Managing Director of Mahira Homes Pvt. Ltd., Blossom Properties Pvt. Ltd., Mendell Developers Pvt. Ltd., Vaibhav Warehouse Pvt. Ltd., Vatika Ltd., Feldon Developers Pvt. Ltd., Ignacio Developers Pvt. Ltd. and Bacon Developers Pvt. Ltd. in respect of License Nos. 09 of 2022 dated 31.01.2022 and 61 of 2023 dated 27.03.2023. With regard to License No. 09 of 2022, the affidavit states that post obtaining the HARERA registration certificate, no sale, advertisement or creation of any third-party rights in respect of the said land/project has been undertaken. Further, in respect of License No. 61 of 2023, it has been stated that no sale, advertisement, or creation of any third-party rights in respect of the said land/project has been undertaken, and no HARERA registration certificate has been obtained for the said project.

The promoter has now approached the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram, for the registration of the project namedly "4S Estate" over an area measuring 10.075 acres on dated 11.08.2026.

The relevant application and related details and documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours up to 09.10.2026 from 11:00 am to 4:00 pm. Also, if anyone wishes to appear, may appear before the Authority on 14.10.2026 at 11:00 am during the hearing.

Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Secretary,
Haryana Real Estate Regulatory
Authority, Gurugram

Dated: 26.09.2026

18 police officers and personnel booked for parading, assault of accused in Pune

Express News Service
Pune, September 25

TWO FIRS have been registered against police officers and personnel of the Bharati Vidyapeeth Police Station in Pune following a fact-finding inquiry by the Maharashtra State Human Rights Commission (MSHRC) into allegations of custodial assault and public humiliation of suspects, including minors, in July.

A total of 18 police officers and personnel have been booked in the two cases — 13 in one and 11 in the other — with some being common to both. Senior Inspector Mansingh Patil, who was in-charge of the Bharati Vidyapeeth Police Station at the time, has been named as an accused in both the cases.

The first FIR concerns four accused in an assault case, while the second relates to eight Children in Conflict with Law, accused of another minor’s murder. The second FIR also invokes provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

The FIRs were registered on a complaint filed by Deputy Superintendent of Police Sanket Gosavi, based on findings of the MSHRC. The panel initiated suo motu inquiry after videos of the two alleged incidents surfaced on social media.

The first FIR alleges that four accused were assaulted at the Bharati Vidyapeeth Police Station, then taken to a Slum Rehabilitation Authority (SRA) colony on July 7, where they were allegedly made to kneel and walk on the road, beaten on their legs with sticks and lathis, made to sit on their knees and hold out their hands, apologise to local residents and subjected to public humiliation. The FIR also records that there was no corresponding general diary entry or police vehicle log-book entry regarding the SRA colony visit.

Among the 13 police personnel named in this case are Senior Inspectors Mansingh Patil, and sub-inspectors Anna Darade and Nilesh Mokashi. They are facing charges of causing hurt, wrongful restraint or confine-

ment, assault or criminal force, intentional insult, criminal intimidation and public servants disobeying law.

According to the second FIR, four minors were taken into custody at Ambegaon Pathar police chowki on July 20, three more on July 21 and an eighth around midnight on July 21-22. They were accused of murdering another minor.

The FIR alleges that the accused minors were kept in police custody for periods extending beyond the permissible period. The FIR also alleges that three of the minors were made to sit on the bonnet of a police vehicle, tied with a rope, beaten up and paraded on a public road, with another minor inside the vehicle. The FIR notes that four of the minors belong to SC category.

The 11 police personnel named in the case include Mansingh Patil, assistant inspectors Ganesh Mohite and Snehal Thorat, three head constables, and five others. Apart from provisions of the BNS, the SC/ST Act and the Juvenile Justice Act have been invoked.

The MSHRC had taken up the two incidents suo motu in August, saying that they reveal “a shocking story of extreme brutality of Pune Police by blatantly projecting to the public at large that constitutional provisions including fundamental right to life conferred by the Constitution of India has no value in functioning of the Pune Police Department”. Subsequently, Mansingh Patil was transferred to the Special Branch of the Pune Police.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* at the time, Patil had defended the decision to parade the minors saying the police action had helped defuse public frustration that “police do not do anything when accused are minors”. “I decided that something had to be done,” he said. “For the satisfaction of the people, we had to go beyond the law.”

Four dead after SUV rams into truck in Gujarat

Surat: Four Mumbai residents died in a road accident in Gujarat after an SUV they were travelling in rammed a stationary dumper truck on the outskirts of Surat on Friday. The accident took place at Kamrej on the Vadodara-Mumbai Expressway.

The group were headed to the Shankeshwar Jain temple, a major pilgrimage centre for the Jain community. Police sources said the incident took place at 8 am on Friday. The dumper truck driver had parked his vehicle on the left land, reportedly due to a flat tire. ENS

EXPRESS

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Banaras Hindu University invites Online applications in prescribed format from Indian citizens for appointment to Scientific/Technical and Non-Teaching posts under various ICAR-AICRP Projects on as per standard terms of Govt of India Krishi Vigyan Kendra(KVK), RGSC, Barkachha, Mirzapur.

Last date for online submission of application form is **22.10.2026** upto 5:00 p.m.(IST). The downloaded application form along with supporting documents should reach to the Office of the Registrar, Recruitment & Assessment Cell, Holkar House, BHU, Varanasi-221005 on or before **27.10.2026** upto 5:00 p.m.(IST).

For details of qualifications and other instructions, please visit the University website: <http://www.bhu.ac.in/rac>

Date: 19.09.2026

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DIP/Shabdarth/Display/097/26-27

MP revives public bus network 21 years after winding it up

Express News Service Bhopal, September 25

AFTER 21 YEARS, Madhya Pradesh on Friday formally brought back a state-backed public bus network, with Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari using the launch to push for safer buses, stricter enforcement, and a much larger shift to electric public transport.

“Manufacturers need to be clearly told to pull up their socks,” Gadkari said.

“If bus manufacturers do not meet the desired standards, they will be dealt with in the same manner by the government as we are dealing with contractors.”

Gadkari, along with Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, flagged off 351 buses under the newly launched Mukhyamantri Sugam Parivahan Sewa and the Centre’s PM e-Bus Sewa at the BHEL Dussehra Ground in Bhopal.

SC notice to Goa on Tejpal appeal against his rape conviction

Express News Service New Delhi, September 25

THE SUPREME Court on Friday issued notice to the Goa government on *Tejhelka* magazine’s former editor-in-chief Tarun Tejpal’s appeal challenging his conviction and sentencing for the 2013 rape of a woman journalist.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and P B Varale issued notice on Tejpal’s plea against the August 6 ruling of the Bombay High Court in Goa, which convicted and sentenced him to 10 years’ rigorous imprisonment.

Appearing for Tejpal, senior advocate Kapil Sibal said that it is a case of reversal of sentence and there is a right of appeal. He pointed out that Tejpal had surrendered following the sentencing. The senior counsel urged the Supreme Court to hear his case for bail.

Tejpal had earlier urged the top court to exempt him from

surrendering. However, the court rejected the request and said that it will take up the appeal once he surrenders.

The Goa government too has approached the Supreme Court, seeking enhancement of the sentence awarded to him.

The case dates back to November 2013, when Tejpal allegedly assaulted the journalist on two separate occasions in a Goa hotel while the two were alone during a literary festival. She confided in colleagues the same night and, a week later, emailed a complaint to *Tejhelka*’s managing editor seeking an apology and an internal inquiry.

Tejpal responded with two apology emails before the matter became public and an FIR was registered. He was tried on charges including ‘rape by a person in a position of trust and dominance’, along with assault, sexual harassment, wrongful restraint, and confinement.

In May 2021, he was acquitted by an additional sessions court in Mapusa. The Goa government appealed to the high court, which on August 6 convicted him for aggravated rape and related offences.

Dalit murdered in Rajkot, police probe inter-caste marriage angle

Express News Service Ahmedabad, September 25

A DALIT man was murdered in Rajkot on Thursday, allegedly by his brother-in-law, with police saying that the crime may be a fallout of his marrying the sister of the accused, who belongs to a different caste.

Police identified the victim as Vimal Dharmendra Vaniya. Vimal was allegedly assaulted by three men including his brother-in-law Kamlesh alias Kano Lakha Dhandal, when he was with a friend at Bhaktinagar circle around 2pm on Thursday. He was stabbed several times and was declared dead at Rajkot Civil Hospital, police said.

The police suspect that Vimal, who belonged to a Scheduled Caste, was murdered by Dhandhal and his friends for marrying Dhandhal’s sister. The inter-caste couple have a child together.

Inspector J D Parmar of Bhaktinagar police station told *The Indian Express* that Vimal and the woman had eloped over seven years ago and at that time, her family soon traced them and took her back home. Later on, she again left home and joined Vimal, eventually settling together in several different towns before returning to stay with his mother and stepfather in Rajkot.

Dhandhal and two unidentified persons were booked for murder as well as sections of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

TN: SIT to probe POCSCO case against R Veeramani

Arun Janardhanan Chennai, September 25

TAMIL NADU police have constituted a four-member Special Investigation Team to investigate the POCSCO case against granite businessman R Veeramani and “related matters”.

The SIT, constituted by Director General of Police Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal on September 24, will comprise Additional Commissioner of Police P C Thenmozhi, Joint Commissioner Disha Mittal, Superintendent of Police J Mutharasi and Deputy Commissioner V V Geethanjali. It will work under Chennai Police Commissioner A Amalraj.

The development comes as M P Ranjan Kumar, president of the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee’s Scheduled Caste wing, has shared a detailed account of how he claims to have first encountered an objectionable video involving Veeramani. The account refers to a dispute involving Veeramani, his associate Shanthi and her husband Mahendra Simhan before the police formally registered the POCSCO case in October 2025.

Kumar said his acquaintance with Shanthi began over an unrelated real-estate discussion in June 2024. Months later, he claimed, she asked him to arrange a meeting with Tamizhaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam leader John Pandian over a financial dispute.

Kumar claimed the three subsequently met at a hotel in Nungambakkam, where he



R Veeramani

witnessed a heated exchange between Shanthi and Pandian involving money and references to a video.

Pandian, however, disputed Kumar’s version of that encounter and said, “Ranjan came to see me after getting an appointment through a political leader. He was the one who brought Shanthi to the hotel.” According to Pandian, the two asked him to help obtain Rs 20 crore from Veeramani.

“I told them, ‘I don’t do this kind of work. This is unnecessary. Go and see him yourselves. I will not interfere’,” Pandian claimed, adding that he neither met nor spoke to them afterwards.

Kumar denied asking Pandian for money. His account instead places the origins of the video in a dispute within Shanthi’s household. Kumar claimed Shanthi told him that she had not recorded the footage deliberately. He claimed Shanthi told him that her husband had installed a concealed camera because he suspected the nature of her relationship with Veeramani, and the camera instead captured Veeramani allegedly entering with a minor girl.

Police have not publicly established the circumstances in which the recording was made.

Kumar claimed Shanthi and her husband then left him

alone in a room and played a clip on a television. “I saw an elderly-looking man removing his clothes, giving a gift box to a girl who appeared to be 15 or 16, and touching her inappropriately,” Kumar claimed. “Immediately recorded the video on my phone.”

He claimed he confronted Shanthi and left, consulted lawyers and decided to approach the police. Kumar said he signed a written complaint on November 21, 2024, and the following day met then Additional Commissioner of Police N Kannan at the Chennai Police Commissionerate, submitting the complaint along with screenshots.

“After 10 or 15 days, AVS Inspector Mahesh contacted me,” Kumar said. “Whenever he asked me for information, I provided it.”

He claimed that in December 2024, at the inspector’s request, he sent the video clip through WhatsApp for further inquiry. But according to Kumar, police repeatedly told him in the following months that an arrest could not be made without identifying a survivor. “From the day I gave the complaint until the end, I clearly told them that I did not know any of the victims,” he said.

Kumar’s claim has assumed greater significance because the POCSCO case was formally registered only in October 2025, after a child-rights activist approached police with a pen drive containing a video. Kannan has separately confirmed receiving Kumar’s earlier complaint and said he escalated it to then Chennai Police Commissioner A Arun.

Meanwhile, on Thursday night, the Tamil Nadu government placed senior IPS officers Arun and Kannan on compulsory wait.

Anti-goonda Bill not returned, still under consideration, says Bengal CM

Atri Mitra Kolkata, September 25

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday denied reports, including in this newspaper, that President Droupadi Murmu had returned the anti-goonda Bill to the state government for reconsideration, and said the proposed legislation is currently “under consideration” of the Union Home Ministry.

Accompanied by senior bureaucrats at a press conference, Adhikari said the Bill is “completely crystal clear” and that he is hopeful it will receive the President’s assent.

The West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-Social Activities Bill, 2026, or the anti-goonda Bill, was passed in the Assembly in June, substantially expanding the state’s powers to tackle organised crime, extortion, illegal mining, cybercrime and public disorder.

“We constituted this Act within the provisions of Article 254(2) of Schedule VII of the Constitution of India, and we are confident that we will get the assent of the President,” he said.

“We sent this Bill to the Home Ministry because one section has a provision of three years of imprisonment in the NDPS Act, but it is bailable, and we want to make it non-bailable. As per our knowledge, the Bill is now at the joint secretary-level of the Home Ministry. They did not ask for any clarification,” he said.

“When Andhra Pradesh and Kerala brought such a law, they too needed to get concurrence from the President of India, and they did. We will also get it,” he said, calling reports of the President returning the Bill “baseless”. “Those who are showing joy know they are criminals, and they are posting that this is a setback for the government. This is baseless,” he said.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Invitation of Tenders through E-procurement system (Corrigendum)

Principal chief materials manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001 for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for the following items.

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing time
01	82265067A	Pediatric Patient Simulator (As per attached Revised Specification)	01 No	13.10.2026

Note: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 82265067A Date: 25.09.2026 3331/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile

IRCON INTERNATIONAL LIMITED
NAVRATNA COMPANY
(A Govt. of India Undertaking)
Website : www.ircon.org, CIN : L45203DL1975GOI008171

e-Tender Notice
e-Tender No.: IRCON/MECH/P&E/MAHSR-T2/Slab Wagons/07 Date: 25.09.2026
e-Tender for and on behalf of IRCON INTERNATIONAL LIMITED is invited from bidders meeting qualifying requirements for the work of “Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of 44 Nos. Track Slab Carriage Wagons (10T capacity) for MAHSR-T2 Project.”
Last Date & Time of e-Bid Submission 05.10.2026 15:00 Hrs.
For further details, visit website <https://etenders.gov.in/eprocure/app>. Corrigendum, if any, would be hosted only on the website.
Executive Director/Infra C-4, District Centre, Saket, New Delhi-110017

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
For and on behalf of President of India, Sr.CDO, Santragachi, South Eastern Railway, Kharagpur Division invites an open tender through e-tendering in www.ireps.gov.in website as per details mentioned below. Eligible tenderers are requested to apply for the same through online only in website as per details mentioned below. No offline tender will be accepted. Please read the tender document uploaded in the document section for details. **Tender Notice No.: SRC-C-PIPELINE-DT-230926; Name of the Work:** Santragachi: Provision of compressed pneumatic pipe line with quick coupling arrangement of 4 km length with ancillary work at santragachi coaching depot. **Tender Value :** ₹1,00,73,772.80/- **EMD:** ₹2,01,500/- **Closing Date of Tender :** 15.10.2026 at 11:30 hrs. **Cost of tender document:** ₹0/- (Zero). **(PR-811)**

The English and Foreign Languages University
(A CENTRAL UNIVERSITY ESTABLISHED BY AN ACT OF PARLIAMENT)
HYDERABAD-500007

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) FOR EMPANELMENT OF LIBRARY VENDORS/SUPPLIERS
Ramesh Mohan Library, The English and Foreign Languages University (EFLU), Hyderabad 500007, invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from reputed vendors and suppliers for empanelment for supply of Print Books, E-Books and Journal Resources. Interested vendors may visit the official website of EFL University at <https://www.efluniversity.ac.in/> for detailed EOI, eligibility criteria and submission guidelines.
Last date to apply - One month from the date of advertisement.
Date:26.09.2026 Sd/ REGISTRAR

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
गंगा नहर संचालन मण्डल, सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग,
पल्लवपुरम फेस-1, मेरठ

अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-03/एसओई/2026-27

महामहिम राज्यपाल, उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु ऑनलाइन निविदायें (<https://etender.up.nic.in>) सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश में वगीकृत श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक: 06.10.2026 को अपराह्न 02:00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टेक्निकल बिड कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, गंगा नहर संचालन मण्डल, पल्लवपुरम फेस-1, मेरठ के कार्यालय कक्ष में गठित समिति के सदस्यों द्वारा दिनांक: 06.10.2026 को अपराह्न 02:30 बजे खोली जायेगी। प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टेक्निकल बिड में क्वालिफाइड पाये गये ठेकेदारों की ही फाइनलिस्टेशन बिड खोली जायेगी। कार्यालय बन्द होने अथवा अवकाश होने की दशा में यह निविदायें आगले कार्य दिवस में उसी समय खोली जायेगी। निविदा दिनांक: 30.09.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे से दिनांक: 06.10.2026 को अपराह्न 02:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती है। कार्यों का विवरण निम्नवत है:-

क्र० सं०	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत (जि.एस.टी. रहित (लाख ₹० में)	धरोहर राशि (लाख ₹० में)	कार्य को पूर्ण करने की अवधि	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (₹० में)	पंजीकृत श्रेणी	सम्बन्धित अधिशासी अभियन्ता का पता
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	जनपद हरिद्वार में ऊपरी गंगा नहर के दाहिने किनारे पर निम्नित सेवा मार्ग के कि०मी० 22.840 से कि०मी० 31.900 के मध्य नवीनीकरण का कार्य।	165.59	3.32	45 दिवस	₹० 3500.00 + 18% GST	'B' स्तर एवं उच्च	उत्तरी खण्ड गंगा नहर, रुड़की
2	जनपद हरिद्वार में समानान्तर ऊपरी गंगा नहर के दाहिने किनारे पर कि०मी० 8.220 से कि०मी० 11.160 के मध्य पूर्वनिर्मित क्षतिग्रस्त सेवामार्ग के पुनर्निर्माण का कार्य।	38.14	0.77	45 दिवस	₹० 3500.00 + 18% GST	'बी' स्तर एवं उच्च	

नोट :- उपलब्ध धन से तत्समय कार्य की महत्ता के अनुसार कार्य सम्पादित करवाया जायेगा एवं कार्यों का विस्तृत विवरण बी०ओ०न्यू में संलग्न है।

भारतेन्दु गौड़
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
गंगा नहर संचालन मण्डल, मेरठ

UPID-256940 Date 24/09/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

Office of Superintending Engineer
Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr
E - Procurement Inviting Tender Notice

No. 9224/96M/E-TENDER-BSR CIRCLE/2026-27 Dated: 14.09.2026

1. On behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh, Superintending Engineer Bulandshahr Circle, U.P.P.W.D., Bulandshahr invites following tenders of percentage rate bid online through <http://etender.up.nic.in> from the eligible and registered in Bridge Works Category (A/B Class) Firm/Contractors in the UP PWD, from dt. **05.09.2026 to 15.10.2026 up to 12.00 P.M.** as per the prescribed T-2. The technical bids will be opened online on dated 15.10.2026 at 12:30 P.M. If the office happens to be closed on the date of opening of the bids as specified, the bids will be opened online on the next working day respectively, at the same time and validity of bid will be considered from the original date. The date and time of opening of the financial bid shall be notified on the website.

2. Details of Work-

Sl. No	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs. in Lac)	Bid Security (Rs. in Lacs)	Tender document fee including GST	Work Completion Months	Add. Of Executive Engineer	Add. Of Superintending Engineer	Add. Of Chief Engineer	Contractors Category
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1	Construction of Minor Bridge over Ganda Nala Bridge in Ahmapur Naya Gaon	109.25	7.46	Tender Cost-Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	06 Months	E.E., P.D., Hapur	S.E., BSR Circle, Bulandshahr	C.E., M.Z., Meerut	A (Bridge Work)

3. The Bid Security and Tender Document Fee must be deposit through Internet Banking.

4. For the above works, it is mandatory to carry out maintenance work for 02 years from the date of completion of the work.

5. The determination of experience regarding the construction of minor bridges, the renovation and repair of major/minor bridges, and the construction of RCC box culverts in the Public Works Department shall be governed by the instructions mentioned in the Circular No.-6410MT/Gen. Cat./60MT-1/2025, Dated-17.12.2025, issued by the Office of the Engineer-in-Chief (Dev.) and H.O.D., PWD, U.P., Lucknow.

6. All registered contractors have to upload Turnover certified by C.A. of last 5 Year and details of maximum cost work satisfactorily completed in last 5 Years on Chanakya software before Submission of tender.

7. Details of e-tender uploaded on <https://etender.up.nic.in> shall also be uploaded on UPPWD Chanakya software, before last date & time of submission of bid.

8. Bidder has to upload required documents as per Government order No. 879(1)/23-7-2020 P.W. Anubhag-7 Lucknow Dt. 25.08.2020 for “Prahari Application” in Chanakya Software by accessing hyperlink available on <http://roc.uppwd.gov.in> for Tendering Process

9. Terms & Conditions related to bids are available on <https://etender.up.nic.in>

10. In PWD technical evaluation of tenders is to be done by Prahari Software URL <http://vms.uppwd.gov.in/Prahari/>

11. The additional performance security must be deposited as per the provisions contained in G.O. No. 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 dated 23.05.2026.

(Maneesh Verma)
Superintending Engineer
Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D.
Bulandshahr

UPID-256950 Dt. 24.09.2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

बिहार सरकार

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता (यांत्रिक) का कार्यालय
सिंचाई यांत्रिक प्रमंडल मोहनियाँ
(Email: imd.mohania@gmail.com)
शुद्धि पत्र

प्रमंडलीय कार्यालय द्वारा विज्ञापित कार्य (विश्वकर्मा पंप केमाल परियोजना के जीर्णोद्धार कार्य) हेतु पत्रांक 726 दिनांक 16.09.2026 द्वारा आमंत्रित ई० कोटेशन आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-10/2026-27 जिसका PR No.:012038(W R D) 2026-27 है, को अपरिहार्य कारणों से निम्नवत् संशोधित किया जाता है-

1. प्राकृतिक राशि (लाख ₹० में) को 2994.40629 (Tentative) के स्थान पर 2979.43426 पड़ा एवं समझा जाए।

2. अग्रघन की राशि (₹० में) को ₹ 2995000.00 (FIXED) के स्थान पर ₹ 39,80,000.00 पड़ा एवं समझा जाए।

3. उक्त कोटेशन आमंत्रण सूचना की कटिंक संख्या-32 (Point No.32 -MSME पंजीकरण की अनिवार्यता) को तत्काल प्रभाव से विलोपित किया जाता है।
शेष नियम एवं शर्तें यथावत रहेंगी।

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता (याँ०) सिंचाई यांत्रिक प्रमंडल, मोहनियाँ गौ० 91-8285653609

PR- 012557 (W R D) 2026-27
नरो की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

Govt. of Bihar
Patna Smart City Limited (PSCL)
NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER FOR
Selection of Concessionaire for Operation, Maintenance, Commercial Management & Revenue Enhancement of newly developed Facilities at Maurya Lok Complex, Patna under Patna Smart City Limited.
(Through e-procurement mode only- www.eproc2bihar.gov.in)

NIT No. – 19/MD/PSCL/2026-27

Patna Smart City Limited (PSCL) invites bids from eligible experienced Firms/ /Contractors / Agencies / Bidders registered in appropriate category in any Government Organization/PSUs for execution of works as given below:-

Name of Work	Bid Document (Non-Refundable)	Bid Security (EMD)	Bid Processing Fee
Selection of Concessionaire for Operation, Maintenance, Commercial Management & Revenue Enhancement of newly developed Facilities at Maurya Lok Complex, Patna under Patna Smart City Limited.	Rs. 11,800/-	As per RFP	As per Eproc2 website.
2. Date of Downloading of Bid Document	: From 21.09.2026 to 12.10.2026 up to 1500 hours. Through website : www.eproc2bihar.gov.in		
3. Place & Date of pre-bid meeting	: Date: 30.09.2026, Time 1600 hours; Patna Smart City Limited, 4th Floor, ICC - cum - PSCL Building, SSP Office Campus, Gandhi Maidan, Patna-800001		
4. Last date of Receiving Queries (Online)	: Date: 30.09.2026, Time 1700 hours (through e-mail)		
5. Last Date and time for uploading of bid.	: Date: 12.10.2026 up to 1500 hours through website - www.eproc2bihar.gov.in		
6. Time & Date of opening technical bids	: Date: 13.10.2026, Time 1000 hours		
7. Time & date of opening financial bids	: To be communicated later on		
8. Place of opening of Bid	: Through website : www.eproc2bihar.gov.in		
9. Periods of bids validity	: 120 Days.		
10. Officer inviting bids	: Managing Director, PSCL, Patna.		
11. For participation in E-tendering proc. the contractor shall have to get themselves registered to get User ID, Password & digital signature. This will enable accessing the website www.eproc2bihar.gov.in & download/participate in E-tender.			
12. The tender documents can be obtained through our website www.eproc2bihar.gov.in & http://www.smartpatna.co.in .			
17. Estimate amount may vary. So EMD will be deposited as per technical Sheet uploaded on the website www.eproc2bihar.gov.in			
18. For queries & Clarifications, if any, send e-mail to patnasmartcity.psc@gmail.com .			

For further details please visit website state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
PR- 012538 (B & C) 2026-27
नरो की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

Managing Director
Patna Smart City Limited

GOVERNMENT OF ANDHRA PRADESH
A P STATE DISASTER MANAGEMENT AUTHORITY (APSDMA)
REVENUE (DM) DEPARTMENT

Ref: NIT No.1/YAMS/SDMA/2024(3rd Call) dtd: 25.09.2026

The Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority (APSDMA) invites short notice tenders for the procurement of Emergency Responder Kits (ERKS) for Yuva Aapdamitra Volunteers in the State under the YAMS Scheme of NDMA.

The Bids can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal (<https://tender.aeprocurement.gov.in>) from **28.9.2026** For further details please refer to AP e-procurement portal. If any corrigendum in this regard will be published on the above AP e-procurement portal only.

No : 5461PP/ Dt.: 25.09.2026 Sd/- Managing Director, APSDMA

ଓଡ଼ିଶା ବିଦ୍ୟୁତ୍ ଶକ୍ତି ସଂଚାରଣ ନିଗମ ଲିମିଟେଡ୍
(ଓଡ଼ିଶା ସରକାରଙ୍କ ଏକ ଉପକ୍ରମ)
Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007

ODISHA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Odisha Undertaking)

E-TCN NO.- CPC-79/2026-27

OPTCL invites bids under single stage two part system from any bidder for Engineering, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning work for AI based survey and maintenance of Transmission line of OPTCL on Turnkey Contract Basis in e-tendering mode only. The estimated cost of the tender is **Rs. 111,49,26,001/-**. The last date & time of Submission of Bid Dt. 27.10.2026 up to 12:00 P.M.

The interested bidders may visit OPTCL’s official website <http://www.optcl.co.in> and www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL for detail specification.

Sd/-
Chief General Manager(CPC)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARIK SURKSHA SANHITA Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Laxmi Narayan @ Bitto S/o Rajender R/o Imarti Devi ka Makan, Vill. Poothkalan, Alipur, Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 014158/2024 U/s 379/411/34 IPC.**, has been registered at **PS: Civil Lines, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Laxmi Narayan @ Bitto** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Laxmi Narayan @ Bitto** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Laxmi Narayan @ Bitto** of under **FIR No. 014158/2024 U/s 379/411/34 IPC.**, Registered at **PS: Civil Lines, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **04.11.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Kartik Taparia
JMFC-06 (Central), Room No. 247
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/13063/N/2026 (Court Notice)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE No. TSD-GZB-03-2026-27

No. TSD-GZB-03-2026-27 Date 25.09.2026

On behalf of the President of India, Chief Engineer/TSP, Northern Railway, Headquarters office, Baroda House, New Delhi-110001 invites the following tender through E-Procurement system:

S. Tender N.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Cost of tender document	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Estimated Tender value (in Rs.)	Date & Time of opening of tender	Period of completion
1	TSD-GZB-03-2026-27	Random testing of Track Fittings at Northern Railway, Track Supply Depot, Ghaziabad	NIL	20,000/-	9,98,114,80/-	28.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.	12 months
2	TSD-GZB-04-2026-27	Hiring of machinery for leading of Rails, Fishplates & other material from various locations over Northern Railway including shifting of Rails and Fabricated Glued joint and other allied works to facilitate Fabrication of insulated Glued Joints at Glued Joint workshop, in Track Depot Ghaziabad for a period of Two years.	NIL	28,000/-	13,97,995.36	28.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.	24 months
3	CSP-KSF_07_2026-27	Sawing & supplying of soft wood scantling of Mango or Eucalyptus or other locally available soft wood (size 50 mm x 50 mm, minimum 01 meter long) for a period of Two years to Concrete sleeper plant, N. Rly., Khalispur-Varanasi	NIL	18,200/-	9,10,700/-	28.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.	24 months

Note:- The complete information of above E-Procurement tender is available on website www.ireps.gov.in

3354/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

epaper.indianexpress.com

NO CASUALTY SO FAR; REGIONAL CONNECTIVITY DISRUPTED, SAY LOCALS

Heavy rain triggers landslide in Sikkim village, CM calls situation serious

Sweetey Kumari

Kolkata, September 25

CONTINUOUS RAINFALL triggered a major landslide in a Sikkim village on Thursday night, damaging several houses and government quarters as debris swept towards residential areas, causing extensive property damage. While no casualties have been reported so far, authorities have begun assessing the damage.

The incident occurred in Rimbi village in Sikkim's Gyalshing district.

Sikkim Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang termed the situation "serious" even as authorities urged residents to remain vigilant amid concerns that several houses could be swept away, with the weather forecast indicating the likelihood for more rain in the state.

The soil along the mountain slopes is unstable, fuelling panic among locals that a much larger landslide could occur at any moment. With several houses directly in the landslide's path at risk, residents have begun moving essential belongings from their houses.

"The landslides have disrupted regional connectivity, forcing commuters to navigate mud-covered roads at great

personal risk. Residents fear that if the rainfall intensifies, the soil will loosen further, increasing both the scale and momentum of the landslides," a local said.

In a post on X, Tamang said, "Deeply saddened and concerned by the situation in Rimbi, Gyalshing district, following the severe landslides last night. The situation remains serious, and the safety and well-being of the people continue to be our foremost priority."

He added that directions have been issued to the authorities to remain on high alert, closely monitor the situation, and take every possible measure to ensure the safety and security of the public. "I understand the deep distress and uncertainty being faced by the residents, especially as the difficulties have persisted from the very beginning. My thoughts and prayers are with every family affected," he said.

Advising locals to stay vigilant and follow the advisories, Tamang said the government was closely monitoring the situation.

Earlier this month, a landslide struck the area near the Theng Tunnel within the Naga Sanctuary in North Sikkim.



The landslide caused extensive damage to property in Rimbi village in Sikkim's Gyalshing district on Thursday night. Locals have started moving essential belongings from their houses. PTI

Wrestlers move court against Brij Bhushan acquittal

Nirbhay Thakur

New Delhi, September 25

FOUR WOMEN wrestlers moved a sessions court Friday challenging the acquittal of former BJP MP and ex-Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh in a sexual harassment case. In their petition, the wrestlers claimed that the trial court order acquitting Singh applied the "ideal victim standard" throughout and unfairly relied on stereotypes of how a victim "should" act.

The petition is listed for hearing at 10 am on Saturday before Special Judge Dig Vinay Singh at the Rouse Avenue Court.

Singh was acquitted by a magistrate court on August 3, more than three years after six women wrestlers accused him of sexual harassment.

Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Ashwini Panwar had held that the allegations were "false and fabricated" and "seem to be politically motivated". Former WFI assistant secretary Vinod Tomar was also acquitted in the case.

In its acquittal order, the court had noted that the victims were initially hesitant to level allegations against the ac-



Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh was acquitted by a magistrate court in August. FILE

cused, fearing that doing so could jeopardise their careers. When they eventually came forward, the order noted, they gave "wrong" details about the country and year in which the alleged incident took place. The court cited this "contradiction" as one of the major reasons for acquitting Singh.

In their fresh petition, the wrestlers contended that the trial court discredited the complainants simply because they could not recall incident dates with photographic precision, did not immediately fight back, and maintained professional ties with the accused despite

his complete control over their careers.

It also claimed the order was "archaic" and founded on an "erroneous and selective appreciation of evidence on record". It said the order relied on "stereotypical assumptions about the 'expected' behaviour of victims of sexual assault and harassment, rather than on a fair, evidence-based assessment".

It further said the magistrate court "repeatedly treats the absence of retaliation" as proof that the "allegations are false".

Olympian Vinesh Phogat, who disclosed earlier this year that she was among the six complainants, had previously said the wrestlers would appeal the verdict. "We have not lost hope, and the wrestlers will continue their fight," she said.

The trial in the case was completed three years after a chargesheet was filed. A total of 32 prosecution witnesses were examined. Two complainants had alleged that Singh touched them inappropriately and sexually on the pretext of checking their breathing patterns.

Of the six complainants, two later turned hostile, while charges were not framed in the allegations levelled by a third.

IIT-Delhi researchers build homegrown graphics chip for low-cost devices

Express News Service

New Delhi, September 25

RESEARCHERS AT IIT Delhi claimed to have developed a programmable micro-graphics processing unit (GPU) designed in India, a step they say could eventually enable locally designed graphics hardware for low-cost embedded devices.

The processor is designed for graphics and display applications rather than high-end AI computing, with potential uses ranging from industrial control displays and e-rickshaw navigation systems to educational devices and navigation terminals for small boats.

Currently, all GPUs are imported. "To the best of our knowledge, this is the first working, demonstrable indigenously designed micro-GPU from a university in India," one of the researchers from the Department of Electrical Engineering said.

The current system runs on a Spartan-7 Field Programmable Gate Array (FPGA), rather than as a standalone silicon chip.

The team developed a programmable graphics processor architecture capable of graphics rendering, with the hardware described in Register Transfer Language (RTL) and implemented on the FPGA platform.

M Tech students Nammi Akash and M Ravi Teja led the project under the guidance of professors Jayadeva and Kausik Saha of the Department of Electrical Engineering.

"Our objective was to create a compact but genuinely programmable graphics-processing architecture suitable for FPGA implementation and future ASIC realisation. We hope such indigenous hardware systems can support affordable digital-access platforms and contribute meaningfully towards bridging the digital divide," said Akash, one of the researchers.

Teja said that the hardware architecture is a scalable, programmable graphics processor IP suitable for applications such as industrial control displays, low-cost human-machine interfaces, e-rickshaw dashboard navigators, inland-water navigation terminals for small fishing boats, educational e-book readers and other affordable embedded visualisation systems.

The design could be implemented on programmable hardware such as FPGAs or converted into an Application-Specific Integrated Circuit (ASIC), the researchers said.

An ASIC would involve manufacturing the processor design as a dedicated silicon chip. The current work, however, remains at the FPGA demonstration stage.

The researchers said they are now exploring an 8-16-core vector-style graphics processor architecture, along with an optimised compiler and graphics software toolchain. The longer-term plan includes developing a proof of concept using a 65-nanometre ASIC process.

Manga, helpline and AI: India pilots BRICS' mental health support network

Anonna Dutt

New Delhi, September 25

A 17-YEAR-OLD Chinese schoolgirl, Xiaoyu, watches her grades collapse as severe anxiety and depression take hold. Afraid that a diagnosis could bring shame to her family and hurt her university prospects, she suffers in silence. Her mother dismisses her exhaustion as laziness.

It is only when an empathetic classmate steps in, understands her distress and helps her reach a community counselling clinic that Xiaoyu begins to understand that mental illness is not a failure of character.

In an educational manga created to tackle mental health stigma in China, a doctor explains it through a simple metaphor: a mental health condition, like a broken leg, may require treatment and support. By the end, Xiaoyu has returned to school with tools to manage her condition — and is helping another struggling student seek support.

The story is designed to challenge ideas around "losing face", parental blame and the notion that seeking psychological help is a sign of weakness. But it also illustrates a larger challenge facing countries across the BRICS grouping: how to make mental healthcare more accessible, acceptable and closer to where people live. That is where a newly established BRICS Network of Centres of Excellence (CoEs) in mental health, which will be piloted by India, hopes to play a role, bringing together approaches developed across



As the coordinating centre, the NIMHANS has been developing the governance protocol while a multi-country steering committee and technical working groups are being formed. TCM

member countries and adapting them to local health systems.

"The hope is that this network will mitigate the existing treatment gaps across BRICS countries by scaling task-sharing models and digital telehealth platforms. It will also aim to integrate mental healthcare into primary health centres, bringing services to hard-to-reach and rural populations," says Dr Naveen Kumar C, professor of psychiatry at NIMHANS and one of those working on setting up the network.

The focus will be to upskill frontline and non-specialist health workers so that basic mental-health support, identification and referral can become part of routine primary care. This approach is particularly relevant in nations where specialist services are concentrated in cities while large populations live in rural or underserved areas.

Indonesia has developed a 24x7 digital platform aimed at responding to mental health

crises and suicide prevention. South Africa has explored pictorial, story-based screening approaches that can help community health workers identify mental health concerns during home visits. The UAE is using virtual-reality-based clinical simulations and interventions.

Russia, meanwhile, provides examples of tech-assisted assessment and rehabilitation. Approaches being explored there include physiological measures like heart-rate variability and galvanic skin response (sweaty skin), alongside biofeedback and other non-invasive technologies.

India brings its own experience to the table, particularly with tele-mental-health services that can plug into the existing healthcare system.

"Collaboration within the network will span technical expertise, joint research, capacity building, and knowledge exchange rather than pure monetary grants," says Dr Naveen.

Potential areas of joint re-

search include AI-assisted screening, digital interventions, suicide prevention, biomarkers and epidemiological mapping of mental-health conditions across BRICS countries. The network is also expected to share operational blueprints for digital platforms, tools and learning-management systems.

"A compendium of evidence-based clinical protocols, culturally adaptable tools and public-education strategies is also envisaged," says Dr Naveen.

Members will also work on common approaches to issues like data privacy and cybersecurity, ethical deployment of AI and human-rights-based mental-health policies. The scale of India's challenge makes such knowledge-sharing relevant.

Dr Naveen says, "An estimated 197.3 million individuals in India were affected by mental health disorders in 2017. And there was a 70%-92% treatment gap. There is a shortage of psychiatrists, clinical psychologists, and psychiatric nurses, with most specialists being concentrated in cities. And, mental health conditions in India are projected to result in economic losses of USD 1.03 trillion between 2012 and 2030. Learning from other countries may help India address these challenges."

The network is being operationalised, with Centres of Excellence, agreements, contact points and governance mechanisms being worked out. NIMHANS, as the coordinating centre, is developing the governance protocol, while a steering panel and technical working groups are being formed.

Child abuse material online: SC gives MeitY, law & justice ministries 'one last chance' to act

Express News Service

New Delhi, September 25

TERMING IT an "extremely serious" matter, the Supreme Court on Thursday gave the Centre one last opportunity to respond to a plea seeking steps to prevent the availability of child sexual exploitation and abuse material (CSEAM) on digital platforms.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran noted that on August 14, it had asked the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology and the Ministry of Law and Justice to explain the steps taken to effectively implement the directions issued by the court in its September 23, 2024, judgment in the case 'Just Rights for Children Alliance & Anr vs S Harish & Ors'.

"Unfortunately, till this date, no such counter or report has come on record. The matter before us is extremely serious. We give one last opportunity to both the ministries to file their counter/report," the bench said.

"The counter/report should explain clearly what steps the two ministries have taken to give meaningful effect to the directions issued by this court in the main judgment dated 23.09.2024...and what steps have been taken so far to curb this menace....," the Supreme Court said.

It asked the government to "also indicate in so many words, what precautions the government would be taking in future to prevent lapses on the

part of the social media intermediaries."

The court was hearing a petition filed by a coalition of NGOs working against child trafficking, sexual exploitation, and other allied causes.

During the hearing, the counsel for the petitioner told the bench that two years had passed since the judgment but its directions had not been complied with. The Centre said that it would file an affidavit setting out an action-taken report. It added that a standard operating procedure (SOP) was in the process of being prepared and would be placed on record after being finalised.

By its September 2024 judgment, the Supreme Court had set aside a Madras High Court order which said that merely storing child pornographic material without any intention to transmit it would not constitute an offence under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. It held that viewing, distributing or displaying any child pornographic material without actually possessing or storing it in any device or in any form or manner, would still tantamount to 'possession' in terms of Section 15 of the POCSO Act.

Among others, the Supreme Court judgment also called on Parliament to consider bringing about an amendment to the POCSO Act so as to substitute the term "child pornography" with CSEAM so as to reflect "more accurately on the reality of such offences".

STUDENTS WILL ALSO BE INTRODUCED TO PROS AND CONS OF AI IN NEW TEXTBOOKS, SAYS STATE IT & HRD MINISTER; WORK UNDERWAY ON 'GAMIFYING' CLASSROOMS THROUGH TECH

Father in kitchen, girls playing drums: Andhra's bid to end gender stereotypes

Sreenivas Janyala

Hyderabad, September 25

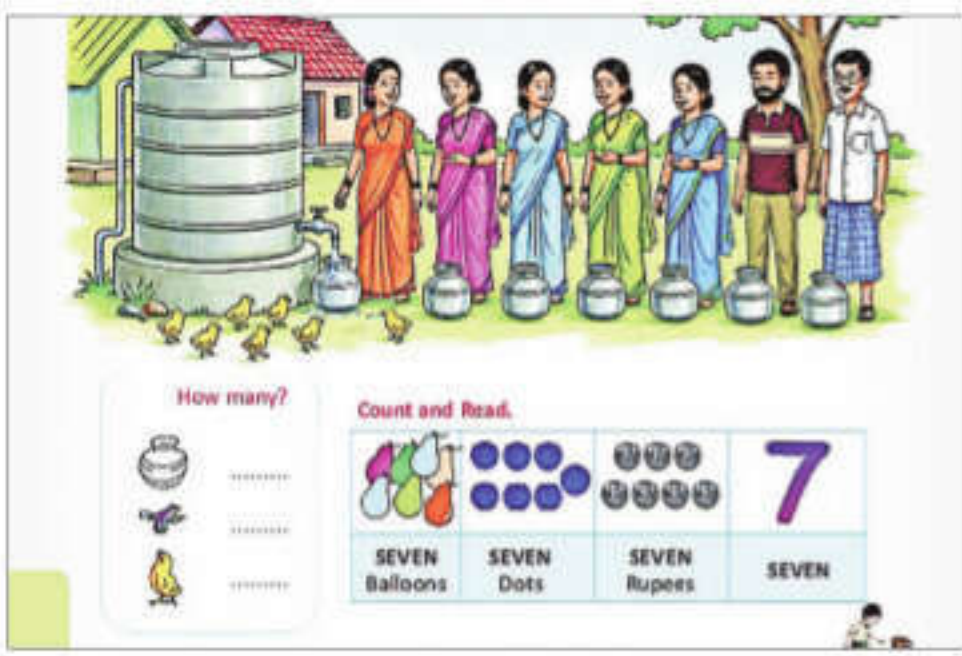
FATHER WORKING alongside the mother in the kitchen, girls on drums and violins during musical performances, and men and women both standing in line to collect water from a common public tap: These are some of the images that can be seen in the new textbooks for classes 1 and 2 in Andhra Pradesh as it attempts to eliminate gender stereotypes from a young age.

In the new books, the children will also be introduced to both "good" and "bad" sides of Artificial Intelligence.

"While past textbooks depicted household chores as being performed entirely by women, the new textbooks, introduced recently, changed this approach so that 50% of the household chores shown are performed by men and 50% by women," said an official.

"The aim is to avoid gender stereotyping from the first grade itself," said state IT and HRD minister N Lokesh Naidu.

During a chat organised by the Public Affairs Forum of India (PAFI) in Delhi on Thursday, Lokesh said that the state's ongoing reforms in school and higher education have a strong



This image shows both men and women standing in a queue to collect water from a public tap.

focus on value-based education, gender sensitivity, technology-enabled learning, curriculum reform and industry-linked skilling.

Other examples of gender-neutral roles in the textbook are of a woman selling vegetables, a man weaving a flower garland alongside a woman at a shop, and a man and a woman working in an agricultural field.

Listing other changes in the school system, Lokesh said primary schools are now implementing "No Bag Day" on Saturdays, which is reserved for value-based and practical learning. The activities include

lessons on managing family budgets and agricultural budgets, field exposure visits and an introduction to AI.

Lokesh said students are being introduced to both the positive and negative sides of AI so they can understand the technology and use it effectively in their chosen fields. The state government is working on a project of "gamifying" classrooms through technology.

Under the proposed approach, after every 45-minute class, students would watch a 60- or 90-second video summarising the lesson, followed by four to five questions. Using

clicker technology, students would actively participate in answering the questions, he said. "The data would feed into the state's Learning Management System (LMS), enabling the system to identify individual learning gaps and provide prescriptive homework and targeted learning content," he said.

"If a student is strong in mathematics but weak in another subject, the system would identify the specific gap and provide additional homework and learning material through the LEAP app, which is accessible to parents and teachers as well. This would

allow students to clearly understand the areas where they need improvement," he added.

The minister said the state government was also working to improve the teacher-taught ratio. "From just 3% schools having one teacher per class in 2024, the number has now increased to 33%," he said.

"The state recently completed a major teacher recruitment drive under which 16,000 teachers were recruited to achieve the objective of one teacher per class," Lokesh told *The Indian Express* on Friday. He said teacher recruitment is being undertaken every year.

Senior bureaucrat
Mandeep
Bhandari is new
CBSE chairperson

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 25

SENIOR IAS officer Mandeep K Bhandari, a 2001 batch IAS officer of the AGMUT cadre, will be the new chairperson of the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE).

Bhandari will replace Lokhande Prashant Sitaram, who was given the additional charge as the CBSE chairperson after the Centre transferred his predecessor, Rahul Singh, on June 2, amid the On-Screen Marking system row.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has approved Bhandari's appointment as the CBSE chairperson, an order issued by the Ministry of Personnel said. Bhandari is currently Principal Secretary to the Lieutenant Governor of Jammu and Kashmir.

Meanwhile, 2001-batch IAS officer Ankita Mishra Bundela of AGMUT cadre, currently posted as the Additional Secretary, Department of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare, has been appointed as Additional Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education.

Armed men kill 4 Naga civilians in border village of Manipur

Express News Service
Imphal, September 25

FOUR TANGKHUL Naga civilians, including a man and his son, were killed by suspected Myanmar-based Kuki National Army-Burma (KNA-B) militants in an attack on a village in Manipur's Kamjong district on Thursday evening, police said on Friday.

According to the police, the suspected KNA-B militants, armed with sophisticated weapons, entered Pilog Naga village along the India-Myanmar border, around 35 km from the Kamjong district headquarters, and opened fire on villagers, killing four people. The victims have been identified as Vareishim Jajo, 67, his son Phami Jajo, 43; Ningthem Kasak, 35; and Betterson Jajo. The bodies were brought to the Kamjong district headquarters for post-mortem examination.

With the latest incident, at least eight members of the Naga and Kuki-Zo communities have been killed in separate incidents over the past nearly two weeks.

Condemning the killings, the Tangkhul Naga Long (TNL) called a 24-hour emergency shutdown across its jurisdiction

from 7 am Friday. In a notice issued on Thursday, TNL secretary Thanreingam Muivah said the shutdown was being observed in protest against the killing of the four civilians.

The organisation said essential services, including power, medical and fire services, as well as movement related to funeral and condolence programmes, will be exempted.

Meanwhile, youth organisation Khanuithot-Khon (Voice of the Tangkhul Naga Youth) has opposed Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh's proposed visit to Ukhrul on September 28. In a statement, the organisation said Singh was scheduled to visit Ukhrul to attend a public outreach programme, and the visit should be reconsidered in view of the security situation following recent killings and violence in Naga-inhabited areas.

The organisation raised concerns over the continued presence and activities of armed groups operating under the Suspension of Operations arrangement and demanded greater accountability for violence against civilians.

It also called on the state and Central governments to take im-

mediate measures to protect Naga civilians, ensure accountability for the killings and restore security in Naga-inhabited areas.

The recent incidents have added to growing concerns over the deteriorating security situation in districts bordering Naga and Kuki-Zo areas.

On September 15, two Kuki-Zo women were killed at Leijangphai in Tamenglong district in an attack by armed miscreants.

On September 21, a 17-year-old Naga boy was gunned down in an area between Tamei and Nkou by unknown armed miscreants.

Two days later, on September 23, a 36-year-old Kuki-Zo man was shot dead at Wakotphai village in Tamenglong district. Hours later, at least 24 houses in two Naga villages—Makui Khuman and Makui Thanamba/Chamruioi—were set ablaze in Kangpokpi district by armed miscreants, official sources said. The villages are located around 15 km northeast of the Chalwa police station.

The same day, gunfire erupted at Makui Thebram, another Naga village, between two armed groups, officials said.

AFSPA extended in parts of Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal

New Delhi: The Centre has extended the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958, in specified areas of Nagaland, Manipur and Arunachal for another six months, according to Gazette notifications issued on Friday. This follows a review of the law and order situation there.

The AFSPA, which gives special powers to the Armed Forces, will remain in effect for six months from October 1, unless withdrawn earlier, the notification said.

In Manipur, the MHA has extended the disturbed area declaration across the state, excluding areas under the jurisdiction of 13 police stations in five districts.

In Nagaland, the AFSPA has been extended in nine districts: Dimapur, Niuland, Chumoukedima, Mon, Kiphire, Noklak, Phek, Peren and Meluri. ENS



Until Next Year

Devotees click photographs of the 'Lalbaugcha Raja' idol of Lord Ganesh as it is taken for immersion on the occasion of Anant Chaturdashi in Mumbai, Friday. DEEPA JOSHI

Ahmedabad man held for defrauding US nationals of over \$7 million: CBI

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, September 25

THE CBI on Friday said it had, on Wednesday, arrested a key accused in a transnational cyber-enabled financial fraud case involving illegal call centres and defrauding US nationals of \$7.21 million.

The CBI said that it registered a case on September 8, against the accused Ankit Satishchandra Pandey and other unidentified persons. It said, "The accused persons, in criminal conspiracy with each other and unidentified associates, impersonated as officers of Federal Trade Commission (FTC), US Attorney, Critical Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) and other federal agencies, falsely informing the victims through VoIP communications that their identities were used to access child pornography through their computers. Thereafter, the accused induced the victims to withdraw funds from banks, purchase gold and handover the same to courier persons engaged by them in the USA."

Dhaka stops import of Indian hilsa; may not export it as well this Puja season

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, September 25

IN NEWS that will disappoint fish lovers, Bangladesh is unlikely to export hilsa to India this Durga Puja season and has also stopped importing the famed fish from India. This comes weeks after India exported 500 metric tonnes of hilsa to Bangladesh in a role reversal of sorts.

According to fish traders in Kolkata, this is a deviation from the annual practice of the Bangladesh government earmarking the amount and window for hilsa exports to India just before Durga Puja.

"They have abruptly stopped imports from India. All permits in their country were cancelled through a circular on September 23. Also, Bangladesh is not allowing import of hilsa this year. Time has run out," said Syed Anwar Maqsood, secretary of the Fish Importers Association in Bengal and the Howrah wholesale fish market.

"Every year, between September 15 and 20, just before Durga Puja, the Bangladesh government makes an announcement, allowing us to import hilsa. They also fix the amount which can be imported. But this year, the time has passed. From October 7, fishermen in Bangladesh will stop catching hilsa. So we have no time to import," he added.

"It is very unfortunate. Hilsa from Bangladesh is in high de-

mand here, especially the ones from the Padma River. But this time, we won't get it. Interestingly, even during the political upheaval in Bangladesh and under the interim government, we were allowed to import hilsa," added Maqsood.

"The movement of hilsa from India to Bangladesh through Petrapole has stopped. They are unlikely to allow imports to India. We do not know what prompted the decision, but it is unprecedented," said Kartik Chakraborty, secretary of Petrapole Clearing Agents Staff Welfare Association.

Incidentally, a delegation from the Fish Importers Association visited Dhaka in August, met Bangladesh's Commerce secretary Ataur Rehman Khan and requested that the ban on hilsa exports to India be lifted.

Bangladesh imposed restrictions on exporting hilsa to India in 2012. But since 2019, the neighbouring country has lifted the curbs for a short window during the Durga Puja season. "But now we see that the small window for imports before Durga Puja is also gone," said Maqsood.

A substantial proportion of the consignments India sent originated from Gujarat, while some supplies moved through the Howrah wholesale fish market. Hilsa from India with high roe content is in high demand in Chattogram, Sylhet and other districts of Bangladesh.

'Extraordinary matter, concerns PM': Delhi HC tells Meta to remove morphed posts in 24 hrs

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, September 25

THE DELHI High Court Friday directed police protection for a woman who accused Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders, including Saurav Das and Abhijit Dipke, of circulating alleged obscene morphed pictures of her with the Prime Minister and exposing her to death threats.

Justice Girish Kathpalia also directed Meta to "immediately", in not more than 24 hours, take down the objectionable photos. The court issued directions, noting that it is an "extraordinary" matter since it concerns the PM.

"Otherwise I will not interfere in this kind of proceedings because you've remedy available in law. But this is an extraordinary petition in which it is not just a matter of one lady but a matter of the prime minister of this country... I believe action will be taken," Justice Kathpalia

remarked, addressing the police.

The court issued notice to all respondent parties in the woman's plea, and sought a status report from the Delhi Police on the progress of the probe within a week.

The court was hearing a plea filed by a woman against CJP leaders Saurav Das, Abhijit Dipke, Ashutosh Ranka and Ratna Singh for allegedly posting and circulating an alleged deepfake picture of her alongside PM Modi on social media.

The woman had filed an FIR with the Delhi cyber police station on Thursday. However, according to her plea, the police have not acted on the objectionable content circulating online so far.

Termining such circulation a "coordinated cyber-assault and public character assassination using deepfake technology", the woman sought that the alleged morphed images be taken down as well as police protection for herself.



“Success is linked to fitness, and the one thing common among those who set benchmarks in any field of life is their fitness. A healthy individual, a healthy family, and a healthy society are the path to great new India.”

- Narendra Modi



District Administration Faridabad

organizes

Drug-Free Haryana

Faridabad Nammo Marathon

«« 2026 »»

Chief Guest

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini

Chief Minister, Haryana

August Presence

Sh. Krishan Pal Gurjar

Union Minister of State for Cooperation

Sh. Vipul Goel

Revenue & Disaster Management, Urban Local Bodies and Civil Aviation Minister, Haryana

Sh. Rajesh Nagar

Minister of State for Food, Civil Supplies & Consumer Affairs, Printing & Stationery (I.C.), Haryana

September 27, 2026, 6:00 A.M. - Surajkund Mela Ground, Faridabad



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TIMED RUN



10KM
TIMED RUN



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FUN RUN

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The Big Picture

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 26, 2026

11



Hasina Majothi at her home in Morbi, Gujarat. She teaches tailoring to girls at a convent near her home and stitches school uniforms for a private company. CHIRAG CHOTALIYA

SAVING SAHIL A mother on the front line

Sahil Majothi's Russia dream soured soon after he landed in 2024 — forced into combat, he ran across the border and surrendered to Ukraine, where he is now a prisoner of war. Back home in Morbi, Gujarat, his mother, wracked by worry for her only child, began a fight to get the 23-year-old home. **BRENDAN DABHI** on Hasina's long wait for Sahil

Majothi Sahil Mahamadhusen... India...Morbi... That was all Hasina Majothi could understand of what her son Sahil was saying in the video. It was a strange tongue. The boy only knew Gujarati, Urdu, Hindi and some English. What was this then?

It was the first time in a year that Hasina had heard from Sahil. The last time he called was to say that he was in a jail in Moscow. On April 10, 2024, three months after he left for Russia on a student visa, Sahil had been arrested in a drug case.

And now, this video, released by the Ukrainian army. In the video, Sahil wore a red T-shirt, his hair closely cropped. He didn't look particularly distressed, even laughed a bit as he spoke. But her mind raced. Was he in more trouble? Had he been kidnapped? Hasina recalls crying loudly that day, October 7, 2025, her heart aching.

It was after her brother got the video translated that Hasina got to know more: Sahil, speaking in Russian, was talking about his arrest in the drug case, that he was not at fault, how he had later been "forced" to fight Russia's war against Ukraine and how he surrendered to the Ukrainian army. Soon, his photograph was on all news channels — as the Indian caught in the Russia-Ukraine war.

Sahil would later be sent to a Ukrainian facility that houses Russian prisoners of war (POW), many of them foreigners like the 23-year-old.

Since then, thousands of kilometres from the war front, from her home in Morbi, Gujarat, the 43-year-old has been waging a war of her own: both against a breast cancer that is, for now, in remission, and to get her son repatriated to India.

'At least he is safe'

Since the Russia-Ukraine war began on February 24, 2022, several Indian youth have found themselves at the front lines of a battle they have no stakes in. Many of their stories follow a similar thread: in Russia on a student or work visa, and recruited by the Russian army to fight its war.

On September 1, 2026, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said India had information about 227 of its nationals being recruited into the Russian armed forces, of whom 139 had been discharged, 51 had died. New Delhi, he said, was in constant discussions with Moscow for the release and repatriation of those still in Russia.

Addressing the UN General Assembly on September 23, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy named India among 47 countries whose citizens, he said, Russia was using in its war against Ukraine.

What gives Hasina some comfort is that Sahil is now more than 1,000 kilometres from the war zone, at a POW internment facility in Lviv, western Ukraine. He is believed to be the only Indian at the facility.

"At least he is safe... at least he is not fighting the war," says Hasina.

A year into her marriage, Hasina had

separated from her husband and moved in with her maternal family in Morbi. Since then, Sahil had grown up in the old, yellow house in the corner of Lane No. 4, diagonally opposite the convent of the Sisters of Charity, where Hasina teaches tailoring to girls. She also stitches school uniforms for a private company.

Her mother, brother and his family live on the floor above. She says she never left Sahil out of sight, with the boy spending hours curled up on the bed across hers, talking to her or sleeping to the rhythmic clack of Hasina's sewing machine. He could stitch, too, and was especially good at making shirt collars. Sometimes, he would carry out deliveries for her.

Hasina says that after Sahil finished school in 2021, he wanted to go abroad to study engineering. But with the pandemic raging that year, he gave up on the idea and later worked 12 hours at a ceramic factory in Morbi, bringing home Rs 22,000 a month.

By 2024, he finally got into an engineering course at ITMO University in Russia's St Petersburg, before which he had to do a Russian Language and Culture course. Hasina says the family pooled in money to send Sahil abroad.

On January 10, 2024, he flew to Delhi and from there to St Petersburg. "He was so happy. But that was the biggest mistake I made, letting him go," says Hasina.

From Russia, Sahil would call her on video, send her photographs — of snow, of him in jackets, selfies in front of St Basil's Cathedral in Moscow. He also found part-time work as a courier.

He was living his dream. Until Hasina got a call on the midnight of April 10, 2024. "It was a video call, but I was sleeping and I missed it. When I called back at 3 am, he was

crying. He said he was delivering a packet, but police had found drugs in his bag. *Be-chara...* he didn't know what was inside. He said he was being arrested," says Hasina.

The line broke off. "After that, I kept calling him, but he didn't answer. The next day was Eid, and I wished him, but the message was never delivered. After that, I lost all contact with him," she says.

For the next few months, the family launched a frantic effort to trace him. Hasina's brother Farukali Samsudinbhai Majothi wrote several letters, to the Union Home Minister, to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), reached out to the Indian Embassy in Russia and politicians in Gujarat, and registered on the grievance portal of the Prime Minister's Office.

In a letter to the MEA on June 12, 2024, Farukali wrote, "It has been two months and two days and we are not in touch with Sahil... We have received information that he is currently in a rehabilitation centre somewhere in Russia... Currently everything is grey for us... Please help me get Sahil back to India with all the formal and legal process. If required, I am ready to travel to Delhi."

Then, sometime in October that year, six months after Sahil's arrest, Hasina got another call from him. "He said he was in a jail in Moscow. He told me he was being forced to accept Russian citizenship. If he agreed to do so, they would give him a house, a job, and a girl to marry, and drop the case against him. I told him not to sign it. I don't think he signed," she says.

It was around the same time, in October 2024, that advocate Deepa Joseph took up Hasina's case *pro bono*. "I found a news report about the advocate helping a Kerala nurse return from Yemen. I managed to get her contact and spoke to her," says Hasina. As vice-chairperson of the Save Nimisha Priya International Action Council, Advocate Deepa had run a campaign to stop the execution of Nimisha Priya, a nurse from Kerala who was on death row in Yemen.

For almost a year after that October call in 2024, Hasina got no calls. Traumatized and worried sick, and as a side effect of the cancer treatment, she says she ate less and less. "I lost 12 kg in that period," she says.

'I killed no one, send me home'

Then came the October 2025 video, posted on the X handle of the 63rd Separate Mechanised Brigade of the Ukrainian army. A friend had brought it to Hasina's brother Farukali's attention.

In the video, Sahil, speaking in Russian, talks about how he was sentenced to seven years in prison in the drugs case. "I didn't

want to serve time in prison, so I signed a contract for the SVO (the Russian term for the war with Ukraine). It's a one-year contract, you serve for one year, and then... well, they let you go home... Someone said they give 1.5 million rubles. I think they gave me nothing. In short, everyone there is a total liar," he says, chuckling.

He says he was trained for 16 days. "How to hold [a rifle], shoot... This is an F-1 [grenade]. Here's how to prime it... throw it, that's all. And on September 30 [2025]... they transferred me to the green lines [the stage before the combat zone]. The next day, on the 1st [of October], the commander asked, 'Well, are you ready?' There were three of us... We walked 3 or 3.5 km. We had to dig a trench."

He says he didn't want to do any of it. "I told the commander: 'I am very tired. My legs hurt, my heart hurts.'" An argument followed, the Russian commander asked a soldier to confiscate Sahil's radio and throw him out. "I gave my radio and ran. The Ukrainian dugout was 2-3 km away. I went there, put down my assault rifle... I don't want war, that's all. I need help... I killed no one... It's only my third day... I don't want to go back to Russia. I'd rather stay here, in prison. If possible, send me home to India."

After the video became public, the Gujarat Police took Hasina to the headquarters of the Anti-Terrorist Squad in Ahmedabad, where she told them everything she knew.

On October 30, 2025, advocate Deepa Joseph filed a writ petition in the Delhi High Court, seeking the judiciary's intervention to bring Sahil home. At the first hearing on November 3, 2025, the court asked the Indian embassy in Kyiv and the MEA to file status reports within four weeks. The MEA was also asked to depute an officer to liaise with officers in Ukraine.

In a March 18, 2026, response to the Delhi High Court, the MEA said that the embassy in Kyiv was in contact with the Ukrainian government, but communication from Ukraine's foreign affairs ministry on Sahil's release and repatriation was still pending.

Asked for an update, MEA sources said they had obtained consular access to Sahil and officials from the embassy had met him twice. They also said they were pressing the Ukrainian government for his early release.

A month after the court order, advocate Joseph, while on a personal tour to Europe, decided to go to Ukraine "to find out what was happening" since "there was no response from the authorities".

She reached Ukraine on December 23, 2025, and contacted the Indian embassy. "They had already met Sahil. But Hasina didn't know about it," says Deepa, adding

Sahil on a video call with his mother Hasina from the POW camp in Lviv, Ukraine, where he is lodged

INDIANS ON THE FRONT LINES OF RUSSIA-UKRAINE WAR

227

Indians recruited into Russian army

Of them, **139** DISCHARGED

51 DEAD

SOURCE: MEA

2024

- JANUARY 10:** Flies out to Russia to study engineering at ITMO University in St Petersburg
- APRIL 10:** Arrested in a drug case by Russian police
- SEPTEMBER:** Sent out to front lines to fight Russia's war against Ukraine

2025

- OCTOBER 1:** Surrenders to Ukraine
- OCTOBER 7:** X handle of Ukraine's 63rd Separate Mechanized Brigade of Ukraine uploads a video in which he talks, in Russian, about the events surrounding his surrender. Family sees the video
- OCTOBER 30:** Family moves court, seeking judiciary's intervention to bring Sahil home

2026

- JANUARY 1:** Lawyer visits Sahil at a facility for POWs in Lviv, Ukraine
- JULY:** Office of the President of Ukraine writes to family lawyer, saying their plea has been forwarded to the Coordination Headquarters for the Treatment of POWs "for processing and consideration"

that she finally sought help from 'I Want to Live', an organisation that works for foreigners in Ukraine jails. "They told me that Sahil was in a POW camp in Lviv. That was the first time any of us, even his mother, knew where he was."

On New Year's Day in 2026, advocate Deepa and Sister Ligy Payyappilly, Superior of the Sisters of St Joseph of Saint-Marc, drove four hours from Mukachevo, a city in western Ukraine, to the Lviv camp. They carried a few items for Sahil: clothes, undergarments, coffee powder, biscuits, and four boxes of cigarettes that he could barter for milk and coffee.

"They took me past a room where there were a lot of POWs watching television. As I walked, all eyes turned to me. I spotted a familiar face and shouted, 'Sahil'. He was shocked. I introduced myself. He had had no contact with his family since he went to jail in Moscow. He was called out of the room to meet me," says Deepa.

At the end of their meeting, recorded by the 'I Want to Live' team, Joseph made a video call to Hasina.

In Morbi, Hasina says, "It was the first time in over a year that he had heard my voice and seen my face. Out of 18 minutes, he cried for 10 minutes. We hardly spoke, but at least I knew he was safe."

Since then, Sahil has been calling once every couple of months. There is never enough time for a conversation. "We have so much to say to each other, but we need to rush... There are others waiting for their calls," she says.

When Hasina speaks, it's with a rare stoicism, honed over dozens of interviews that she has given since the 2025 video. Over and over again, she has stepped out of the yellow house, veil on her head, eyes fierce and dry, and stood in front of the line of microphones and cameras to explain her son's case, hoping someone important enough would intervene to bring her son back home.

'I can hardly sleep'

These days, Hasina's life revolves around the calls she gets — from Sahil and from advocate Deepa with updates on the case. Hasina makes sure her phone never runs out of charge.

She is also part of a WhatsApp group of families whose sons are stranded in Russia. "We are a group of 61 from across the country. Somebody or the other says something almost every day," she says, before lowering her voice to a whisper. "Some left the group after losing their sons to the war."

In July this year, advocate Deepa got an email from the Office of the President of Ukraine, saying her plea for Sahil's release "has been forwarded to the Coordination Headquarters for the Treatment of Prisoners of War for processing and consideration..."

The advocate had passed on the news, but all Hasina understood was that it was a reason to hope. She has now started preparing for Sahil's return, browsing through an online portal on her phone and making purchases — a T-shirt that says "soldier, never off duty", a cap, a sweatshirt, a wallet, a pair of shoes, a belt, deodorant, some socks. "He told me he left all his stuff behind in Russia. When he comes home, he will need something," she says.

Beside her lie two electric sewing machines, the plug off the sockets and the needles without thread.

"I don't feel like working. I keep praying. I can hardly sleep," says Hasina, her voice finally cracking.

With inputs from Divya A, New Delhi



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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Trump-Xi bonhomie can't paper over tensions

LITTLE OF substance was achieved at the Donald Trump-Xi Jinping summit this week, particularly on the three Ts that have come to define the US-China relationship. On trade, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the two countries had agreed to extend the Busan truce, which expires in November, when China's suspension of its rare-earth export restrictions is also due to end. On technology, Trump said he was content to leave AI "exactly where it is", while Xi merely stressed the need to maintain human control over it. And on Taiwan, Xi urged Trump to oppose Taiwanese independence, even as the US has held back an arms package for Taiwan worth about \$14 billion. The pageantry, however, appears to have been the overarching objective of the meeting. A strategy of managed stability suits both sides for the moment: Trump is bogged down by the war in Iran with the midterm elections around the corner, while Xi is contending with a slowing economy ahead of next year's Communist Party Congress.

What does stand out from the summit, however, is the red carpet Trump rolled out — literally — for Xi, personally receiving him at Joint Base Andrews for their third meeting in less than a year. Trump referred to their "truly great friendship", and Xi reciprocated by using the US President's own catchphrase while stressing the need for closer cooperation: "Achieving the great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation and making America great again can go hand in hand." Such personalisation of the US-China relationship may help the two sides keep tensions temporarily contained and preserve a fragile *modus vivendi*. The US is heavily reliant on China's critical minerals, and Beijing wants an open market in the US for its goods. This means that neither country has an incentive to tackle any of the fundamental disputes. But managed stability can also allow unresolved tensions to accumulate, making a future rupture more difficult to contain.

Nowhere are the risks more apparent than in the case of AI. Despite growing calls for an agreement on AI safety, especially amid warnings from leading US AI companies that the pace of AI development needs to slow, neither Washington nor Beijing has much incentive to constrain a technology they see as a source of strategic power. The history of arms control offers little reason to expect either side to make concessions. The worry for other countries, including India, is that an AI dialogue between Washington and Beijing could evolve into a framework in which the two leading powers set the rules for everyone else. Pursuing cooperation with allies and building indigenous capability should be New Delhi's priority.

Growth holds up for now. Inflation clouds outlook

OVER THE past few days, global agencies have upgraded their full-year growth estimates for India, following the first-quarter GDP estimates that showed a stronger-than-expected economic momentum. The Asian Development Bank, for instance, is now pegging growth at 7 per cent for the year, up from its earlier forecast of 6.6 per cent. S&P Global is now forecasting the economy to grow at 7 per cent, while the OECD has raised its projection from 6.3 per cent to 7.1 per cent. Moody's had earlier raised its growth forecast for the year to 7 per cent, up from 6 per cent.

Some of the commentary has revolved around investments, industrial activity and exports as driving growth, despite concerns over activities being impacted by the conflict in West Asia. Industrial production has been healthy, with IIP growing at 6.3 per cent during April-July and manufacturing by 7 per cent. The Centre's capital spending is growing at a brisk pace — capex has surged by almost 30 per cent during April-July this year. Merchandise exports have grown at a robust 17.8 per cent during April-August, aided perhaps by a weak currency. Growth, however, is expected to moderate towards the second half of the year. As per S&P Global, "growth to ease in the second half of the fiscal year as the tailwinds from general sales tax rationalisation and income tax cuts diminish". The OECD also expects the momentum to weaken, "before a gradual recovery takes place in 2027". The farm sector has emerged as a key area of risk. As per the ADB, "Worse-than-expected El Niño could reduce agricultural output and raise food inflation" in the wider region.

Price pressures are building up in the economy, and the expectations of higher interest rates have gained traction. S&P Global expects inflation to average 5.1 per cent, and the RBI to "raise its policy rate by 25 bps in the current fiscal year". As per the OECD, "India is projected to raise policy rates temporarily to help offset stronger inflationary pressures." The central bank's monetary policy committee is slated to meet in a few weeks. The growth-inflation dynamics should tilt the scales towards tighter policy.

A bronze medal, quiet gains in table tennis

TABLE TENNIS is the slowest-growing among racket sports in India. That impression is largely because there is no poster girl or poster boy for the sport in the country. But the mixed doubles bronze won by Diya Chitale and Manush Shah at the Asian Games indicates India's slow but steady progress. The duo defeated Hong Kong's World No. 4 pair, Wong Chun-Ting and Doo Hoi Kem, but lost in the semis to the World No.1 Chinese pair, Wang Chuqin and Sun Yingsha.

Amid the shambles at the shooting range and the slow start in other sports, TT has made unheralded progress. This is the racket sport's fourth bronze after the medals won by the men's team and Manika Batra-Sharath Kamal mixed doubles in 2018 and Ayhika Mukherjee-Sutirtha Mukherjee in women's doubles in 2022. TT has a thriving national league, the UTTT. But Manush from Vadodara and Diya from Mumbai have kept the legacy of the sport's traditional TT hubs. They won a Muscat World Table Tennis Contender title earlier this year, defeating the Chinese pair of Huang Youzheng and Shi Xun Yao. Last year, they became the first Indian pair to qualify for the season-ending WTT Finals. This incremental growth has gone unnoticed.

Table Tennis is a global sport because of low entry-level expenses, but it is among the toughest at the Asian Games, where China, Japan and Korea tend to be impregnable. A foothold for India is significant, especially because the sport remains riddled with problems, including borderline selection calls. Players get little recognition unless an Olympic medal arrives. Ayhika Mukherjee's victory over World No.1 Sun Yingsha at the World Team Championships, for instance, hardly stirred any Indians. But an Asian Games medal helps.

A declining United Nations is not good news for a rising India

INDIA IS rising as the United Nations (UN) loses authority. Rivalry among major powers may create room for manoeuvre but it also makes agreements harder to trust. For an aspirational power, that is a poor bargain. Indian diplomacy must win more influence over UN decisions while helping make those decisions matter.

This year's General Assembly is unlikely to resolve that tension. Governments whose consent the UN needs are often pursuing objectives it was established to restrain. A week of diplomacy in New York will do little to change the calculations that lead powerful states to bypass the organisation or block its work.

India needs agreements that hold when relations sour. New Delhi has long defended sovereignty and resisted intrusive international rule-making. Yet constraints imposed by powerful countries can leave it with even less say. The question is who writes the rules and how much influence India has over them. Multilateral arrangements give India a voice in those negotiations and room to cooperate with countries it disagrees with elsewhere.

Ukraine, Gaza and the war involving Iran and the Gulf expose the Security Council's inability to restrain its strongest members and their clients. Sudan demonstrates the consequences of neglect. The Council was designed to work when the major powers could agree. Its veto gives each permanent member the means to block action when they cannot. Appeals to the Charter have little effect when those expected to uphold it can prevent its enforcement.

Unilateral coercive measures extend this problem into everyday commerce. An Indian company may be free to trade under Indian law yet find that a foreign bank will not process its payment or an insurer will not cover its cargo. Control over these networks lets powerful states project national restrictions far beyond their borders without authorisation from the UN Security Council. Weaponised interdependence leaves Indian businesses exposed to rules their government had no part in writing.

A world divided into rival financial and technological systems could make that dependence harder to escape. India might gain bargaining opportunities, but access to a market or technology could increasingly require accepting the conditions of one camp. A larger economy will not by itself remove that vulnerability.

The UN retains value even when its Council is paralysed. Universal membership gives smaller countries a claim to be heard without a major power's invitation. Its agencies deliver relief, document the human cost of crises and organise the scientific assessments used in climate negotiations. As climate shocks and widening inequalities strain developing countries, the UN gives them a forum to press claims on climate finance and sustainable development.

That is not enough. The UN still falls short too often. The Secretariat must simplify procedures, cut duplication and spend carefully. Governments are also weakening the organisation they invoke when convenient. They assign tasks they



SYED AKBARUDDIN

The UN retains value even when its Council is paralysed. Universal membership gives smaller countries a claim to be heard without a major power's invitation

do not fund, delay payments they owe, and cut assistance while expecting the UN to absorb the damage. A peace operation given an ambitious mandate and inadequate resources is being set up to fail.

AI presents an early test of who gets to write rules that matter. The UN's independent scientific panel has warned that AI agents could become harder for humans to control. On September 23, technology executives briefed the Security Council on AI's risks. The Council has a role where AI threatens international security. Companies bring essential expertise, but also commercial interests. AI's reach into employment, education and development needs wider consideration. India should press for safety standards and access to technology to be negotiated where developing countries have a voice. Permanent members and some technology firms cannot represent everyone whose future these rules will shape.

India's influence at the UN depends on the partners it can bring to a negotiation. On September 21, India helped launch Partners for Multilateralism, or P4M, with Brazil, Canada, Kenya, the EU, Australia and Barbados. The group spans different diplomatic camps. The declaration recognises that economic interdependence is being used to exert pressure, disrupting trade, supply chains and development finance. Each partner has relationships that could help India persuade countries it might not otherwise persuade. Joint proposals on climate finance or protec-

tion against economic coercion could attract wider support. That work need not wait for agreement on the more contentious questions of UN reform.

The world's most populous democracy and a major economy, India has a compelling claim to permanent membership. Africa's exclusion from permanent membership makes the case for Council reform harder to ignore. Regional rivalries obstruct agreement on expansion. Charter amendments also require ratification by all five permanent members. An elected seat is the nearer prospect.

A practical priority for External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar at this Assembly is to secure support for India's candidature for an elected Security Council seat for the 2028-29 term. Its opponent in the June 2027 election is Tajikistan, which has never served on the Council. A founding UN member in 1945, India has contributed more than 275,000 personnel to UN peacekeeping. Smaller countries will also want to know how India would use another term to address their concerns. India can draw on that record to argue for mandates troops can carry out, and for affected countries to be heard before the Council acts.

A Council term would give India more scope to negotiate agreements and insist that governments honour them. The test will come when an agreement obstructs the choices of powerful states. The Charter matters most when it gets in the way.

The writer is former permanent representative of India to the UN, and dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy, Hyderabad

Gen Z is much more than political street theatre



NEELKANT BAKSHI

THERE IS a new political fashion in India: Anyone who takes to the streets, abuses opponents, damages public property, or creates disorder is quickly presented as the authentic voice of "Gen Z". The label is then appropriated by political groups and vested interests eager to give their own agenda the sheen of youth rebellion. This portrayal does a profound injustice to India's young generation. The people who shout the loudest do not necessarily represent their generation. And those who destroy public property, attack institutions, hurl abuse, or turn political disagreement into violence cannot claim a monopoly over the aspirations of millions of young Indians simply because they happen to be young.

India's Gen Z is far larger, more diverse and considerably more accomplished than the political street theatre through which some of its supposed representatives are being showcased. In a democracy, peaceful protest is an important constitutional and political instrument. Young people have every right to question governments, challenge policies and demand accountability. But protest does not acquire moral legitimacy merely because the protesters are young.

Age cannot transform vandalism into democracy and turn abuse into political argument. Nor can a crowd become a representative voice for an entire generation simply because cameras happen to be pointed at it. A dangerous narrative is slowly taking shape: That India's Gen Z is inherently angry, anti-establishment, violent, contemptuous of institutions and incapable of constructive engagement. They may disagree passionately with the government of the day. They may support different political parties. They may be politically conservative, liberal, socialist, nationalist, or politically indifferent.

But political diversity is not the same thing as political disorder. This is where the "Cockroach Janta Party" phenomenon (political forces that seem determined to crawl into every available social grievance and appropriate it for partisan purposes) needs to be called out.

No political party, whether in government or opposition, owns Gen Z. No ideological group owns the youth. Neither should India's Gen Z have its identity outsourced, nor should vested interests be allowed to hijack the label of "Gen Z" and use it to portray an entire generation as

angry, anarchic or hostile to the institutions of democracy. There is a profound difference between challenging authority and rejecting responsibility.

There are those young Indians whose contribution is measured not in social-media followers or television sound bites but in courage. They are the young men and women in uniform who guard India's borders, serve in difficult terrain and, when required, make the ultimate sacrifice for the country. They demonstrate something that is increasingly absent from the caricature of Gen Z being constructed by sections of political activism: Responsibility.

The danger of such appropriation goes beyond politics. It distorts how India and the world understand its young population. India is one of the world's youngest major societies. India's young people are not merely a demographic statistic; they are an enormous productive, creative and strategic resource. If the image of Indian youth is reduced to angry crowds breaking things, abusing people and confronting the police, the country does itself a disservice. More importantly, millions of young Indians who quietly work, achieve and contribute are rendered invisible.

India needs young citizens who question authority, but who also understand responsibility. It needs young people who demand change, but who know that change requires institution-building. It needs young Indians who are fearless enough to criticise power, but disciplined enough not to destroy what belongs to the public. It needs disagreement without dehumanisation, protest without violence and political activism without the abandonment of basic civic responsibility.

The real Gen Z story of India is not being written exclusively on the streets. They do not need to hurl abuses to demonstrate courage. They do not need to vandalise public property to demonstrate anger. They do not need political parties to certify their relevance. Their work speaks for itself. The real Gen Z of India is not a mob. It is a generation building, competing, innovating, serving, and achieving. And that Gen Z is far too large, and far too consequential, to be represented by those whose only claim to represent it is that they know how to make the most noise.

The writer is former media relations head, Delhi BJP



ROHAN MANOJ

If not, this could be one more tragic episode in the broader conversation about student suicides. But if so, the focus needs to shift to casteism at elite institutes

SOME DISCUSSIONS on the death of Sahil Wakode, a student at IIT-Bombay, have linked it to the ongoing national conversation about student suicides, highlighting issues such as academic pressure, disciplinary processes, teacher-student relationships and mental health support on campus. Yet there is perhaps too little emphasis on what may turn out to be the key factor in this case: The allegations of caste-based harassment, which have led to the police invoking the SC/ST Act alongside the offence of abetment of suicide. The entire issue really hinges on one question: Was a crime committed? If not, this could be one more tragic episode in that broader conversation about suicides. But if so, the focus needs to shift to casteism at elite institutes. That discussion is already happening, acrimoniously, at several institutes and on social media.

If a crime was committed, who did it? Wakode's father has made allegations not just against Suryanarayana Doolia, the professor involved in the incident in the exam hall, but also the institute's director, Shireesh Kedare. And if a crime was committed, over what period of time did it take place? The parents have spoken of harassment that had been going on for around three months, not just the incident in the exam hall on the day of their son's death. There is little detail in the public domain so far about these allegations, only rumours, supposed leaks and commentary. The claim that the student cheated in an exam is just that — a claim. In any case, it does nothing to disprove the allegation of ongoing harassment. The prudent approach would be to wait for more facts to be established and for the police to complete their probe. At this stage, the most important thing to emphasise is the need for a fair and thorough investigation.

Three aspects of the discourse emerging around this incident deserve special attention. One, this has turned into a STEM-versus-humanities conflict due to the involvement of humanities students in the protests. The very need to teach the humanities at a technical institute is being questioned in a puerile manner. There could be no better argument for the necessity of ensuring all students get a strong grounding in social and political thought.

Two, the anxiety of the meritorious. The concerns raised by some who have rallied in support of the professor — that he is being scapegoated even though he simply did his job and followed the prescribed process — are remarkably similar to the fears over the now-stayed UGC Equity Regulations, as well as the old anxieties around the "misuse" of the SC/ST Act. In this case, there are two problems. First, the facts of the "cheating" incident have yet to be established; it is not known if the proper process was followed. Second, by confining their indignation to that one incident, they sidestep the allegation of ongoing harassment.

Finally, there is the question of the perpetrator. Previously, in the context of OBCs, I have written about the need for a reframing — from "backward" to "oppressed". One thing this does is that it acknowledges the existence of perpetrators; "oppression" is always carried out by an "oppressor". If this case is truly about lack of mental-health support or institutional lacunae in some broad sense, then there is no perpetrator. One may lament and call on the administration to do better, but everyone is responsible and therefore no one is accountable. Crime, on the other hand, is done by criminals, casteism by casteists. The investigation will, hopefully, establish which is the case here.

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40 YEARS AGO

September 26, 1986



CPI leader, copshot dead

IN A spurt of terrorist activity, Communist Party of India (CPI) national council member Darshan Singh "Canadian" and a Punjab police head constable were shot dead even as military forces nabbed four extremists and recovered arms and ammunition from them in the past 24 hours in Punjab. Darshan Singh, three-time CPI legislator in Punjab and former secretary of the state unit of the CPI, was gunned down by two extremists while he was going on a cycle from Mahalpur to his native village Langeri in Hoshiarpur district.

Chinese intrusion confirmed

ARUNACHAL PRADESH Chief Minister Gegong Apang said the exact area occupied by the Chinese in Tawang district could not be ascertained so far but confirmed they had intruded into the Wangdung and Thundrong areas. He told the Assembly that defence forces in Tawang had been strengthened.

Ruling on suicide attempts

THE BOMBAY High Court held Section 309 of the IPC, which penalises an attempt to com-

mit suicide, to be *ultra vires* of the Constitution. Justice P B Sawant and Justice B G Kolse Patil gave this ruling on a writ petition filed by Sulochana, wife of a mentally ill police constable, Maruti Shripati Dubal, who was being prosecuted before a metropolitan magistrate on a charge of attempt to commit suicide.

Price of wheat

THE COMMISSION for Agricultural Costs and Prices is understood to have recommended Rs 165 per quintal as the government price of wheat for the 1987-88 rabi marketing season.

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
China and the US should be partners, not rivals.
— *Global Times, China*



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The election umpire’s independence begins with its appointment



FAIZAN MUSTAFA
AND MADHAV ANAND

NEUTRALITY IS not an ornament of the Election Commission. It is the constitutional reason for its being. In *Mohinder Singh Gill* (1978), Justice Krishna Iyer, echoing Lord Camden, cautioned that “wide discretion is fraught with tyrannical potential even in high personages, absent legal norms and institutional checks”. In the Constituent Assembly, Shibban Lal Saksena spoke of the possibility of the Election Commissioner being “a knave or a person who is likely to be under the thumb of the executive”. In response to this criticism, B R Ambedkar, through Article 324(2) made appointments to the ECI “subject to the provisions of any law made in that behalf by Parliament”.

For seven decades, however, Parliament did not make that law. In *Anoop Baranwal* (2023), a Constitution Bench prescribed an interim arrangement comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition and the Chief Justice of India. With godspeed and much like it had acted in the Shah Bano case, Parliament filled the legislative vacuum through the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, and replaced the CJ with a cabinet minister nominated by the PM.

On Wednesday, a two-judge bench of the Supreme Court referred petitions challenging the 2023 law to the CJI for constituting a Constitution Bench due to disagreement between the two judges, Justice Dipankar Datta and Justice Satish Chandra Sharma.

In Justice Datta’s words, the Narendra Modi government’s plea to refer the issue to a Constitution Bench emerged “in gradual course of his (the Attorney General’s) arguments”. The plea found no place in the counter affidavit and came two years into the litigation. Justice Datta rejected it, while Jus-

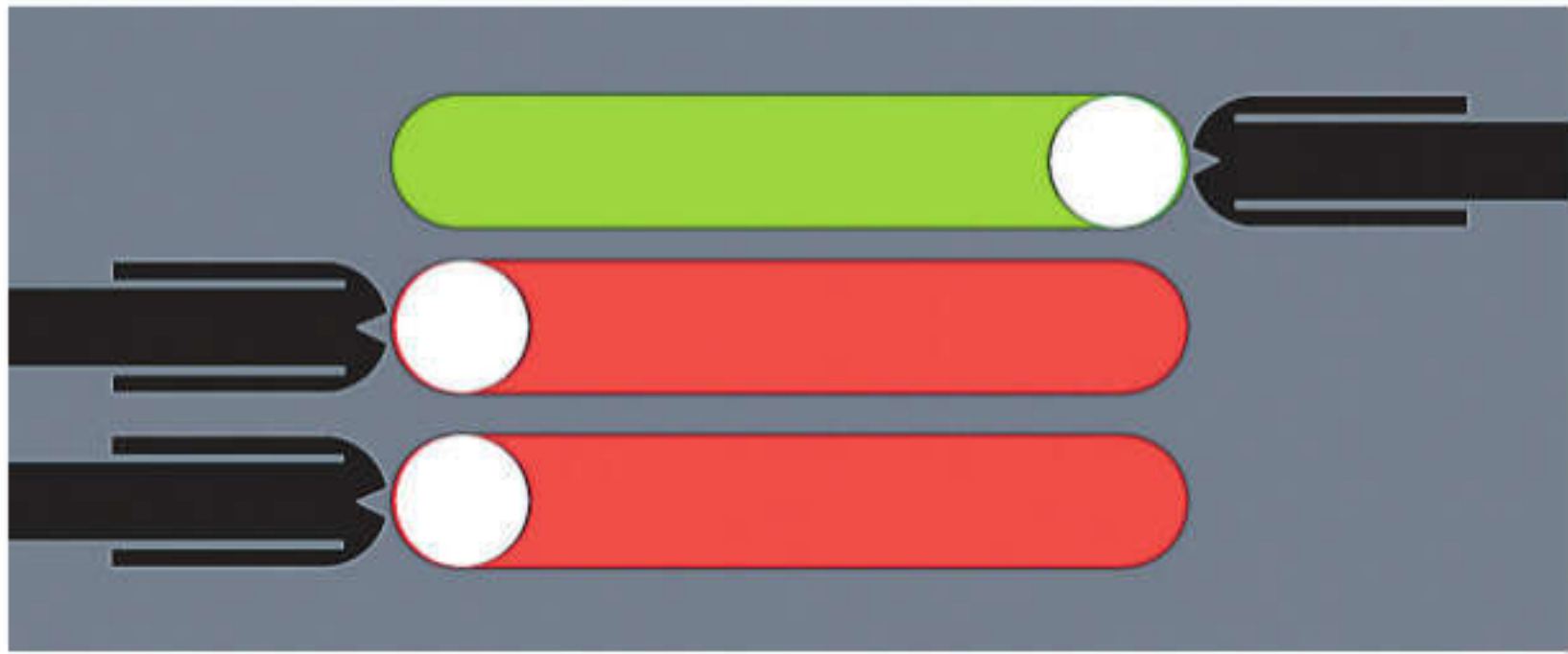


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

tice Sharma accepted it. Interestingly, in the *Aligarh Muslim University* judgment (2024), both the judges had found the referral to a Constitution Bench by a two-judge bench in a 1981 verdict problematic.

Justice Datta’s opinion rightly rests on an elementary and decisive distinction: Application of law is not interpretation. In *Thakur Ganga Singh* (1960), the Court held that a question of interpretation arises only when competing constructions of a provision are canvassed. Parliament answered the disclosure judgment in *Association for Democratic Reforms* (2002) with Section 33B of the Representation of the People Act. In *PUCL* (2003), a three-judge bench struck this down and called the demand for a reference “totally misconceived”. A parliamentary overruling of a judgment does not, by itself, make the constitutional question new. Where the governing principle has already been conclusively established, the remaining task is simply to apply it to the facts of the case.

What, then, did *Anoop Baranwal* settle? The bench held that “a person who is in a state of obligation or feels indebted to the one who appointed him, fails the nation”, that one “weak-kneed before the powers that be” cannot be an Election Commissioner, and that an appointment “must not be overshadowed by even a perception” that a “yes man will decide the fate of democracy”.

Justice Datta distilled this into a binding declaration of the ECI’s independence — the appoint-

Justice Datta distinguished the principle, which binds, from the prescription, which Parliament was free to change. The principle is that appointments must be insulated from exclusive executive control

ment process must be free of exclusive executive control. That standard, he held, “is binding on all courts”. What is not binding is the machinery the bench devised to meet it. The CJI’s inclusion was “a deliberate signalling advice, and not a mandate”. Demonstrating judicial reasoning at its best, Justice Datta distinguished the principle, which binds, from the prescription, which Parliament was free to change. The principle is that appointments must be insulated from exclusive executive control, and that “it is not enough for the ECI to be independent, it must also appear to be independent”. Justice may not be done but it should at least appear to have been done.

When the bench asked whether the PM’s nominee would ever oppose him in case of a difference of opinion between the PM and the Leader of the Opposition, the Attorney General’s answer was, “probably no”. The petitioners were more emphatic, saying, “certainly no”.

Whether the selection committee meets that constitutional principle is a question of application. It cannot become a question of interpretation merely by “repackaging an existing constitutional principle in a seemingly new factual or legislative setting”, Justice Datta held.

Though Justice Sharma demonstrated judicial humility, the difficulty lies in his reasoning. He accepts that the *Anoop Baranwal* committee was an “*ad hoc* arrangement”. He acknowledges

that free and fair elections are part of the Basic Structure, which “no court can or would, possibly, doubt”. He also accepts that “to the extent law has been declared under Article 141”, it “is to be applied”. He then describes what remains: “Whether the said Act fails the test of free and fair elections has to be independently examined”. To examine whether a statute fails a settled test is the very definition of application.

Justice Sharma notes that the question of whether Parliament, “was justified in not including a neutral selector” is “an important question arising for the first time before this Court”. However, this sentence cannot bear that weight because the neutral selector was the very reasoning of *Anoop Baranwal*, which included the CJI “as a neutral arbiter”.

Justice Sharma did not find the Solicitor General’s reliance on *NJAC* (2015) problematic. If the Law Minister’s presence in the committee to appoint judges offended the judiciary’s independence, his argument ran, “a corresponding degree of constitutional independence” must be recognised for the executive. Justice Sharma accepted the analogy as a “constitutional principle”. However, the SG’s argument turns *NJAC* on its head. *NJAC* shielded an independent institution from the executive; the SG’s analogy invokes it to shield the executive’s hold over another independent institution. Article 324 — which gives the ECI constitutional status — protects the independence of the umpire, not the players. And the executive, as Justice Datta courageously notes, is itself “a participant in the electoral process”.

Since the two judges could not agree on upholding the law, they should have read it down by requiring the selection committee to make its decisions unanimously. Such a requirement, in our opinion, would ensure that an Election Commissioner could be appointed only with the agreement of both the government and the Opposition, providing a stronger assurance of the appointee’s independence and credibility.

To err is human. A democracy can survive an umpire’s wrong call, but it cannot survive the suspicion that the umpire was deliberately chosen to make it.

Mustafa is vice-chancellor, Chanakya National Law University, Patna. Anand is scholar at NUJS, Kolkata. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Guarding the guards

THE LATEST revelations (‘14 times in 10 months, two Election Commissioners objected on record to poll panel steps’, *IE*, September 23) relating to serious differences within the ECI raise an even more fundamental question: Who will hold the Election Commission accountable when the institution entrusted with protecting the integrity of elections itself faces allegations of opaque and partisan functioning? The reported objections raised by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi over the past 10 months concerning electoral-roll management, voter registration, deletion and restoration of names, and electoral data are deeply disturbing. Reports that some decisions were allegedly taken without their knowledge require a transparent explanation.

Tharcius S Fernando, Chennai

Everyday failure

THE HORRIFIC gang rape of a 17-year-old girl in a South Delhi park lays bare how casual and reactive the system remains when it comes to the safety and protection of women (Don’t ask women to shrink, secure their space, *IE*, September 25). Furthermore, this security failure extends beyond isolated crimes to the everyday decay of public spaces.

Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi

Trump address

THE RECENT address by US President Donald Trump at the United Nations raises important questions about the future of international diplomacy (‘In Trump’s annihilation threat, a tiny space’, *IE*, September 25). His strong emphasis on American power, along with threats against Iran, risks weakening the spirit of cooperation that the UN was created to protect. However, the talks between US and Iranian officials show that diplomacy still has a valuable place. Dialogue, rather than threats, offers a better path to resolving conflicts and preventing further instability.

Ansh Dubey, Delhi



SHWETA SAINI
AND VANSH OBEROI

INDIA IS not short of wheat. The question is whether it knows enough about the crop it will harvest six months from now to export freely today.

On August 24, wheat exports moved from “prohibited” to “free”, following calibrated permissions of 2.5 MMT each in February and April. The balance sheet looks comfortable. Production is officially estimated at 120.7 MMT, though trade estimates are closer to 110 MMT. Procurement reached 35.76 MMT, against about 30 MMT last year. Central Pool wheat stocks stood at nearly 48 MMT on September 1, more than twice the October 1 buffer norm of 20.5 MMT. But a buffer surplus is not an export surplus. Today’s abundance comes from a crop already harvested. The crop that must replenish these stocks will be sown over the next two months, and there are reasons for caution.

The monsoon is about 15 per cent below normal, and the risk is uneven. Punjab and Haryana face large rainfall deficits, but their heavily irrigated wheat can lean on groundwater, at a cost to aquifers and state power subsidies. Rajasthan is more exposed: Rainfall is about 25 per cent below normal and reservoir storage about 31 per cent below. Bihar has received around 35 per cent less rain, raising concerns over pre-sowing moisture and groundwater recharge. Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh are better placed for now.

The crop that must replenish these stocks will be sown over the next two months, and there are reasons for caution

The outlook adds to the risk. NOAA’s September 14 update keeps El Niño in place through January-March 2027. The International Research Institute for Climate and Society sees higher chances of below-normal rain and above-normal temperatures over parts of India through March. A warmer winter is effectively a shorter one, and March matters most — an early temperature rise during grain filling cuts yields. This is not a forecast of crop failure. But parts of the wheat belt enter rabi with a thinner water cushion, and the heat risk is very much alive.

Nor can wheat be viewed apart from rice. Rice prices are already 7-8 per cent above a year ago, and kharif acreage is nearly 17 lakh hectares lower. Rabi and summer rice may recover some of this, but weak reservoirs and an unfavourable weather outlook could limit that. India’s cereal basket therefore has less room to absorb a wheat shock than headline stocks suggest.

The incentive to export is real. Black Sea wheat lands at Chittagong for about \$380/mt, against roughly \$330/mt for Indian wheat (based on Rs 27/kg in Madhya Pradesh). Forward markets point firm too. May 2027 Chicago wheat is around \$275/mt and Kansas HRW near \$300/mt, both about 15 per cent above May 2026 levels. With Black Sea disruptions persisting, futures are not signalling cheap wheat by the time India’s next crop arrives.

India has seen how quickly

Don’t export tomorrow’s wheat surplus today

such calculations change. In February 2022, Indian wheat production was estimated at a record 111.3 MMT. With the Russia-Ukraine war disrupting global supplies, India stepped up exports and targeted 10 MMT for 2022-23. Then came the unusually hot March. As late as May 12, the government was announcing trade delegations to promote wheat exports. A day later, exports were prohibited. On May 19, the production estimate was cut to 106.4 MMT.

Sugar offered a reminder just last month. On expectations of comfortable availability, the government expanded sugar exports in February. Production subsequently disappointed. By August, policy had moved from permitting additional exports to allowing duty-free raw sugar imports.

Such swings carry another cost. Opening exports fully and then shutting them abruptly erodes India’s reliability as a supplier. The answer is not to halt agricultural exports whenever forecasts are uncertain, but to retain room to respond.

India can keep a calibrated wheat export window and revisit it as information improves. If the crop is excellent, India can always export more. Wheat shipped today cannot be recalled if the harvest disappoints.

India has enough wheat now. What it lacks is enough information about its next crop. That is a reason to preserve optionality, not surrender it.

The writers are with Arcus Policy Research



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

forthright at the 80th session last year, pointedly asking if the UN had “lived up to expectations”.

Trump, who opened the session on September 22, also came down heavily on various UN bodies like the International Criminal Court and UNESCO. “There is no global government,” he insisted, and warned that the UN must “stop imposing the far-left agenda of globalist bureaucrats who nobody ever elected”. The US’s lack of faith in multilateralism became clear when Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on the sidelines of the UNGA that the current international system is unable to deliver. The US, “at least as long as President Trump is in office”, will always act in its own interest, “not in the interest of the international order”, he declared, categorically stating that “We will never put the international order above the interests of the US”.

Reform at the UN is long overdue. But the problem is that as pointed out by Jaishankar last year, the process for reform itself is an obstacle. John Bolton, former NSA of the US, was more candid in saying that any move to amend the UN Charter itself would face a veto roadblock. That brings us back to the outgoing Secretary-General’s comment: Not reform, but overhaul.

In the middle of World War II, when the League of Nations had completely become dysfunctional, two Western leaders, Franklin D Roosevelt of the US and Winston Churchill of Great Britain, came together to proclaim the Atlantic Charter in 1941. That served as the foundational document for the creation of a new multilateralism under the UN four years later. At a time when that West-dominated system is faltering, we need the statesmen from the Global South to come forward to build a new system — an Indo-Pacific Charter — the basis for which should be the recognition of multipolarity.

The writer is national vice-president, BJP and president, India Foundation

I don’t want to be cautious. I want to live free of fear

I was just 18, three months into college, when I was flashed for the first time by a middle-aged man. I was on a busy road that leads from my PG to the college. What stayed with me after was not the absolute horror and disgust that I felt in that moment but rather how ordinary it was. When I mentioned the incident to other girls, every one had their own story.

Ever since, I do mental math before I go out. Can I go on the route alone? Booking an auto is better than booking a cab. Is it too late or too early? Is the road too empty?

In the scorching Delhi heat, it has become my habit to think twice before wearing shorts, skirts and tank tops while stepping out. Nobody ever taught me to do this. I just learnt to carry shirts, scarves and cover-ups, like the way you learn a language. By living in it.

This week, when the news about a minor’s gang rape in Aastha Kunj Park (only 2 km from Lady Shri Ram College) near the college’s back gate broke out, the arithmetic only got louder in my head.

The cruel part is that LSR is where I have not had to stay alert. It’s a place where the shirts and scarves come off, we dress as we like, girls exist loudly, stay late without explaining themselves and take up room without apology. It is a space that taught me how to be unguarded. A man accused of rape was found barely 50 m from that very place’s

What I want is a city that makes a girl’s walk to her lecture something she doesn’t have to mentally prepare for

back gate, tainting that tiny island of freedom by proximity. That wasn’t just a security lapse; it was a disrespect to everything that place stands for.

On Wednesday, when hundreds of girls from LSR and other DU colleges filled the road outside our gate, they came for every woman who has been raped, and for every woman who lives in the constant fear that she might be next. We shouted slogans on a road where I usually walk with my guard up, and for once, it felt like it was ours. It felt like reclaiming space. It felt like we were worthy of our own institution, which has a reputation for standing with women — it was where the Pinjra Tod campaign took off, where they refused to accept curfews as the price of being safe.

But solidarity cannot be all we have. I do not want pepper spray in my bag. What I

want are streetlights that work, police who patrol before, not after, a crime, media that states facts correctly, and a city that makes a girl’s walk to her lecture something she doesn’t have to mentally prepare for.

The question was never how women should stay safe because that has been answered a thousand times, in parents’ warnings and PG rules and shopping lists. The question is why a whole society has left that answer to us.

I will carry the spray tomorrow, because I have to. But I have stopped believing this is what safety means. Safety is not a girl who is cautious about everything; it is a place where she never has to be cautious about everything, ever again.

The writer is a student at Lady Shri Ram College, University of Delhi

LEADERS FLAG 'STRATEGIC STABILITY', TO MEET AGAIN AT TWO SUMMITS BEFORE END OF THE YEAR

Trump, Xi wrap up summit with tea minus any big breakthrough

Trevor Hunnicutt & David Brunnstrom
Washington, September 25

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping drank tea at the White House on Friday and visited the National Archives, capping a three-day summit that showed-case personal diplomacy rather than big breakthroughs in economic relations.

The two leaders praised each other in remarks while they had tea in the White House Red Room. Trump said the summit between the world's two largest economies had produced great strides and that "I think our farmers are going to be happy", but did not provide details.

"America is very happy about this visit, and I'm sure China is very happy also," he said. Xi said the US-China relationship had developed into a constructive one of "strategic stability on the basis of respect, fairness and reciprocity."

Xi also said he and Trump would have two more opportunities to meet this year, the APEC summit in China and a G20 summit in Miami.

"I do welcome you, Mr President and the First Lady to visit China," he said. The lavish state summit, with flyovers, tours and a glittering state dinner, has been heavy on symbolism but light on substance.

Still, Trump highlighted progress under a bilateral trade mechanism, citing what he described as increased market access for US farmers and ranchers, while both leaders



Clockwise from top: US President Donald Trump talks with China's President Xi Jinping; OpenAI CEO Sam Altman engages with Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg; NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang and his wife Lori during a State Dinner in the East Room of the White House on Thursday. AP

identified artificial intelligence as an area for cooperation.

Details of the limited agreements the two sides struck regarding their tense trade relationship would be released on Monday, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer told CNBC on Friday.

"We're in a managed trade situation. ... We've had progress, and we will release on

Monday, I think, a lot more details about what we've accomplished over the past few weeks in negotiating with the Chinese," he said.

The US has agreed with China on exempting some key goods from arguments over trade, Greer said, including exports to China of agricultural products and medical devices and imports of consumer and

non-sensitive goods.

The summit concluded at the National Archives, where Trump and Xi appeared to review the US Declaration of Independence and the Constitution and the Bill of Rights.

Responding to a question, Trump said he and Xi had discussed Iran and said "I think we're going to do great" without elaborating.

Trump told Xi helping Iran is not acceptable, says US envoy

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump made clear during candid talks at the White House with Chinese President Xi Jinping that Chinese help for Iran is unacceptable, US Ambassador to China David Perdue said on Friday.

"We made it very clear to them weeks ago that, you know, any help that they would give Iran, whether it be direct or indirect, whether it be intelligence or parts or military equipment, was totally unacceptable. President Trump made that very clear again yesterday. This is an ongoing drumbeat," Perdue said in an interview with CNBC.

"These two leaders are beginning to develop a relationship of somewhat trust and also working on the issues... I think we see a different level of intimacy about these difficult issues that we're dealing with." REUTERS

China claims democratically governed Taiwan as its own and Xi has long sought to persuade Trump to state publicly that the US opposes Taiwan's independence, rather than saying only that it does not support independence, which has been Washington's formulation for decades. He is also keen to get the US to halt arms sales to the island. REUTERS

KEY TAKEAWAYS

TRADE DEAL EXTENDED

● The US secured an extension of its trade truce this week — but only a short one. US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the two sides agreed to extend by two months a trade agreement that ended last year's trade war and was due to expire in November.

DRESS TO IMPRESS

● For Trump, Xi's White House visit was an opportunity to show off a Washington being remade in his image.

XI WANTS 'PRUDENCE' OVER TAIWAN

● As expected, Xi pressed Trump on the Taiwan issue, saying, according to China's official news agency, that China hoped the US would "handle the Taiwan question with prudence."

STRATEGIC RISK

● Xi invoked the "Thucydides Trap", an academic theory that competition between a rising and an established power tends towards war. While Xi said the risk "can be overcome," his reference underscored how concerns about a potential US-China conflict continue to shadow relations.

DIFFERENCES ON AI

● The two leaders expressed diverging views about AI. Trump said in a social media post that he wants to "to leave it exactly where it is" and rely on the US Department of Justice rather than impose any new guardrails. But Xi said that as leading nations on AI, China and the US must manage its growth. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

FRANCE

Pope Leo warns world: AI is creating 'paradise of machines'



Pope Leo XIV. REUTERS

our humanity amid a 'paradise of machines' invading and conditioning our daily lives, there is an urgent need for education in ethical discernment," he said, speaking under the gilded ceilings of the Elysee Palace. REUTERS

POPE LEO urged the world to reconsider the development of artificial intelligence, opening his four-day visit to France on Friday with a fervent warning that AI could create a future where "a paradise of machines" takes control of the Earth. The first US pope, who has made sounding the alarm about the risks of AI a central part of his 16-month papacy, put the issue at the heart of his visit to France, the first by a pope in nearly 20 years. "If we are to avoid losing

GERMANY

Eastern town bans Holocaust memory plaques

AN EAST German town has approved a motion by the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) and ruling centre-right Christian Democratic Union (CDU) to reject future installation of brass plaques commemorating victims of Nazi persecution. The "Stolpersteine" are a prominent feature of Germany's Holocaust remembrance culture. The decision in Heidenau, a town near Dresden in the eastern state of Saxony, comes as the AfD tops national polls ahead of CDU. REUTERS

GREECE

Explosion near the Acropolis injures at least 2

A POWERFUL blast shook the Greek capital's tourist district of Plaka, near the ancient Acropolis, on Friday morning, causing a building to collapse and injuring at least two people who were rescued from an adjacent building, authorities said. Rescue crews with a sniffer dog were searching the rubble for potentially missing people, the fire department said. The fire department said the explosion occurred in an old two-story building in the Plaka district, historic part of Athens. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

Navy rescues 25 Indonesian fishermen

THE SRI Lanka Navy has rescued 25 Indonesian fishermen after their fishing trawler capsized south of the island nation, bringing them safely ashore at Colombo Port. The fishermen were aboard an Indonesian fishing trawler, which capsized on September 22 in waters within the Australian Search and Rescue Region, officials said on Friday. A merchant vessel, MV Moonstone, had rescued all 25 fishermen from the water on Thursday and alerted the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) in Colombo. PTI

over 1.2 million forcibly displaced Rohingya from Myanmar for more than nine years, and urged the international community to sustain humanitarian assistance and work towards their safe return. "This has placed immense pressure on our resources, environment, security and local communities," Rahman said in his address to the 81st session of the UN General Assembly on Thursday. PTI

PAKISTAN

Forces kill several Afghan Taliban fighters

PAKISTANI SECURITY forces killed several Afghan Taliban fighters after they allegedly attempted to enter Pakistan and opened hostilities along the border in Balochistan province, state-run media reported on Friday. The development comes after Pakistan conducted aerial and drone strikes on 10 locations in Afghanistan on Thursday. Afghanistan's Taliban government said the strikes killed four civilians. PTI

BANGLADESH

PM urges UN to ensure return of Rohingya

BANGLADESH PM Tarique Rahman has highlighted at the UN General Assembly his country's sheltering of

Russian strikes shut Ukraine's biggest steel plant, kill at least seven in Kyiv

Reuters

Kyiv, September 25

STEELMAKER ARCELORMITTAL said it was shutting production at Ukraine's largest steel plant, underscoring the growing economic toll of Russia's airstrikes that on Friday killed seven people in Kyiv, including a 14-year-old boy.

ArcelorMittal said on Friday it had informed the Ukrainian government that "safe and sustainable" operations were not possible after four strikes in five weeks caused extensive damage and killed five workers at the southeastern plant.

The shutdown is another blow to Ukraine's once-mighty steel sector, which previously accounted for 15% of the



Emergency personnel work at the site of a Russian drone attack on a business centre in Kyiv on Friday. REUTERS

country's exports but has come under pressure from Russian attacks and restrictions from the EU, its top trading partner.

Russia has intensified air

strikes across Ukraine in recent months using ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones that have hit businesses, logistics networks, Black Sea port facilities

and civilian infrastructure.

The economic impact of the attacks is cutting tax revenue and leaving the government with a widening budget gap as it seeks to finance the war, officials have said.

"The Russians are constantly expanding their escalation operation," President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, noting a food warehouse used by McDonald's was also hit on Friday. "It is important that the world responds to all of this and that Russia feels the response to its terror."

Ukraine has also stepped up its attacks on Russia, targeting defence and energy facilities as well as major online retailers in an effort to undermine revenues and support for Moscow's war effort.

TV channels resume White House coverage

Susan Heavey

Washington, September 25

US TELEVISION networks resumed their coverage of President Donald Trump's White House events on Friday, amid an ongoing court fight over the administration's decision to block CNN, MS NOW and Politico from the presidential grounds.

The White House television press pool on Friday aired video



CNN correspondent Betsy Klein at the White House on Thursday.

of Chinese President Xi Jinping's arrival at the White House for tea as well as the two leaders'

tour of the National Archives, which houses the US Constitution.

CNN along with ABC, CBS, Fox News and NBC share the costs of covering the president and rotate coverage, providing pool footage to other outlets. The other networks' refusal to set up cameras in solidarity had meant there was no pool coverage of Xi's visit to Washington until Friday.

Trump has long used the

press as a platform and punching bag, and since returning to office his administration has taken an aggressive stance against major news outlets, including limiting access to the Oval Office for some.

Trump declined to answer questions from reporters on China and Iran, his media ban and a controversial new government television ad as Xi arrived at the White House on Friday.

• YODELING EMERGED CENTURIES AGO AS A WAY OF COMMUNICATING IN THE ALPS — NOT JUST BETWEEN PEOPLE, BUT ALSO BETWEEN MAN AND ANIMAL

Austrian yodelers turn a parking garage into the Alps

Philipp Jenne
Graz, September 25

NO MOUNTAINS to practice on? No problem. Yodeling fans in Austria have moved their practice sessions to an underground parking garage, since it produces echoes like those they can get in the landscapes of the Alps.

"It's not too dissimilar to the high mountains," said yodeling teacher Anna Maria Gutschi as she led a group of 30 through an empty parking garage earlier this week. "You have wide hallways, you have walls that reflect a lot."

Gutschi works for the Styrian Volksliedwerk, a cultural organ-

ization promoting traditional folk music in the southeastern Austrian city of Graz — which is not in the high mountains, but sits in a flat basin surrounded by hills and low mountain ranges at the edge of the Alps.

The group has been holding a series of courses on yodeling in unusual places to keep the tradition alive in modern times. Whether it is an underground car park, a canal or a gas station — as long as the acoustics work, up to 30 people are allowed to join each time for a unique experience.

"It's a form of communication from mountain to mountain — just like that, without the need for a phone," Gutschi said,



People yodel in an underground garage in Graz, Austria. AP

describing the art of yodeling as she let her voice wander up and down the scales. "And it's not as boring as writing an SMS.

Sounds much better, too." "The energy is rising, it's rising and rising," Gutschi said as she explained the unique mel-

odic tradition to her students. "Ever higher and then it wants out on top and there it goes."

For over an hour, the yodelers walked through the city's largest underground parking garage, practicing their yodeling skills until they had reached the deepest part of the garage — and the best conditions for a great sound.

While some participants were already experienced yodelers, newcomers to the craft also were welcome to join this subterranean class.

Jamey Sohn, from South Korea, who is studying sustainable development in Graz, decided to take the class to immerse herself in Austrian

culture.

"When I actually came here, it was a lot more — well, I wouldn't say easy per se, but it's a lot more approachable than I first expected," Sohn said.

Yodeling emerged centuries ago as a way of communicating in the Alps over long distances — not just between people, but also between man and animal. Cattle would recognize their owner from his voice and return to the stable from far away. Over time this primeval form of singing has evolved into its own musical genre first made popular internationally by the US musical film The Sound of Music. AP

REVENUE DEPENDENCE ON DERIVATIVES CUT, SAYS CHAIRMAN

Focus on investor protection, revenue diversification: NSE

SEBI should allow exchanges to list on their own platforms, said Srinivas Injeti

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 25

THE PRIMARY duty of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) is to ensure a safe and trusted market for investors even if it comes at the cost of business for the exchange, Chairman Srinivas Injeti said here on Friday, amid the ongoing tightening of regulations in derivatives markets which has been a “cash cow” for both the bourse operators, NSE and BSE.

“We can’t be distracted from our primary duty of giving you a market with integrity and a market where investors are protected,” Injeti said during a media briefing here, a day after NSE’s listing.

MD and CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan and other senior management of the bourse operator were also present.

On regulatory tightening in the derivatives segment, Injeti said, “This imbalance, excessive dependence (on the derivatives segment), you know, will have to be reduced. So, I think that is the big picture. And given this, there is no way, there is no jugglery, there is no way in which quarter to quarter you can do some magic.”

Before this tightening, NSE and BSE were deriving over 90% of their revenues from the derivatives segment at one point.

Diversifying revenue streams

NSE’s management emphasised the need to take steps to better protect retail investors and diversify its revenue streams going forward.

Govt never agreed to 5-day work week for banks, facts being twisted: Sources

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 25

THE GOVERNMENT never agreed to a 5-day working week for banks, a finance ministry official has said ahead of the three-day strike announced by the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) from September 28 to 30 because this key demand has not been met. “The five-day week was never agreed at the time of the last wage negotiations. It was never a negotiating tool. They (bank unions) are twisting the facts,” the official said on the condition of anonymity.

In a letter dated September 22, the All India Bank Officers’ Confederation said there had been no response to this demand “which was agreed and signed in March, 2024 under the last wage revision settlement”. The letter added that officials from the Indian Banks’ Association (IBA) had informed

union representatives that the issue of five-days banking is “under consideration by the Government”.

Currently, bank branches are open on the first, third, and fifth Saturdays of every month.

The 12th Bipartite Settlement, agreed in March 2024, said that “in terms of an understanding” was reached between the IBA and unions to declare all Saturdays as holidays for banks.

“...IBA has accordingly recommended to the Government. The due changes in the working hours, will be effective after approval by the Government of India and necessary clearances from Government/ Reserve Bank of India,” the Settlement said.

However, the finance ministry official asserted the government had not agreed to a five-day work week, although a lot of other concessions were

made.

“The IBA didn’t want to go beyond an 11% hike in the wage negotiations, but the government intervened and a hike of 17% was announced.

Even on the issue of family pension, the IBA was not keen but the government said that post-retirement, they will be on the other side, and they should not fight it,” the source said, adding that the performance-linked incentive (PLI) scheme had been kept on hold for the current financial year following opposition.

Announced in November 2024, the PLI scheme for public sector banks’ employees faced intense pushback and was called “discriminatory” because it was only for Scale 4 officers and above. According to bank unions, the scheme is divisive, demotivating, and distortionary.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

2036-37 under Vision 2047. These corridors are special sections of national highways which provide uninterrupted, end-to-end travel. The total length of high-speed corridors by December 2025 stood at 3,052 km. The highway authority has mandated that traffic assessment of these projects should include existing, generated, induced, as well as diverted traffic based on proper traffic modelling. “Freight growth rate shall be duly analysed considering economic development. The traffic shall be validated from other secondary sources such as toll transactions. For freight

traffic and determination of VDF (vehicle damage factor), data from GST portals, mining departments and other sources should be validated,” it said.

It said that when the present traffic is up to 15,000 PCU (passenger car unit), the corridor should be developed as a four-lane highway with a four-lane structure. If the traffic is between 15,000 to 25,000 PCU, the corridor should be of four-lane highway and six-lane structures, and if the traffic is 25,000-40,000 PCU, then it should be a six-lane highway with six-lane structures.

“Access should be planned with the objective that the long

NEW MODEL BILATERAL INVESTMENT TREATY WITH CABINET, APPROVAL CLOSE

‘4-5 BIT pacts to be finalised soon’

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 25

THE MINISTRY of Finance has finished reviewing the model Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT) and has sent it to the Cabinet Secretariat, a senior government official said, adding that pacts with 4-5 countries, including Canada, are expected to be finalised soon under the new framework.

“We should soon finalise 4-5 BITs, we have expedited them. These will be as per the new model framework, which is waiting to be approved,” the official said on the condition of anonymity.

A statement issued late last month after the Inaugural Canada-India Finance Ministers’ Economic and Financial Dialogue, attended by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, said that “India expressed its readiness to initiate negotiations on a Bilateral Investment Treaty at the earliest”.

The Union Budget for 2025-26 had announced a review of the 2016 model BIT to make it more investor-friendly and attract sustained foreign investment. While the aforemen-

● COURSE CORRECTION

A BIT is an agreement between two countries which spells out rules governing private investment in either nation from companies in the other. They help promote, protect, and provide clarity to foreign investments

THE UNION Budget for 2025-26 had announced a review of the 2016 model BIT to make it more investor-friendly and attract sustained foreign investment

tioned official said 20–25 BITs were signed on the basis of this model, “we have moved far away from it” in recent years when agreements were inked with the United Arab Emirates, among others.

“The new model BIT will absorb those agreements where we had moved far away from the 2016 model,” the source added.

While critics have called for the five-year local remedy period to be reduced to one year or be even done away with entirely, the government has stood its ground and said that

it is important that the local judiciary is not ignored.

“People may have complained about India’s judiciary from time to time. But it has stood the test of time,” the official said, adding that “some red lines will not be crossed”.

To be sure, the government has shown a willingness to reduce the length of time for which local remedy must be pursued before international arbitration is sought. For instance, the BIT signed with the UAE in 2024 mandated local legal remedies be pursued for three years, lower than the five years in the 2016 model BIT.

A BIT is an agreement between two countries which spells out the rules governing private investment in either nation from companies in the other. As such, they help promote, protect, and provide clarity to foreign investments.

This would be especially beneficial at a time when India is struggling to attract money from abroad due to structural shifts globally: net Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) inflows in the first six months of 2026 have been \$12 billion. While this is up from \$3.1 billion in

France’s EDF pushes for its nuclear reactor tech in India

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 25

SENIOR OFFICIALS of the Ministry of Power on Friday held a meeting with French government-owned energy major Électricité de France (EDF) on the proposed deployment of European Pressurised Reactors (EPRs) in India, which has recently opened up its tightly-regulated civil nuclear sector for private players.

The opening up of the nuclear sector has renewed interest among global nuclear majors — including those from France, the US and Russia — in India’s nuclear power programme. The government is now moving towards finalising the rules and regulations under the SHANTI Act.

France, a global leader in nuclear reactor technology, has shared close and trusted ties with India for several decades, including in the strategic and civil nuclear sectors.

“The discussions centred on the deployment of EPR technology, India’s regulatory reforms for the nuclear sector, cooperation on pumped hydro storage projects, and the way forward for a robust, mutually beneficial partnership,” the power ministry said in a statement. The meeting assumes significance as the Department of Atomic

● What French energy major EDF said

● **Électricité de France** (EDF) briefed Indian officials on its efforts to develop an ecosystem and supply chain in India to enable large-scale localisation

● **The French** company reiterated

ated that a sizeable programme involving multiple nuclear reactors would provide suppliers with confidence and enable economies of scale by leveraging the capabilities of Indian industry



Energy (DAE) last month issued the draft rules and regulations of SHANTI Act, laying out the regulatory framework for a wider nuclear power ecosystem, including private participation, captive nuclear generation, foreign reactor technology, licensing, safety oversight and nuclear liability.

Pankaj Agarwal, secretary at the Ministry of Power, officials of the Ministry of External Affairs, Central Electricity Authority (CEA), NTPC Limited and NPCIL on the Indian side, and by officials of EDF and the Embassy of France in India on the French side attended the meeting. According to the power ministry, EDF briefed Indian officials on its efforts to develop an ecosystem and supply chain in India to en-

able large-scale localisation.

The French company reiterated that a sizeable programme involving multiple nuclear reactors would provide suppliers with confidence and enable economies of scale by leveraging the capabilities of Indian industry. Agarwal briefed the French side on the progress in finalising India’s regulatory framework for the nuclear power sector, including the draft SHANTI (Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India) Rules and Regulations, which were recently placed in the public domain by the DAE for stakeholder consultation.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

India key to Suzuki plans for next 10 yrs

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, September 25

SUZUKI MOTOR Corporation will halve the time taken to develop new vehicles by 2030 and deepen its focus on India as a manufacturing and export hub as part of a new technology strategy aimed at responding faster to changing customer needs and market conditions.

Under its “Technology Strategy 2026 for 10 Years

Ahead”, Suzuki will target a 50% reduction in new-model development lead time, alongside a 30% improvement in development efficiency and a 50% improvement in manufacturing efficiency by 2030.

The company plans to achieve this by changing the way vehicles are developed, moving away from a sequential process towards concurrent development, in which planning, design, production, quality and

procurement are brought together from the beginning.

Suzuki will also increase its use of digital engineering and modularisation. India will have a larger role in this global strategy.

Suzuki plans to strengthen the country as a manufacturing and export hub, targeting annual production capacity of around four million units by 2030.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

2025 and \$2.9 billion in 2024, it is far below \$35 billion in 20022 and \$53 billion in 2020.

A model BIT creates a standard template that can be followed whenever such agreements are being pursued with other countries. The model text is used as a guide and the final agreement between two countries depends on the negotiations that take place.

At present, the Indian government follows the BIT model approved in December 2015 and adopted in January 2016. However, that model has come under fire from various quarters, particularly because it mandated that domestic legal processes be pursued for five years to resolve disputes before international arbitration is sought.

This clause, which did not exist prior to the 2016 model BIT, is seen as a hurdle for foreign investors.

Another red line is set to be the exclusion of any tax-related provisions from the model BIT.

“Tax will not go into the model BIT. It’s our sovereign right to tax, and that can’t be open to arbitration.”

● BRIEFLY

Centre to borrow Rs 7.86 lakh cr in October-March

New Delhi: The Union government will raise Rs 7.86 lakh crore from securities in the second half of this fiscal year, reducing the total borrowing for the current financial year by Rs 1.2 lakh crore despite global headwinds. The reduction in total borrowing indicates the government’s commitment to fiscal prudence. A senior finance ministry official said the reduction is mainly due to switching of securities maturing in 2026-27 of Rs 1.14 lakh crore, a conscious debt-management strategy of the government. PTI

Forex reserves fall \$14.89 billion to \$766 billion

New Delhi: India’s forex reserves dropped by \$14.88 billion to \$765.9 billion during the week ended September 18 due to a fall in foreign currency assets, according to the RBI data. In the previous reporting week, forex reserves had fallen by \$4.92 billion to \$780.78 billion. For the week ended September 18, foreign currency assets, a major component of reserves, fell by \$14.816 billion to \$630.98 billion, as per the RBI data. PTI

● MARKETS

			
Sensex 73,895.74	NIFTY 23,140.50	Gold ▲ ₹1,52,113	US Dollar ▼ ₹95.82
315.20	77.40		
0.43%	0.34%	Silver ▲ ₹2,32,350	Oil ▲ \$123.67

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA
GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 24, 2026

Indian economy resilient despite headwinds, says RBI Bulletin

Mumbai: India’s financial and external sectors continue to draw strength from a resilient domestic economy, though escalating geopolitical tensions and weather-related uncertainties remain key downsides risks, RBI Bulletin said on Friday.

The escalation of conflict in West Asia in September has led to a sharp increase in crude oil prices, reigniting concerns of further disruption in global supply chains and build-up of inflationary pressures, said the article on ‘State of the Economy’ published in the latest Bulletin.

Besides, the rise in sovereign yields in some of the major advanced economies has put pressure on government finances.

Despite the challenging global environment, the Indian economy recorded a strong GDP growth in Q1:2026-27, the article said.

“India’s financial and external sectors are drawing strength from the real economy, although geopolitical tensions and weather-related uncertainties are acting as key downside risks,” it said. PTI

Airbus detects coating issue in A321 neo planes

New Delhi: Airbus has detected a quality issue with the surface protection coating on the fuselage of a significant number of narrow-body A321neo planes and around a dozen of such aircraft operated by IndiGo are also impacted, according to sources. IndiGo and Air India operate A321 neo aircraft. Together, they have around 190 such planes. An Airbus spokesperson on Friday said during some standard rework a surface protection deviation on stringers located at the lower front section of the fuselage was identified affecting a number of A321 aircraft. PTI

Govt appoints Subramanian, Pant to IRDAI

Mumbai: The government has appointed LIC Managing Director Dinesh Pant and former New India Assurance Company chairman-cum-managing director (CMD) Girija Subramanian as members of the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI). Pant will join the insurance regulator as Member (Actuary), while Subramanian has been appointed as Whole-Time Member (Distribution). ENS

● HIGH-SPEED CORRIDORS ARE SPECIAL SECTIONS OF NATIONAL HIGHWAYS WHICH PROVIDE UNINTERRUPTED, END-TO-END TRAVEL

India’s 50,000-km high-speed road plan: What new highway design rules say

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, September 25

TO ENSURE uniformity and consistency in the construction of high-speed corridors, also known as access-controlled national highways or expressways, the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has issued detailed guidelines covering the design, standards and specifications for such projects. Until now, consultants have been preparing detailed project reports (DPRs) for these corridors based on varying standards and specifications.

The move assumes significance as India targets 50,000 km of high-speed corridors by

traffic and determination of VDF (vehicle damage factor), data from GST portals, mining departments and other sources should be validated,” it said. It said that when the present traffic is up to 15,000 PCU (passenger car unit), the corridor should be developed as a four-lane highway with a four-lane structure. If the traffic is between 15,000 to 25,000 PCU, the corridor should be of four-lane highway and six-lane structures, and if the traffic is 25,000-40,000 PCU, then it should be a six-lane highway with six-lane structures.

“Access should be planned with the objective that the long

● NEW DESIGN GUIDELINES

15,000 PCU (passenger car unit)	15,000-25,000 PCU,	25,000-40,000 PCU,
Corridor should be developed as a 4-lane highway with 4-lane structure	Corridor should be developed as a 4-lane highway and 6-lane structures	Corridor should be developed as a 6-lane highway with 6-lane structures



distance through traffic can operate at speed dictated by the flow on the main highway and

not by any other factors such as interference from local traffic, access traffic or cross traffic.

There shall be no at-grade intersection of any road with the project highway. Access to the project highway shall be through properly designed ramps at pedestrian locations,” said the NHAI.

It mandated that in areas characterised by frequent operation of heavy agriculture machinery, specifically harvesters and tractors with high laden farm produce, the height of underpass may be considered at 4.50 metres. The service road shall be provided in built-up and urban sections on both sides with drain cum footpath, said the authority.

Regarding road signage and markings, NHAI said full over-

head gantries carrying direction signs shall be placed 5 km and 2 km ahead of an exit, while cantilever gantries carrying advance direction signs shall be placed 1 km and 500 metres before the exit. The authority also mandated that lane and other markings be 150 mm wide, while edge-lane markings be 200 mm wide.

Barrier-less tolling, corridor protection

Since NHAI is already shifting towards a multi-lane free flow (MLFF), or barrier-less tolling system, it has also asked for provisions for the system to be incorporated into the layout of high-speed corridors.

“In order to prevent encroachment and unauthorized access on high-speed corridors, a 1 meter high RCC (reinforced cement concrete) boundary wall shall be constructed along the extreme outer edge of the ROW (right of way),” said the NHAI.

ROW, or right of way, refers to the total width of land legally acquired or owned by the government or road authority for construction, operation, maintenance, and future highway expansion.

The authority also said that drip irrigation will be provided in the median for watering of plants and tree plantation will be made an integral part of the project design at the DPR stage.



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• GEOPOLITICS

How Taiwan looms large in US-China ties



EXPERT EXPLAINS

LYLE MORRIS

SENIOR FELLOW AT ASIA SOCIETY POLICY INSTITUTE'S CENTER FOR CHINA ANALYSIS

DURING CHINESE President Xi Jinping’s visit to the US, issues such as tariffs and AI regulation were on the agenda. But for China, the most significant concern, perhaps, is US policy on Taiwan. Xi said in Washington, DC that “China hopes the US side will adhere to the correct position of opposing “Taiwan independence”... so as to lay a solid foundation for China-US strategic cooperation.”

China has made increasingly assertive historical claims to Taiwan, even as Taiwanese political leaders refer to themselves as functioning independently. How does it add to the complexities of US-China ties? **Lyle Morris**, of the US-based Asia Society Policy Institute, who also served in the Office of the US Secretary of Defense as Country Director for China, spoke to **Rishika Singh**.

What can be made of the visit so far?

In Donald Trump’s first term, his policies centred on strategic competition and trade with China. This view has evolved, largely due to his belief that his personal charm and business-centric approach can persuade autocratic leaders. It hasn’t worked well with Vladimir Putin, with no agreement on Ukraine.

With China, results are unclear. I give Trump credit for understanding the importance of respect in Chinese culture and going above and beyond to show that. But what comes next? During the trade war, when China restricted rare earths, the US lost its leverage. If this meeting yields agreement on AI principles or better personal rapport that prevents escalation in future crises, those are positive outcomes. But as far as a grand bargain is concerned, that ship has sailed.

Why is Taiwan so important for US foreign policy?

Before 1979, the US officially recognised Taiwan as representing China. Then the US and the mainland Chinese government signed three Joint Communiqués through 1982 that led them to recognise each other diplomatically, conditional on the US revoking recognition of Taiwan. They also stated that the US would gradually decrease its arms sales to Taiwan.

At the same time, the US put forth the Six Assurances — a classified memo to Taiwan — stating it had not agreed to an end date on arms sales. That balanced Taiwan’s feeling of being left behind.

The Taiwan Relations Act of 1979 has since formed the basis of unofficial US-Taiwan relations, with the US being its primary arms seller. We have a deep commitment to aid Taiwan’s defensive needs so they can credibly deter China from contemplating a military contingency. Previous US presidents understood that. Joe Biden even said at times that the US would intervene militarily, if needed, to defend Taiwan. Trump has softened that stance and echoed Xi’s talking points. That sends worrying signals to Taiwan while making China happy.

Last year, Trump signed off on a \$10-billion arms package to Taiwan, and another \$14-billion package will be the largest ever, once Trump clears it. It’s unclear if this has become a “red line of red lines” for Xi. Over the last decade, since TSMC in Taiwan became the world’s number one chip maker (chips or semiconductors are essential for producing key electronic components), supply chains have also assumed added significance for a potential conflict.

China might have tried to get the US to hold off on this package. Why is that?

I think Xi sees Trump as malleable on Taiwan. After they met in May in Beijing, Trump didn’t really reassert longstanding US policy on Taiwan, including arms sales. Xi and China see an opportunity to continue to press Trump and have him align with Beijing on Taiwan.

The next few days will reveal how Trump acts. He has clearly paused the package, perhaps to accommodate China in getting a bigger deal on trade and bilateral investments. In some ways, Trump is sacrificing Taiwan, and people I talked to in Taiwan feel a little left out to dry. I would predict that eventually, Trump will approve the package, but he will probably wait after this visit. If he doesn’t approve it, that’s a very worrying precedent.

How are these events influencing US’s partners?

Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi made explicit remarks on Taiwan last year, on a naval blockade being a “survival-threatening situation” for Japan. The whole region is concerned about what China is doing, including in the South China Sea. Countries are hedging, building up their militaries, and discussing joint exercises and evacuation contingencies with the United States because they are worried.

• POLITY

Conflict and consensus in the ECI’s functioning



DAMINI NATH

THE FUNCTIONING of the three-member Election Commission of India is under scrutiny this week, after an investigation by *The Indian Express* published on September 23 revealed that two Election Commissioners had placed their objections on record at least 14 times in 10 months. The Election Commission has responded by saying that the decisions taken by the Commission have been unanimous, saying that “observations” were a part of the deliberative process.

How does the Election Commission take decisions?

The Election Commission derives its powers from Article 324 of the Constitution, which provides for a Commission for the “superintendence, direction and control of the preparation of the electoral rolls for, and the conduct of, all elections to Parliament and to the Legislature of every State and of elections to the offices of President and Vice-President...”

It further says that the commission will consist of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and “such number of other Election Commissioners” that the President may appoint, subject to provisions of law. The CEC “shall act as the Chairman of the Election Commission”.

How the Election Commission is supposed to arrive at decisions is laid out in the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023.

Section 17 of the Act says that the “business of the Election Commission shall be transacted in accordance with the provisions of this Act.”

“The Election Commission may, by unanimous decision, regulate the procedure for transaction of its business and also allocation of its business amongst the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners. All business of the Election Commission shall, as far as possible, be transacted unanimously, and if the Chief Election Commissioner and other



Election Commissioners differ in opinion on any matter, such matter shall be decided according to the opinion of the majority,” Section 18 of the Act says.

Since the Election Commission currently has three members, if the decisions are not unanimous, two of the three members can decide the matter. While the Chief Election Commissioner chairs the poll panel, all three members — the CEC and the two ECs — all have one vote.

Have there been differences of opinion and dissent in the commission in the past?

Ever since the Election Commission was permanently expanded from a single-member body to a three-member commission in 1993, differences have emerged between the individuals who occupy the posts.

Then Chief Election Commissioner T N Seshan and Election Commissioners M S Gill and G V G Krishnamurthy were known to have clashed. In fact, Seshan had challenged the appointment of the two ECs in the Supreme Court, which upheld the appointment and ruled that the three members would have equal status.

The Supreme Court judgment in *T.N Seshan vs. Union of India* in 1995 made it

Election Commission office in New Delhi.

PRAVEEN KHANNA/FILE

First among equals

The Election Commission comprises the Chief Election Commissioner and two Election Commissioners. They are equal in rank and the CEC is the first among equals.

Any decision it takes must, ‘as far as possible’, be unanimous; otherwise, it is decided by a majority.

clear that the three members would have an equal say in decision-making.

In January 2009, then CEC N Gopalaswami had written to the President seeking the removal of Election Commissioner Navin Chawla, citing a “lack of political neutrality”. With no such action from Rashtrapati Bhavan, Chawla eventually was appointed CEC.

Election Commission officials say that differing opinions on matters before the commission, whether it is the conduct of elections or administrative matters, are a routine occurrence. However, when it comes to finally taking a decision, the commission takes a call unanimously or by majority. The Commission generally meets once or twice a week to discuss pending matters, officials say.

In case an Election Commissioner disagrees with the majority view, he or she can record a dissent note on the file.

Former Election Commissioner Ashok Lavasa had done exactly that in 2019, when he disagreed with the majority view of giving Prime Minister Narendra Modi and then BJP chief Amit Shah a clean chit on complaints of Model Code of Conduct violations before the commission. Lavasa had also objected that his dissent notes were not being recorded in the final orders passed

The rupture in the poll panel, revealed by an *Express* investigation, is not its first instance of difference of opinion. Here’s what happened in the past

by the commission. Lavasa, who was likely to take over as Chief Election Commissioner on the basis of seniority, opted to resign from the Commission in 2020.

Before the Election Commission issued its order starting the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls on June 24, 2025, Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu had observed on the draft order that the exercise should not lead to harassment to voters and citizens

“Care should be taken that genuine voters/citizens, particularly old, sick, PwD (persons with disabilities), poor and other vulnerable groups do not feel harassed and are facilitated,” Sandhu had written. However, this, EC sources said, was an observation, and eventually the SIR order was unanimous.

Since then, as *The Indian Express* has reported, ECs Sandhu and Vivek Joshi have recorded their objections on files several times, whether it relates to the functioning of the poll commission’s IT infrastructure or the insertion of a new declaration in the voter enrolment form (Form 6).

What has the Election Commission said on the matter?

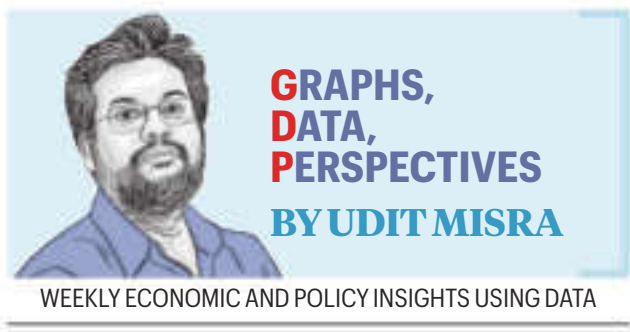
In a press statement on Wednesday, the Election Commission sought to differentiate between observations, which it said were standard and a part of the internal checks and balances, and decisions of the Commission.

“Any operational queries or inputs raised by Commission members during draft stages are part of standard administrative practice aimed at safeguarding voter rights. The suggestions given by the Commissioners were for further improving the electoral processes. Differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution. They are a part of the decision-making process before a final decision is taken. Not only the three Commissioners, but every officer of the Commission is fully authorized to give his suggestions to the Commission for improving the electoral system,” the poll panel said.

The Election Commission has said that all decisions taken in recent months have been the outcome of “unanimous decisions”. It cited the recent elections in Bihar, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Assam and West Bengal, saying that these polls required “wide-ranging administrative and operational machinery and many Commission approvals and instructions.”

• ECONOMICS

Displacing the dollar: Why the yuan is falling short



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping’s visit to the US and his meeting with US President Donald Trump comes at a time when the global economy is buffeted by uncertainty.

Apart from the wars in Ukraine and Iran, global trade has also been affected by the tensions between the world’s two biggest economies, especially as Trump continues to levy punitive tariffs on all and sundry.

The ensuing disruption, be it in the form of higher prices or reduced foreign investments, often hurts smaller and poorer economies such as India the most.

China is still some distance away from overtaking the US — its GDP (or gross domestic product, the measure of the size of an economy) is around \$21 trillion while the US’s is at around \$32 trillion. But China has easily become the second biggest economic power on the planet since it already dwarfs the Euro area (at less than \$20 trillion) in total economic size.

China’s rise over the past 20 years has not only been spectacular but has also been in sharp contrast to the economic stagnation in European economies.

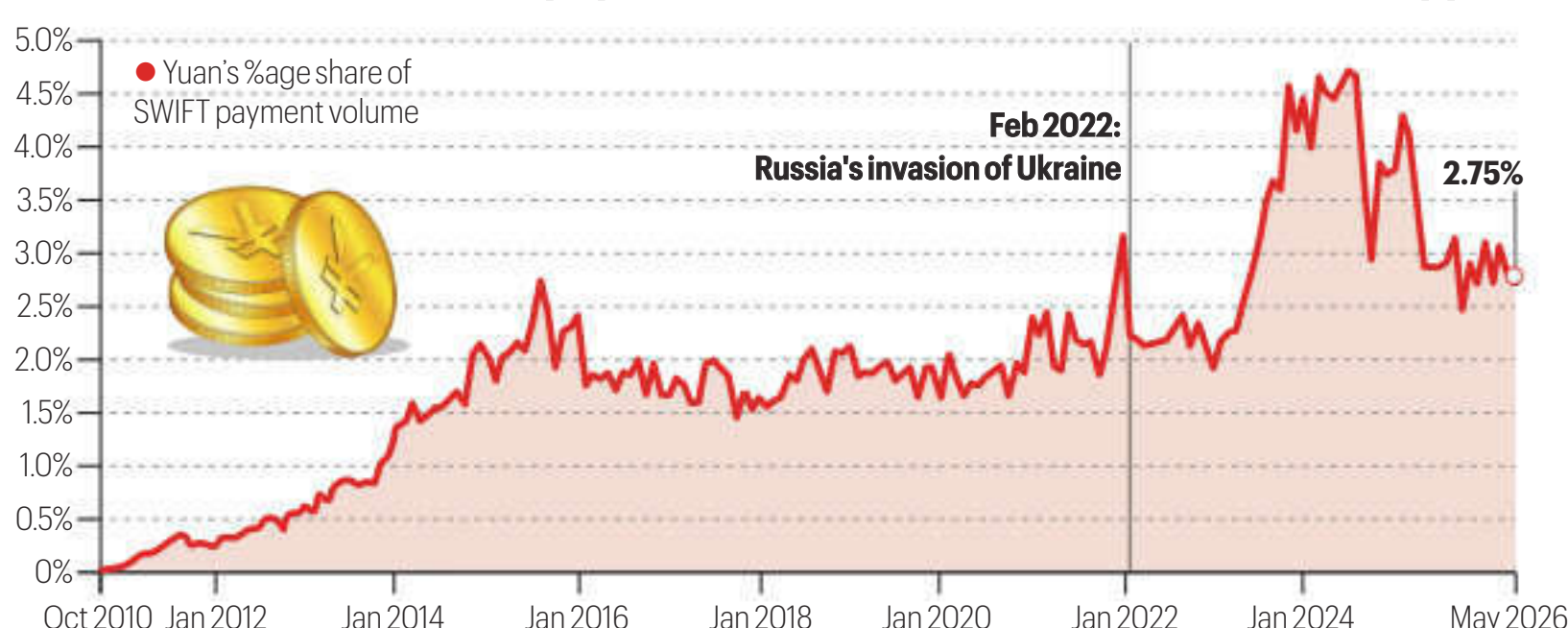
Its growing dominance over the global order has led to a natural query: Can the Chinese currency, yuan, rival or even trump the US dollar as the global currency of choice? This question assumes greater relevance as the US policy decisions become increasingly ad hoc, violating global norms and often weaponising the US dollar.

The ‘privilege’ of the US dollar

To be sure, everyone on the planet (be it an individual or another country’s central bank) is happy to trust the US dollar. They would park their savings in US dollars (or in dollar-denominated assets) or settle trade amongst each other using that currency instead of their own currencies. This gives the US economy great power, allowing the country to live beyond its means.

Here’s how. When the US wants to buy more goods from the rest of the world, it can simply print more dollars to pay for it. The other party accepts these because it trusts the US economy and its governance system. What’s more, the other party uses these new dollars to buy US bonds, either

• Yuan’s use in international payments rose after Russia’s invasion, then dipped



NOTE: SWIFT STANDS FOR SOCIETY FOR INTERBANK FINANCIAL TELECOMMUNICATIONS. SOURCE: PIIE, SWIFT

issued by the government or other big US companies.

This way the lending party can make some profit on their dollars while being assured that it is the safest investment on the planet, because no one thinks the US will default on its debt.

No other country enjoys this so-called “exorbitant privilege” that the dollar confers on the US.

If India prints more money to buy more goods from the rest of the world, all that excess money will stay in India since no one outside wants to hold Indian rupees. In turn, all that excess printing of money will lead to a spike in prices within the country (domestic inflation) because everyone in India would have more money chasing the same amount of goods and services.

It is because the US dollar has become the trusted medium of exchange globally that the country’s economy has got this superpower.

The Chinese challenge

The trust in the US dollar is, in essence, a trust in the continued strength of the US economy and the robustness of the rule of law in the country. But it is also true that for a while now — since World War II, in fact — there has been no single country that could rival the US in terms of economic might.

Over the past few years, the discourse has changed on both counts.

For one, US decision-making is increasingly at odds with the rules-based global order the country itself helped create. Trump’s punitive tariffs are but one example. One can also cite the removal of

Economic might is not enough

● China’s growing economic might and the US’s increasingly erratic policy decisions raise questions on whether the yuan can mount a challenge to the dollar.
● But doing so requires much more than economic strength. Global trust requires China and its government to play fair and by globally-accepted rules.

Russian banks from the SWIFT system — in response to its 2022 invasion of Ukraine — that was led by the US (under Joe Biden) and other Western countries. SWIFT is a global financial messaging service, dominated by the US, which is the cornerstone for money transfers across the world.

Amid these developments, trust in the usage of the US dollar has eroded on the margin. This has happened at a time when China has not only grown big enough in economic might to rival the US but has also increasingly pitched its currency as an alternative to settle global transactions.

The yuan’s rise and fall

Given the overwhelming dominance of the US dollar in the global economy — more than 50% of all transactions are done in dollars and more than 50% of the global foreign exchange is stored in dollars, etc — knocking off the US dollar completely is a bridge too far for any currency.

The yuan, however, did gain considerable ground among users in the wake of the Russia-Ukraine war.

As a new research paper from the Peterson Institute for International Economics (PIIE) pointed out recently (*see chart*), yuan’s share in the SWIFT network, the global standard for payment messages between banks, “spiked after sanctions imposed by every major reserve currency issuer made Russia and other countries more willing to use the yuan”.

By July 2024, yuan’s share of global payments was at 4.7%, overtaking the Japanese yen and Canadian dollar to become the fourth most used currency in the world.

The other two were the euro and the British pound. Since then, however, its share has fallen back to 2.75%, leaving it the sixth most used currency. Dollar’s share is closer to 50% in SWIFT.

Is the yuan challenge over?

There are two ways to look at yuan’s future prospects.

The first is to look at other sets of data to understand yuan’s attractiveness.

The PIIE paper by Martin Chorzempa points out that more and more banks globally are signing up for China’s Cross Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS). CIPS settles payments in yuan instead of dollars. Data shows that more and more payments are being settled in yuan on CIPS over the past couple of years, even as the currency has lost ground on the SWIFT platform.

In other words, CIPS’s trajectory suggests that an increasing share of payments using the yuan are bypassing the SWIFT network. “It is a sign that China is prioritizing resilience to potential future sanctions and self-sufficiency, even at the risk of diverging from global payment standards,” writes Chorzempa.

The second way to look at this issue is to ask a more fundamental question: Can the world trust China?

The global trust in the US dollar is not just about the size of the US economy. What is equally, possibly more, important for the trust in the dollar is the way the US economy is run on the basis of clear-cut rules, well laid-out limitations on the arbitrary actions of the government, transparency of data, existence of a free media, as well as independent and fair courts of justice. All of these components come together over time, along with massive economic might, to afford the US the privilege of the dollar being the go-to currency for the planet.

At present, the US is struggling on many of these counts. It was quite symbolic that on a day when China’s President visited the White House, sections of the US media were refused entry thanks to an illegal and arbitrary ban by the US President.

But China cannot even pretend to have similar freedoms. Global trust requires China and its government to play fair and by the globally-accepted rules. In the absence of well-founded, independent and constitutionally-secured institutions in China, the yuan may never be able to become the global benchmark, regardless of what happens to the dollar.



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9 Noida (New)	5 अक्टूबर दोपहर 3:00 बजे	12 Oct 11:00 AM
9 Indore	23 सितंबर सुबह 8:00 बजे	21 Sept 11:00 AM
9 Lucknow	30 सितंबर सुबह 11:30 बजे	29 Sept 11:30 AM
9 Prayagraj	28 सितंबर सुबह 11:15 बजे	30 Sept 11:30 AM
9 Ranchi	22 सितंबर सुबह 8:00 बजे	Admissions Open
9 Patna	25 सितंबर शाम 5:30 बजे	5 Oct 2:30 PM
9 Jaipur	23 सितंबर शाम 5:00 बजे	21 Sept 11:00 AM
9 Pune (New Launch)	English Medium	5 October 5:30 PM

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Humdrum, only to numb



Shubhra Gupta

SOME FILMS are bad. Some are terrible. And some are pure torture. *The Vvaan* falls neatly into that third category, in which I struggled to find a single redeeming feature, and failed spectacularly.

When we first come upon a Mumbai-based engineer (Sidharth Malhotra) and his wife (Tamannaah Bhatia), childless but certainly not loveless, they are a) singing songs in a large sea-side bungalow, b) fetching up at a quack who hands out potency powders and c) participating in a hideous racist-colourist joke.

The Vvaan never recovers from this early blow. Nor did I, as the film kept drawing me deeper into an off-colour, off-putting mix of so-called fantasy and folklore, of the kind that involves dark forests and their resident guardian *devis*, and evil spirits which devour those who dare walk into their domain after dark.

Said engineer and wife arrive in a village in which live his elder brother (Anup Soni) and perpetually-annoyed wife (Shweta Tiwari) to sort out some property matters, said property being inside the haunted forest.

THE VVAAN: FORCE OF THE FORREST ★
DIRECTOR: Deepak Kumar Mishra
CAST: Sidharth Malhotra, Tamannaah Bhatia, Anup Soni, Sunil Grover

ing Sidharth-and-Tamannaah a chance to swing it.

Rationalist engineer pooh-poohs all *reeti-rivaaj* and *puraani-pratha*, with his family hoping he will come to his senses soon. But that would mean no film, right? So out come wispy CGI monsters, horned bulls with divine power, and *devis* with, well, *devi shakti*. Much footage is spent on pretty *puja thaalis*, and ladies in red adorned with elaborate *teekas* which don't budge while submerged in rivers, and staged fights between hero and villain, helped by humans and benign supernatural beings.

An alleged comedy strand features the hero's pal (Maniesh Paul), stalking a random elderly lady (Sulabha Arya) doing random crazy things. Clearly, Bollywood's idea of broad comedy hasn't moved an inch in all these decades.

When not rescuing Tamannaah from a watery grave, Sidharth is climbing snowy mountains and shouldering holy relics down the slope, very Prabhas-like. Meanwhile, all ideas of a coherent plot and even the faintest bit of sense, leave the chat.

Somewhere in all this, a character says, '*meri maddad kar*', plucking the thought right from my numbed brain.

Cry for Justice

Shubhra Gupta

THE RAMPAGE of *dhongi babas*, spell-bound *bhaktis* and shell-shocked victims continues apace.

The fresh spate began in 2020 with Bobby Deol spreading his beatific smile and vile ways through the multi-season *Ashram*. In 2023, we saw Manoj Bajpayee fighting a lone battle against a powerful self-styled godman — based on the real-life Asaram — in *Sirf Ek Baada Kaafi Hai*. That was followed by Jaideep Ahlawat jumping into the role of the rapacious 'Maharaj' in a

While the hunkkaar comes at the expected juncture, the rest of the series doesn't quite measure up to that fearless girl for stepping up and speaking out

film of the same name in 2024.

Now comes *Hunkkaar*, in which the excellent Raghubir Yadav plays Baapji, the all-seeing seer who preys upon young girls. While the casting seems, at first glance, to be inspired — I mean, the always likeable Yadav turning into a monster, can you imagine — not being able to overcome the utter familiarity of the subject never allows *Hunkkaar* to become its own beast.

Which is a pity because it has a couple



This Bark has Bite

Shalini Langer

AMAN and his dog walk across 58 miles of Alaska wilderness, fighting a heart attack, plane crash, injury, bears, wolves, drowning.

David Ayer and Brad Pitt collaborate for the second time, after *Fury*, for this unlikely film about a bond between a retired US Special Forces Sergeant Major and his combat scout dog. A bond that has been forged during one of those indistinguishable and bloody tours of duty that America keeps rushing into.

The PTSD that follows afflicts not just James (Pitt) but also Odin, and the two are spending time now in a part of Alaska that is even more isolated than the rest of it. They have no company but each other — barring a visit by a mysterious retired gold miner played gamely by Simmons.

And beyond their two trunks of essentials carrying everything from medicines and maps to food and clothes, and a belt with pouches carrying more of the same tied around Odin, they don't need anyone else.

However, the peaceful escape of James and Odin into "the quiet of nature" — broken only faintly by the swish of wind, the call of birds, the rustle of rushing water in a stream, or that dripping off leaves after a bout of rain — ends abruptly.

What follows is the walk, to find help, with James's body put through the kind of injuries and pain that would kill any mortal who doesn't have a dog like Odin by their side, or the training of a US Special Forces personnel, or a camping kit of a well-prepared American.

That *Heart of the Beast* is as gripping as it is, and deeply moving, is due to Pitt. The star with his undeniable charm has embraced his age, and both the length of those years and the depth of his time spent with Odin — and

HEART OF THE BEAST

★★★★

DIRECTOR: David Ayer

CAST: Brad Pitt, JK Simmons

the strength he derives from this — are etched on his face and reflect in his eyes. Odin, played by four different German Shepherds, is in sync with James's every mood and movement, his eyes constantly searching, weighing.

But for unnecessary flashbacks to whatever war James and Odin were in last, leaving Odin with an amputated leg, Ayer doesn't deviate from their story. Or from Alaska. The perils of this path are entirely common, nothing dramatic about them or anything particularly heroic in how James and Odin survive. The tussle with the wolves, though, may leave you with nightmares.

Eventually, the film does have one too many perils. A few near rescues or some more quieter flashback moments may have helped give a break.

Yet, when James and Odin huddle quietly in a tent, the two of them against the dark outside, you can't help but feel like an intruder.



SHAQUE: TRUST NO ONE

★★★

DIRECTOR: Rensil D'Silva

CAST: Parineeti Chopra, Jennifer Winget, Harleen Sethi, Tahir Raj Bhasin, Anup Soni

STREAMING ON: Netflix

missing as she is not in the nursery with the other infants, the first port of call; the CCTV in the corridor isn't working; and the investigating cops, led by the doughty Anup Soni, turn up nothing useful.

Even though Shimla has been such a popular destination in the movies, there's something about the hills which make you feel that there are spots right behind leafy trails where mysteries lurk. Sure enough, there's a *baba-tantrik* type in the undergrowth, whose job it is to cast evil spells. A human trafficking ring is flourishing, to which the otherwise alert cops seem oblivious. Tribal women are being used as surrogates. Illicit affairs are being carried on, with at least one party admitting that they

knew all along, and another professing deep surprise.

Clearly, there's a lot going on. But as it winds its way around the bends of the very busy plot, stuffed with characters who appear straightforward but who, keeping with the tone and title, harbour dark secrets, it becomes clear that the show doesn't want you to work hard. The continuous little reveals are presented along with spell-out motivation followed by explanatory dialogue, with a few loops on repeat: for a woman struggling with unprocessed grief, grabbing at baby girls, and breaking down hysterically, can't just be done once. When this happens with yet another mother (Jennifer Winget), everything starts to unravel even faster.

Contrivances in a show like this are never the problem, because yes, babies do disappear and yes, some people never really recover, and yes, of course, strange things happen all the time. But you have to make those twists convincing: the zeal to keep the hard-working Chopra — looking as natural as she can, never buried under make-up — in the forefront means that the other parts feel undercooked.

Shaque: Trust No One reminds me very much of your standard undemanding Harlan Cohen shows: The actors are all competent, and there are some random moments of suspense, but it all feels forced, and the outcome stays determinedly mid. So mid, in fact, that I kept falling out of it.

Mum's the Word

Shalini Langer

THE REAL Chris Hansen is not happy. *Primetime*, which is based on Hansen's successful but short-lived TV show *To Catch a Predator*, is "a complete work of fiction attached to a real name", Hansen has said. The filmmakers have acted in an "exploitative or predatory manner", he says.

Irony hardly has it this good. *To Catch a Predator* involved Hansen and producers baiting paedophiles using adult actors who pretended to be children as decoys, and then filming them, following which police swooped in to arrest the men. Police were often in the loop, for their own reasons. The show that ran between 2004 and 2008 on NBC, ended abruptly when one of the "targets" shot himself on camera.

Documentary filmmaker Lance Oppenheim bathes *Primetime* in grainy, dark lighting, shifting between the film and the TV show within it continuously, in a relentless, rather performative effort to show that he treats all this very solemnly. What "all this" is, though, is a different matter.

Is this a comment on the media, on the voyeuristic nature of reality TV, on the price of success, or on the headiness of being seen as a vigilante? Oppenheim hints at everything without really making a convincing argument about anything. The stylistic flourishes the film resorts to in aid of this high-minded effort seem self-aggrandising.

Robert Pattinson does unlikeable well, despite his good looks. And here, he really digs his teeth in. His Hansen is a work of oily insincerity and insecurity, who has convinced

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



Don't Be Shy

PRIME VIDEO

DON'T BE Shy follows Shyamili 'Shy' Das, a 20-year-old who believes she has her life all figured out — until an unexpected turn sets her carefully planned world spiralling. Written and

directed by Sreeti Mukerji, the YA romcom is produced by Alia Bhatt's Eternal Sunshine Productions. The film features four newcomers — Aarushi Bajaj, Piyush Khati, Bianca Arora and Ansh Duggal — alongside Kunal Roy Kapur, Anurag Basu, Neha Dhupia and Anju Alva Naik in pivotal roles.



This Tempting Madness

LIONSGATE PLAY

MIA'S LIFE is thrown into uncertainty when she wakes up from a coma following a near-fatal fall. She learns that her husband has been arrested for attempting to murder her. Determined to understand what really happened, Mia begins piecing together fragments of her past. As her brother and husband pull her in opposing directions, Mia finds herself caught between love and suspicion. Led by Simone Ashley, alongside Austin Stowell and Suraj Sharma, the film is directed by Jennifer E Montgomery.



The Love Hypothesis

PRIME VIDEO

BASED ON the novel by Ali Hazelwood, *The Love Hypothesis* follows Olive, a brilliant PhD candidate focused on her future.

But when she realises her best friend Anh has fallen for her crush Jeremy, Olive impulsively kisses professor Adam Carlsen to prove she has moved on. What begins as an act of desperation spirals into a fake, mutually beneficial agreement. The film is directed by Claire Scanlon and stars Lili Reinhart and Tom Bateman in lead roles.

Midsommar

JIHOTSTAR

NEWLY ADDED to the streamer's slate is the much-talked-about *Midsommar*. This 2019 folk horror film is written and directed by Ari Aster. Starring Florence Pugh and Jack Reynor as an American couple, the film follows them as they travel to rural Sweden and become entangled with a sinister cult and its increasingly violent rituals. The supporting cast includes William Jackson Harper, Vilhelm Blomgren, Ellora Torchia, Archie Madekwe and Will Poulter.

ALAKA SAHANI



PRIMETIME

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Lance Oppenheim

CAST: Robert Pattinson, Merritt Wever, Skyler Gisondo, Matthew Maher, Phoebe Bridgers

himself that he is doing the right thing and talks about a fantastical past in India, which may or may not be true. But, Pattinson's one-tone performance has no depth.

Merritt Wever gets little to do except wring her hands as the producer of *To Catch a Predator*, who has an increasingly egomaniacal and unpredictable star at hand. How her character Andy landed the gig, which may be headed for prime time history, is hard to imagine.

Skyler Gisondo plays Dan, the actor being used as a decoy to catch various men. He hopes this is his foot in the door to do bigger stuff but has growing doubts about playing a 13-year-old for a few minutes in every episode, before Hansen walks in and "catches" the predator.

Primetime also ends on a very dubious note, dodging the questions of who pays when a TV show goes too far and where to draw the line.

But then, there has been hardly a dip in Hansen's own career graph. He has won several awards and continues to run a true-crime streaming network and to investigate online predators. That says a lot.

Given its ambiguity over what it wants to say, *Primetime* chooses silence.



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BOLANGIR

e-Procurement Notice
25001/1204/2627

1. Name of work	Construction of Bridge in the district of Bolangir and Subarnapur under SBY for the year 2026-27					
2. No. of works	19 (Nineteen) works					
3. Time for completion	varies from 12 (Twelve) to 18 (Eighteen) Calendar months					
4. Approximate estimated cost	varies from Rs. 300.92 lakhs to Rs. 825.26 lakhs					
5. Mode of Submission of tender	Tender should be submitted online in www.tendersodisha.gov.in					
6. Other details are as follow						
Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on line for bidding	Last date and time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of Tender		
	From To	From To		Technical Bid	Financial Bid	
Chief Construction Engineer, R.W Circle, Bolangir	BLGR. Online- 21/2026-27	12.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	27.10.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.	26.10.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.	28.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	
The date will be intimated later on						

- Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in
- Any Corrigendum/Addendum will be displayed in the above e tender website only.

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
R. W. Circle, Bolangir

OIPR-25001/25118/1/26-27/0023



UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LTD.
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
ELECTRICITY DISTRIBUTION CIRCLE 33/11 KV SUB
STATION CAMPUS TANAKPUR CHAMPAAWAT-262309
E-Mail:- edc.champawat@upcl.org



उत्तराखण्ड पावर कॉर्पोरेशन लि०
कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता विद्युत वितरण मण्डल 33/11 के०वी० उपसंस्थान टनकपुर चम्पावत-262309
E-Mail:- edc.champawat@upcl.org

पत्रांक- 3484/विद्युत (च.) /
दिनांक 24/09/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

विद्युत वितरण मण्डल चम्पावत निम्नानुसार ई० निविदा आमंत्रित करता है।

क्र०सं- 01 वि०वि०स० चम्पावत से पूर्व में आमंत्रित ई० निविदा संख्या 48/2026-27/EDC (CH), 49/2026-27/EDC (CH), 50/2026-27/EDC (CH) एवं 51/2026-27/EDC (CH) को अंतिमलाई निविदा जमा व खुलने की तिथि विस्तारित कर निविदा जमा की तिथि 12/10/2026 एवं खुलने की तिथि 13/10/2026 की जाती है। निविदा की अन्य शर्तें पूर्वदा रहेगी।

क्र०सं- 02

निविदा सं०	निविदा कार्य का नाम व संक्षिप्त विवरण	निविदा मूल्य (जी०एस०टी० सहित)	निविदा धरोहर	निविदा ऑन लाईन व ऑफ लाईन जमा की अंतिम तिथि व समय	निविदा ऑनलाइन खुलने की तिथि व समय	निविदा ऑनलाइन खुलने की तिथि व समय
52/ 2026-27 /EDC(CH)	केपिटल एस०आई० मद में वि०वि०स० चम्पावत के उपसंस्थान लोहापुर से निकलने वाले वाराकोट एवं मुला पोषक में स्थापित 100/63 के०वी०ए० परिवर्तकों में ए०सी०वी० एवं एस०सी०सी०वी० की स्थापना व अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 5,900/-	₹ 1,61,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (10:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (10:30 AM)
53/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	केपिटल एस०आई० मद में वि०वि०स० चम्पावत के देवीपुर एवं खेतीखान सेक्शन में स्थापित 100/63 के०वी०ए० परिवर्तकों में ए०सी०वी० एवं एस०सी०सी०वी० की स्थापना व अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 2,360/-	₹ 75,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (11:30 AM)
54/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	ओ० एण्ड एस० मद में वि०वि०स० चम्पावत के उपखण्ड टनकपुर के अन्तर्गत ए०वी० लाइन हेतु स्थानीय सामग्री की अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 1,180/-	₹ 68,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (12:00 PM)	14-10-2026 (12:30 PM)
55/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	ओ० एण्ड एस० मद में वि०वि०स० चम्पावत के उपसंस्थान लोहापुर से निकलने वाले मुला, सलना, गुलगांव एवं पॉलिटेक्निक पोषको के अन्तर्गत लाइन, परिवर्तक व उपसंस्थान का अनुसूची एवं उपयोक्ता शिक्कावत निवारण का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 5,900/-	₹ 1,08,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (13:00 PM)	14-10-2026 (13:30 PM)

निविदा सम्बन्धित अधिक जानकारी, नियम व शर्तों हेतु प्रथम ई० निविदा की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर देखें। विद्युत बिलों के 24x7 ऑनलाइन भुगतान हेतु www.upcl.org पर जाएं। Customer Toll Free No-1800 419 0405"

"सद्द हित में बिजली बचाये"

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
विद्युत वितरण मण्डल चम्पावत

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR
OFFICE THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PWD (R&B)
CIRCLE SOUTH JAMMU
TENDER NOTICE INVITING

e-NIT No.SESJ/22 of 2026-27

Dated 22-09-2026

For and on behalf of the Lt. Governor of Union Territory of J&K, e-tenders are invited on percentage rate basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K/CPWD / BRO/ Railways/ MES and other State/ Central Government for the work mentioned below:-

S. No	Name of Work	Advertised Cost	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit in the form of CDR/FDR/ BG	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
Executive Engineer, PWD(R&B)Division, Gandhi Nagar							
1.	Macadamization of Marshalling Yard, PWD Workshop, Transport Nagar, Jammu (Under Capex Budget 2025-26).	Rs. 253.35 lacs	6000/-	2% of the advertised cost Rs.506700/-	04 Months	At or after 1200 hrs on 14-10-2026	'A' Class

Position of AAA :- Sanctioned
Position of Tech. sanction :- Sanctioned

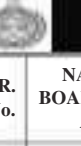
The Bidding documents Consist of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jktenders.gov.in> as per below schedule:-

1. Date of Issue of Tender Notice	22.09.2026
2. Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 22.09.2026 to 13.10.2026, 1800 Hrs
3. Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	07.10.2026 at 1400 hours in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
4. Bid submission Start Date	22.09.2026 From 1800 Hrs
5. Bid Submission End Date	13.10.2026 up to 1800 Hrs
6. Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	14.10.2026 at 1200 hours in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
7. Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

No:-SESJ/DB/5945-52
Dated:-22-09-2026

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
PWD (R&B)Circle South Jammu

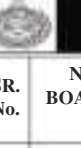
DIP/J-11105/26- DATE 25.09.2026



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HARYANA ROADWAYS ENG'G CORPN., GURUGRAM	PROVIDING MANPOWER FOR FABRICATION OF HARYANA SHAKTI DISTRICT TYPE ALL METAL BUS BODIES COMPLETE BUS WORK ON TATA BUS CHASSIS ALONGWITH SPARE WHEEL BOX.	25.09.2026 12.10.2026	92.82 LACS	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	9250570002 gm.hrec27@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49648/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, FARIDABAD	LIFTING OF MUNICIPAL SOLID WASTE FOR 6 MONTHS FROM GVP AND NON-GVP POINTS (HOT SPOTS, STREET SWEEPING, VACANT PLOTS WASTE ETC) TO TRANSFER STATION FROM VARIOUS WARDS UNDER WEST ZONE CLUSTER OF DTCT, MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, FARIDABAD +1	24.09.2026 15.10.2026	1262 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 memandeep188@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49654/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HVPN	PROCUREMENT OF 11 KV 13 PANEL BOARD VACUUM TYPE SWITCHGEAR (1250A) IN HVPNL(PANCHKULA)	26.09.2026 27.10.2026	EMD 5,600,000/-	PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN	0172-258378 PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN
2	HVPN	PROCUREMENT OF 11 KV 15 PANEL BOARD VACUUM TYPE SWITCHGEAR (2000A) IN HVPNL(PANCHKULA)	26.09.2026 27.10.2026	EMD 10,426,952.06/-	PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN	0172-258378 PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN

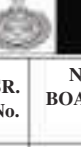
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49655/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	BOARD OF SCHOOL EDUCATION HARYANA, BHIWANI	PRINTING AND SUPPLY OF ANSWER BOOKS FOR SEC./SR.SEC./D.LED.ED. EXAMINATION YEAR 2026-2027	24.09.2026 15.10.2026	RS. 2,50,00,000/-	http://www.bsesh.org.in	7988665495 ascc@bsesh.org.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49681/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, ROHTAK	ESTIMATE FOR REPAIR AND RENOVATION OF SERVICE CLUB, M.C ROHTAK.	24.09.2026 01.10.2026	21 LACS	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	9467717422 engg-rohtak@ulbharyana.gov.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49653/HRY



AXIS FINANCE LIMITED
(An Unlisted Public Limited Company)
Axis House, C-2, Wadia International Centre, Parkside Budhkar
Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025

Under Section 13 (2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules"). Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Finance Limited (AFL) under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Rules already issued detailed Demand Notice dated below under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Guarantor(s) (all singularly or together referred to "Obligors")/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) listed hereunder, to pay the amount mentioned in the respective Demand Notice, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice, as per details given below. Copies of the said Notices are served by Registered Post A.D. and are available with the undersigned, and the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s), may, if they so desire, collect the respective copy from the undersigned on any working day during normal office hours.

In connection with the above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Obligor(s) /Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) to pay to AFL, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice/s, the amount indicated herein below against their respective names, together with further interest as detailed below from the respective dates mentioned below in column (d) till the date of payment and / or realization, read with the loan agreement and other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Obligor(s). As security for due repayment of the loan, the following Secured Asset(s) have been mortgaged to AFL by the said Obligor(s) respectively.

Sr. No	Loan Account No.	Name of Obligor(s)/ Legal Heir(s)/ Legal Representative(s)	DETAILS OF SECURED ASSET	Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.) as on below date	Date of Demand Notice	Date of NPA
1.	0456MMA00011710	Lord Ganesh Education Society, Ravi Kumar, Naveen Kumar, Renu Bala, Ramesh (Since Deceased, through Legal Heirs), Lilo, Hans Raj, Sushil Kumar & Anupama	All the piece and parcel of the Property bearing no. – Property Building Property i.e. Part of Bearing Khawat No. 532 min, Khatoni No.836 Min, Khasra No. 41/24-7-11, 58/42-4-4, measuring 11K-15M, situated at Village Shodia Bishnoiyan, Tehsil Adampur District Hissar Fatehabad Haryana-125052 and same is bounded as under: East :-Agri Land of Ramesh West :-Shubhash Agri Loand North :-Main Road South :-Agri Land	INR 28,04,911/- (Rupees Twenty Eight Lakhs Four Thousand Nine Hundred Eleven Only) as on 08th September 2026	21.09.2026	03.09.2026

*with further interest, additional Interest at the rate as more particularly stated in respective Demand Notices dated mentioned above, incidental expenses, costs, charges etc incurred till the date of payment and/or realization. If the said Obligor(s) shall fail to make payment to AFL as aforesaid, then AFL shall proceed against the above Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property (ies) under Section 13(4) of the said Act and the applicable Rules entirely at the risk of the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) as to the costs and consequences. The said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) are prohibited under the said Act to transfer the aforesaid Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property(ies), whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of AFL. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the Act or Rules made thereunder shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Place: Fatehabad, Haryana

For Axis Finance Limited
Authorised Officer



POSTGRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH, CHANDIGARH

TENDER NOTICE

Sealed tenders are invited from the manufacturers or their sole authorized distributors/sole agents on the prescribed form for below mention items for two years.

Sr. No.	Name of Drug/Material
1.	Inj. Fentanyl Citrate 100mcg/2ml amp.
2.	Lidocaine Lozenges 200mg/unit.
3.	Isabgol Hcg 100gm.
4.	Neomycin 3400 + Bcitracin400 + Polymyxin B 5000 units/gm, 10gm powder
5.	Rate Contract for "Discount on Maximum Retail Price (MRP) of Drugs/Medicines under Local Purchase" for Patient and PGI staff from licensed Chemist/Druggist holder, who has shop/service outlet at Chandigarh on emergency basis to cater day-to-day requirements for two years.

The Pre-Bid meeting for drugs mentioned at sr. no. 1 and 5 is to be held on 29.09.2026 at 03:15PM in the office of Superintendent Dispensary, Room No. 18A, Ground Floor, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh.

The Tender Form and specification of the products are available on the institute website www.pgimer.nic.in and eprocure.gov.in. Above mentioned tenders will be received by 12:30 Hours on 13.10.2026 (Due date) in the office of Prof. In-charge (EP), Room No 18-A, Nehru Hospital, Drugs & Dressing Section, Ground Floor, PGIMER, Chandigarh and will be opened at 02:30 PM on the same date at Committee Room Medical Superintendent office, Ground Floor, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh.

Officer In-charge (HPD), Proc. Drugs & Dressing

राजस्थान सरकार
कार्यालय अधीशाषी अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग खण्ड किशनगढ़बास
Email: celalwar2.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in & pwdalwar2@rediffmail.com

क्रमांक:-1654
दिनांक:- 22.09.2026

NIT No 12/2026-27
Bids are Invited Const. of Missing Link roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/02/ML/2026-27, Const. of Missing Link roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/03/ML/2026-27, Renewal of Non Patchable roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/07/NP/2026-27, Civil works in DJ Court Khairthal Building at Kishangarh Bas HQ & Patan Mewan road to Nimbhara Ki Aur Via Ismal Ki Dhani are invited from interested bidders upto 12.10.2026 time 6:00 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be seen on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 787.27 Lacs.
NIB No. PWD2627A2847
UBN No. PWD2627WSOB12791, PWD2627WSOB12792
PWD2627WSOB12793, PWD2627WSOB12794
PWD2627WSOB12795

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
DIPR/C/16340/2026 PWD Div KISHANGARH BAS



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD (BAR) BRANCH, SIRSA	SPECIAL REPAIR ESTIMATE FOR AGRICULTURE COTTON BUILDING AT SIRSA IN SIRSA DISTRICT.	24.09.2026 05.10.2026	1,09,51,655/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01665220530 pwt-ecpd@sirsa@hry.nic.in
2	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE DEPARTMENT YAMUNANAGAR.	CONSTRUCTION OF RETAINING WALL AT VILLAGE KHOL, FATEHGARH BLOCK CHHACHRAULI, DISTT. -YAMUNANAGAR.	23.09.2026 30.09.2026	2,51,93,77/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9991166622 acoyayunanagar25@gmail.com
3	PWD BAR, HISAR	RECONSTRUCTION AND STRENGTHENING OF DUNGS. ROADS (1) PATTAN TO HINDRAW ROAD RD 0.00 TO 4.286 (ROAD ID 10614) (2) GORICHA TO MEHRUA ROAD RD 0.00 TO 4.286 (ROAD ID 10615) (3) BALSAMAND SARSAHA TO SARSAHA ABADI RD 0.00 TO 0.250 (ROAD ID 5048) IN HISAR DISTT. (NALWA CONSTITUENCY WORK PROGRAMME 2026-27) (GROUP NO. 6)	CLOSING DATE 01.10.2026	4,63,95,578/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384999 pwt-ecpd@hisar@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ BHIWANI	CONST. OF IPB RASTA FROM PWD ROAD TO FIO MAHENDER S/O KARYSINGH VILLAGE -RATERA BLOCK -BAWANI KHERA.	24.09.2026 29.09.2026	51,04,018/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 premseng.bhw@hry.nic.in
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ BHIWANI	COMPLETION OF GRAM SACHIVALYA AT VILL- GORIPUR BLOCK BHIWANI. + 3 WORKS	24.09.2026 29.09.2026	45,04,469/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 premseng.bhw@hry.nic.in

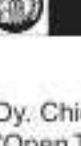
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No.49674/HRY**



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/ CORP./A UTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HVPNL	TENDER REF NO. 2026GEFPA04 39E34E8B3FF609946114B197HVP FOR REPAIR AND MAINTENANCE WORK IN QUARTER NO 8-B/1/5-B/12-A/2 AT RESIDENTIAL BUILDING MEHRALI ROAD HVPNL GURUGRAM (ONLINE TENDER REF. ID 2026_HBC_540992_1.)	18.09.2026 05.10.2026	2,78,447/-	www.hvpnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
2	HVPNL	CREATION OF 33 KV BAY AT 132 KV SUBSTATION JUNDLA TO ACCOMMODATE THE CREATION OF 33 KV S/STN BANSA, CHIRAO ROAD AND CAPACITOR BANK AND AUGMENTATION OF 132 KV JUNDLA FROM 1X40/50MVA 132/33 KV PLUS 2X16/20MVA 132/11 KV T/PS TO 1X40/50MVA PLUS 1X20/25 MVA PLUS 2X16/20 MVA 132/11 KV T/PS (CONSTRUCTION OF 61 NO DT-2, 3NO 33KV LA, AND 2NO NCT (CIVIL WORKS). (DISTRICT KARNALI)	22.09.2026 01.10.2026	1,17,701/-	www.hvpnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
3	HVPNL	REPLACEMENT OF EXISTING CONDUCTOR 8.4 S/4ACSR CONDUCTOR WITH EQUIVALENT HTLS CONDUCTOR OF CURRENT CARRYING CAPACITY OF 1200 AMP ON TURUNKY BASIS(PANCHKULA)	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 194 LACS	www.hvpnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
4	HVPNL	CREATION OF 132 KV & 66 KV TRANSMISSION LINE IN KARNALI, AMPALA & SIRSA AREA	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 89.36 LACS	www.hvpnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
5	HVPNL	REPLACEMENT OF EXISTING CONDUCTOR 0.5 S/4ACSR CONDUCTOR WITH EQUIVALENT HTLS CONDUCTOR OF CURRENT CARRYING CAPACITY OF 1200 AMP ON TURUNKY BASIS(PANCHKULA)	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 127 LACS	www.hvpnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No.49645/HRY**



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice

Dy. Chief Engineer/ workshop/ Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invite "Open Tender" through On Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No. : DY-CE-JHSW-103 **Earnest Money Rs. : 648100/-**

Description of Work : RSK/STL-Comprehensive infrastructure upgradation at RSK/STL.

Approx Cost Rs. : 32402387.45 (Three crore twenty four lakh two Thousand three hundred eighty seven Rupees and forty five paise Only)

Cost of Tender Form Rs. : NIL **Date of closing of Tender. : 22.10.2026 At 15:30 hrs**

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months

* For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.irops.gov.in **2175/26 (AS)**

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in cprncr@ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

Additional Chief Engineer P.W.D. Zone-II, Jaipur
PWD Campus, Jacob Road, Jaipur
Phone:- 0141-2226537 Ex.:-299
E-mail:- acezoneii@yahoo.com/acejprii.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

File No.- 1322
Date- 19.09.2026

NIT No-28/2026-27
Bids for "Budget Announcement Year 2026-27, 08 Packages/ Road Works in Jaipur-Rural District are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM on dated 15-10-2026. Other particulars of the bid may be seen on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>) of the state; and <http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in>. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 4028.05lacs.

S.No	UBN	S.No	UBN	S.No	UBN
1	PWD2627WLOB12740	2	PWD2627WSOB12846	8	PWD2627WLOB12849

Addl. Chief Engineer
PWD Zone-II Jaipur

DIPR/C/16388/2026

EXPORT PROMOTION COUNCIL FOR MEDICAL DEVICES
(Set-up by Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry and Chemical and Fertilizers & YEIDA)
YEIDA, Second Floor, Commercial Complex, P-2, Sector Omega 1, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh – 201308

Reference No.: EPCMD/EVENTS/09/2026-01 Dated: 26th September 2026

Request for Proposal (RFP) for Selection of Event Management Agency for India MedTech Expo 2027

Detailed tender document is available on the Export Promotion Council for Medical Devices website (<https://www.epcmd.in/tenders>) from 26/09/2026.

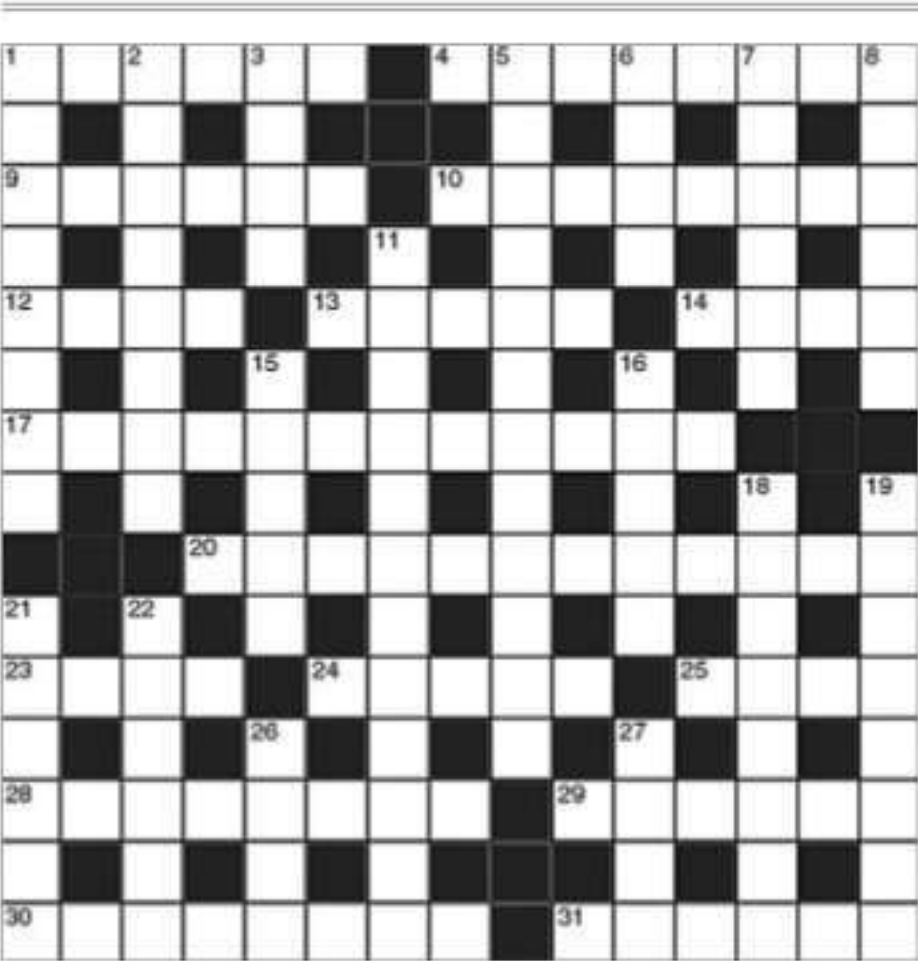
Interested applicants are required to submit their bids to EPCMD Office on or before **15/10/2026, 1000 hrs (IST)** as per the tender document.

In case of any queries, the bidders are invited to contact on the following email id.

ED, EPCMD

E-mail: ed@epcmd.in

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1

Object I've put into the salad (6)
- 4

Could mean coming in last despite everything (5,3)
- 9

Out of the country? (2,4)
- 10

A crying need for free trade cut (4,4)
- 12

Lean nurse (4)
- 13

Follow the band (5)
- 14

Sound cure for cant (4)
- 17

Bound to fight? (2,3,7)
- 20

Travels far and makes one's mark in the world (4,1,4,3)
- 23

A slack return in fielding (4)
- 24

The mating game (5)
- 25

Retainer for an author (4)
- 28

Press the bell and run away for security (8)
- 29

Take quite a time to enjoy membership (6)
- 30

Gloomy result of fewer actors getting parts? (4,4)
- 31

Fishermen use many spinners (6)

DOWN

1

A compulsory turnout (8)

2

Set off for school in time (8)

3

They're taken very seriously (4)

5

Glossy coat shows Parisian chic (6,6)

6

Make sound of a large vessel (4)

7

Sharpness shown by a man with a cue perhaps (6)

8

Very much the opposite (6)

11

Brawl he takes badly is illegal (6,3,3)

15

Attack currency returns (3,2)

16

Gem of standard weight (5)

18

Short odds? That's not fair (3,2,3)

19

How slowly one travelled in olden days (2,6)

21

Critic unreasonably acid (6)

22

Second thoughts about thin pieces of wood (6)

26

Jack and Edward retired (4)

27

Try to be informal (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6103 ACROSS: 1 Offal, 4 Matelot, 8 You, 9 Democracy, 10 Plainer, 11 Sit in, 13 Stifle, 15 Enosis, 18 Comic, 19 Mustard, 21 Potentate, 23 Ear, 24 Everest, 25 Titan DOWN: 1 Olympus, 2 Feudalism, 3 Laden, 4 Memory, 5 Tucks in, 6 Lea, 7 Try-on, 12 Testament, 14 Licence, 16 Sadrion, 17 Impact, 18 Copse, 20 Spent, 22 Tee

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_ does not protect you from __. But __, to some extent, protects you from __. - Jeanne Moreau (3,_,4,_,_,3) (two words twice)

DLREE

DLMAO

AHOSGL

AAELRV

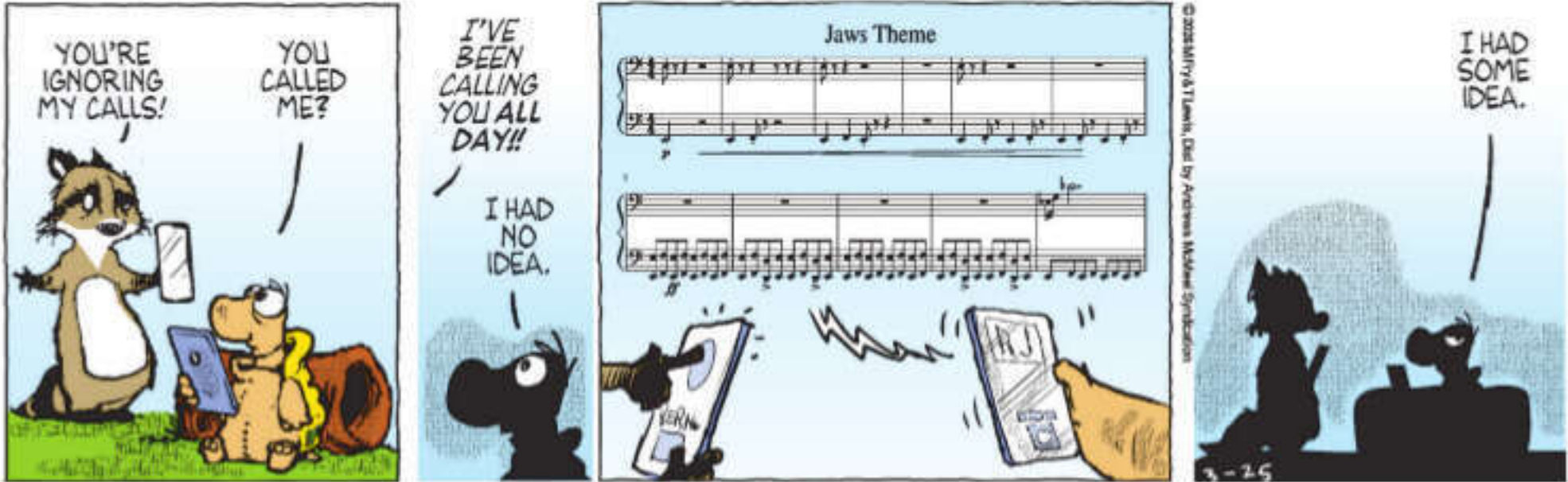
SOLUTIONS: Elder, Modal, Galosh, Larvae

protects you from age - Jeanne Moreau

ANSWER: Age does not protect you from love, but love, to some extent.

6104

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6453

			4					6
7	3			6				5
	8				7	9		
	1							6
	2			3			8	
5							7	
		3	9			8		
	4				7			2
	5					4		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6452

5	4	9	7	2	3	1	8	6
7	3	2	6	8	1	9	5	4
8	1	6	9	5	4	2	3	7
9	2	8	1	6	7	5	4	3
3	7	4	2	9	5	8	6	1
1	6	5	4	3	8	7	2	9
2	8	7	3	4	9	6	1	5
4	5	1	8	7	6	3	9	2
6	9	3	5	1	2	4	7	8

CORPORATE BRIEFS

NGT: Hon. PM of India, Narendra Modi inaugurated and Valedictory Session graced by the Hon'ble President of India, Smt. Droupadi Murmu, as the Chief Guest, the International Conference on "The Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics" at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, organised by the National Green Tribunal. Manohar Lal, Hon. Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs & Minister of Power, Hon. Justice B.V. Nagarathna, Judge, Supreme Court of India, R. Venkataramani, Hon. Attorney General for India along with other officials were part of the program. The Conference acts as an important platform for national & international experts, judicial authorities, environmental practitioners and other stakeholders to exchange knowledge, share, experiences & deliberate on emerging environmental & climate challenges.

IREDA recently conducted its 24th Stakeholders' Interaction Meet through virtual conferencing, chaired by Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty, Chairman, Managing Director, Director (Finance), IREDA. Addressing the participants, Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty emphasized the importance of maintaining asset quality & sound governance practices as key pillars of IREDA's sustainable & long-term growth. He also highlighted the upcoming Bharat RE Summit & Expo 2026, scheduled to be held from 2-5 November 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, as a significant platform for bringing together stakeholders across the renewable energy ecosystem.

ICG, in coordination with the Ministry of Earth Sciences, conducted International Coastal Cleanup Day 2026 across all coastal States and Union Territories on September 19. Marking the culmination of the week-long "Swachh Sagar, Surakshit Sagar 5.0" campaign, the drive mobilised 25,079 volunteers across more than 100 coastal locations. The initiative resulted in the recovery and disposal of 30,554 kg of plastic waste and marine debris. NCC cadets, NSS volunteers, educational institutions, fishing communities, NGOs & civil society groups participated. The campaign highlighted strong interagency cooperation involving government bodies, ports, local administrations, maritime stakeholders and industry partners.

BOB has been awarded the second prize under the GOI's 'Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar' Scheme for the year 2025-26, in the Headquarters category for nationalised banks/ FIs with 800+ employees, in recognition of its outstanding performance in Official Language implementation. This marks the fifth consecutive year that the Bank has received this prestigious award. The award was presented at Hindi Diwas 2026 & the Sixth All India Official Language Conference, held on September 14, 2026 at the CIDCO Exhibition Centre, Navi Mumbai, under the chairmanship of Amit Shah, Hon. Union Minister of Home Affairs and Cooperation. Dr. Debadatta Chand, MD & CEO, BOB, received the award from Nityanand Rai & Bandi Sanjay Kumar, Union Ministers of State for Home Affairs, in the gracious presence of Anshuli Arya, Secretary (OL), GOI & other dignitaries. Additionally, Bank of Baroda received a total of 20 awards across various categories.

SASTRA: "India's growth story is filled with opportunities and the next generation workforce talent makes it a global destination for investment," said R.Shankar Raman, President & Wholetime Director- Finance of Larsen & Toubro during the 40th Convocation Day at SASTRA Deemed University, Thanjavur. He outlined Healthcare, Education, Public Transport & Utilities, Semiconductor, Water, Defence and Energy & Environment as strategic areas of investment that shall leverage the bountiful demographic dividend of India. The Lord Selvamthukumar Award for Overall Academic Excellence & the Silver Jubilee Alumni Award for the Best Outgoing Girl Graduate Student were both awarded to Biyyappu Hari Keerthi of the B.Tec. ECE degree programme.

INFINEON hosted OktoberTech™ Bengaluru on September 21, 2026, marking the first edition of its global innovation platform in India. Held under the theme "Enabling the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047", the event brought together over 800 representatives from industry, government and academia to explore advancements in power electronics, AI, clean energy, smart mobility and digital infrastructure. They also announced collaborations with Scaler, Titan Company Limited and Zenerge, focused on education, digital payments & clean energy. The event highlighted the role of semiconductor innovation in strengthening India's technology ecosystem, developing talent, creating high-value jobs and supporting resilient infrastructure and competitive manufacturing.

NIOS conducted the six-month certificate course in Primary Teacher Education, Noida. The specialised programme was launched by the Hon. Union Education Minister, Pralhad Joshi & has been designed to strengthen the professional competencies of B.Ed qualified teachers working in primary schools to promote quality education. The occasion was attended by T.K. Anil Kumar, Secretary, Department of School Education & Literacy; Prachi Pandey, JS; Bhagwati Prasad Kalal, Director; Prof. Akhilesh Mishra, Chairman, NIOS; Director, Secretary, & other officials. A total of 67,529 teachers from across the country have applied for the specialised Bridge Course. In addition, B.Ed.-qualified in-service teachers from other states have also applied for the programme.

SCOPE organised an Interactive workshop on Labour Law Reforms: Understanding the New Labour Codes & Central Rules with Knowledge Partner, Deloitte. Dr. Mahendra Kumar, JS, Ministry of Labour & Employment, GOI; Dr. K. P. Mahadevaswamy, Chairman, SCOPE & CMD, NBCC; Atul Sobti, DG, SCOPE & Deloitte team - Gokul Chaudhri, President Tax, & Divya Baweja, Partner addressed the inaugural session. The workshop, attended by nearly 100 participants from 32 PSEs & part of SCOPE's ongoing capacity - building initiative, provided comprehensive guidance on implementing statutory provisions regarding wages, social security, workplace safety, and labour - management relations. Speaking on the occasion Shri Atul Sobti hailed the four codes as a globally appreciated 'game changer' that has revolutionised regulatory clarity, efficiency, and inclusivity.

GRID CONTROLLER OF INDIA successfully held its 17th Annual General Meeting on 22nd September in hybrid mode from its Registered Office in New Delhi (Deemed Venue). The meeting was attended by S.C. Saxena, CMD; R.K. Porwal, Director (System Operation); Amit Kumar Jain, Director (Finance) & CFO; and S. Usha, Director (Market Operation), along with Government Nominee Directors, an Independent Director, the Company Secretary, a Ministry of Power representative, and the Statutory and Secretarial Auditors. The CMD briefed members on the Company's functioning and future plans. Members approved a Final Dividend of Rs. 63.32 lakh, in addition to the Interim Dividend of Rs.569.90 lakh paid earlier to the Ministry of Power.

HUDCO organised its annual painting competition for children from underprivileged and vulnerable communities at India Habitat Centre, New Delhi, as a run up to World Habitat Day celebrations. The initiative seeks to sensitise young minds to the importance of safe, inclusive & sustainable habitats, while nurturing creativity, confidence & self - expression. The theme for this year "Adequate Housing for All", encouraged the participants to look beyond the idea of a house as merely a physical structure and reflect on what makes a home safe, secure, healthy, accessible and dignified. Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & MD, HUDCO, along with the Directors and CVO of HUDCO, interacted with the participating children and appreciated their enthusiasm and creativity.

PVNL: Ravish Gupta (IAS), Managing Director, Paschimanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd. (PVNL), conducted a surprise inspection of the Computer Room at the Discom headquarters, Urja Bhawan, Meerut. During the inspection, he reviewed billing data and stressed promoting online electricity payments to provide consumers with convenient services. The MD reviewed smart meter and MRI-based billing, bill exceptions and ATRs of high-revenue-loss feeders. He directed officials to prepare division-, circle- and zone-wise reports of the bottom 10 feeders, along with daily reports on input-billed energy, through-rate and assessment. Director (Commercial) Sanjay Jain, Ravi Kumar, Superintending Engineer, Staff Officer Sonam Singh, Manvendra Singh, Executive Engineer, and other officials and employees were present.

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a restless day for you because the full Moon is in your sign. This happens once a year, and it can create tension between you and those who are close to you. Patience is your best ally. Give yourself the freedom to change plans today. Tonight: You win.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Your work routine might be interrupted today. Be patient with co-workers. Likewise, be patient with care workers and anyone connected with your pet. Today, you're unusually forthright and direct. Tonight: Enjoy some private time.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Be patient and diplomatic when dealing with friends and members of groups. The full Moon energy could create disruptions or tension. You might meet someone unusual. Tonight: Be friendly.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today you might feel torn between the demands of home and family versus the demands of your external world or your career. You can't please both. For this particular full Moon, you can't ignore home and family. Tonight: You're admired.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Pay attention to everything you say and do today because this is an accident-prone day due to the impulsive energy of today's full Moon. Expect to encounter new ideas, new faces and new places. Tonight: Explore and learn something new.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Keep an eye on your cash flow and money scene, as well as your possessions, because something unexpected could impact your assets today. Protect what you own against loss, theft or damage. Avoid hasty decisions. Tonight: Check your finances.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today the full Moon will create tension between you and partners and close friends. Someone might do something least expected. Think twice before you respond. Tonight: Genuinely listen to someone.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): It's a useful moment to consider your physical well-being, taking whatever decisions are necessary to get into shape with diet and exercise. And while you're at it, pursue a new interest now, rather than putting it off.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a challenging day for romance and relations with children as well as social outings, the arts and sports events. Parents should be on guard to avoid accidents with your kids. Likewise, sports accidents might occur. Tonight: Socialise.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You might feel pulled between home and family versus your external world. This is because of the conflicting energy of the full Moon. Your home routine will be interrupted, but you can't ignore the demands of your career. It's tricky. Tonight: Relax.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): This is an accident-prone day. Slow down and pay attention to everything you say and do. Guard against impulsive behaviour. Clever ideas might occur to you. Tonight: Interesting conversations.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Check your bank accounts and shared agreements for errors or unexpected changes. Things might come to a head today and you finally see there's light at the end of the tunnel. Tonight: Check your belongings.

KVIC organised a financial awareness programme on September 18, 2026, at PM Atal Utkrisht Government Inter College, Pujargaon, Saklana, Uttarakhand. Participants were informed about the Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme, which offers bank-linked loans up to ₹50 lakh for manufacturing and ₹20 lakh for service-sector units, along with applicable margin-money subsidies. Information was also shared on the Rural Industrial Development Scheme, covering vocational training & subsidised machinery & tool kits. Officials from KVIC, district administration, banks & training institutions participated, while Chief Guest Sanjay Negi Hon. Minister of State/President, O. B. C. Ayya Uttarakhand encouraged participants to explore self-employment & available government support.

INDIAN BANK: The Hindi in - house magazine "Ind Swaraj" of Indian Bank, Zonal Office, Meerut was recently launched in a dignified ceremony. The magazine was unveiled by Himanshu Kansal, Chief General Manager, Indian Bank in the presence of Ram Swaroop Sarkar, Field General Manager, Santosh Kumar Bhagat, Zonal Manager, along with Branch Managers, senior officers & staff members. The magazine as a platform showcases the creative expression of the Zonal Office, Meerut, its commitment to the Official language & the diverse activities of the Bank. Moreover, the magazine contains a wide range of content related to banking, official language, literature, culture, social concerns, & achievements of the Bank.

GAIL: Manoj Kumar Sharma recently assumed the charge as Director (Projects) of GAIL Ltd (India). Prior to assuming charge as Director (Projects), GAIL Ltd, he served as Executive Director & Regional Head, Eastern Region Pipelines, at IOCL. He was responsible for operations & maintenance, construction & City Gas Distribution businesses across five states, overseeing a pipeline network spanning more than 5,700 km. Sharma holds a Master's in Mechanical Engineering (Production & Industrial Engineering) from Delhi College of Engineering & a PG Diploma in Business Management from XIMB. With over three decades of experience, he has worked across the hydrocarbon infrastructure value chain, spanning design, engineering, project management, procurement, construction, operations & maintenance of crude oil, petroleum products, LPG & natural gas pipelines, as well as major crude oil terminals.

VISION UNLIMITED, a non-for-profit organisation working with children & families in Gurugram's informal settlements, held its first fundraiser on September 19, 2026, at Museo Camera, Gurugram. The event brought together supporters, subject matter experts, community members & well-wishers to highlight the organisation's work & support its programmes. The evening started with the inauguration of Vision Unlimited's book launch by Rao Inderjit Singh, five-term Member of Parliament from Gurugram & Union Minister of State (Independent Charge), GOI. Following the inauguration, Vision Unlimited founder Dr. Shibal Bhartiya highlighted the company's journey. The evening also provided an opportunity for guests to interact with the Vision Unlimited team and panel members over refreshments.

USTM observed National Engineers' Day 2026 on 15 September, commemorating the birth anniversary of the eminent engineer, statesman & visionary Mokshagundam Visvesvaraya. The celebration was held on the theme "Smart Engineering for a Sustainable Future through Innovation and Digitalisation." The celebration brought together students, faculty members and academicians in a spirit of innovation, creativity and learning. The programme was inaugurated by Prof. (Dr.) A.C. Kataki, Director, Medical Administration, P.A. Sangma International Medical College & Hospital (PIMC), USTM, in the presence of dignitaries & officials. Dr Shyamal Baruah, Chief Guest & Chief General Manager, HR, OIL Noida, delivered an insightful address on "From RIGS to HR."

RAJIV GANDHI UNIVERSITY, in Arunachal Pradesh, successfully organised the Youth Festival - Red Run 5 Km Mini Marathon-2026 under the banner of the RGU Red Ribbon Club and NSS Cell, in association with the Arunachal Pradesh State AIDS Control Society (APSACS). The event was organised with the objective of creating awareness among young people about HIV/AIDS prevention and drug abuse and promoting a healthy lifestyle. The programme commenced with a welcome address by Dr. Avicha Tangiang, Assistant Professor, Department of Agriculture and Member of Organizing committee, RGU, followed by the felicitation of the dignitaries. The marathon was formally flagged off by Prof. S. K. Nayak, Hon. VC, Rajiv Gandhi University. The event concluded with an enthusiastic prize distribution ceremony.

MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	98	37	24	159
2	Japan	28	43	44	115
3	S Korea	13	17	34	64
4	Kaz'stan	8	8	14	30
5	Uzb'stan	7	15	9	31
12	India	2	9	12	23

DAY 7 CAPSULE

Haul: 1 Gold, 2 Silver, 3 Bronze

1 GOLD

● **10m air pistol mixed team**
Suruchi Singh and Kamaljeet delivered India's second gold of the Asian Games and the first in any shooting event.

2 SILVERS

● **Men's 50m rifle 3 positions**
Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, Niraj Kumar and Rudranksh Balasaheb Patil got the second shooting medal of the day, finishing behind China.

● **Men's 10,000m**
Gulveer Singh upgraded his Hangzhou bronze and became the first Indian to win two medals at the 10,000m.

3 BRONZE

● **Shot put**
Manpreet Kaur clinched a bronze in the women's shot put event with a best throw of 17.17m, winning her first Asian Games medal. She finished behind two Chinese opponents.

● **Women's pole vault**
Baranica Elangovan's best attempt of 4.15m gave her bronze — India's first ever in the event at the Asiad.

● **Table tennis mixed doubles**
The duo of Manush Shah and Diya Chitale lost to China in the semifinals but were assured of a medal regardless of the result.

TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 8

Shooting: Women's 50m rifle 3 positions individual qualification and team final (6:15 AM)

● Ashi Chouksey, Tilottama Sen, Vidarsa Kochalumkal Vinod will take part in the team medal event, hoping to also qualify for the individual event.

Athletics: Men's shot put final (4:30 PM), Men's triple jump final (5:05 PM), Women's 1500m final (6:45 PM)

● Praveen Chithravel in the triple jump, Parul Chaudhary in the 1500m and Tajinder Pal Singh Toor in the men's shot put will be in action.

Kabaddi: Women's and men's team gold-medal match (9:30 AM, 2:30 PM)

● Both the men's and women's team will take on Iran in the final.

Squash: Men's singles semifinal (11:15 AM)

● Abhay Singh faces Pakistan's Muhammad Irfan.

TOUGH TO BEAT

Indians feel the heat as African-born athletes make a mark

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, September 25

THE AFRICAN presence has stamped its class in track and field at the Asian Games.

In three races — women's 10,000m, men's 10,000m, and mixed 4x400m relay — African-born athletes who switched nationalities, stormed to the podium and in two of them pipped Indians to the gold medal.

This is not the first time that African born athletes are participating in the Asiad. But not only has the number of medals won by them increased (from 14 in 2014 to 16 in 2018), so has the number of countries they represent. For India, it's a challenge because track and field, especially middle distance events, is the strongest suit for the country. Indian athletes have to dig deeper to finish on the podium.

In men's 10000m, Gulveer Singh won a silver after Ethiopia-born Birhanu Balew of Bahrain won the gold. Gulveer, one of the best Asian long distance runners at the moment, was in the leading pack throughout his race. He looked destined for a great finish given his devastating last kick but it was Balew who produced the

“

I won a bronze medal last time (in Hangzhou). So coming into these Games, the plan was to change the colour of the medal.

GULVEER SINGH, ON HIS AIM FOR THE 10,000M RACE

”

Silver lining for Gulveer

Indian finishes second in 10,000m, an upgrade from bronze 3 years ago; set to compete in 1,500m & 5,000m

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 25



FOR 9,750 metres, the Asian Games 10,000m had refused to reveal its winner.

The pack bunched, stretched, re-formed and slowly shed runners, but Gulveer Singh remained exactly where he needed to be — near the front, not setting the pace but matching the rest stride for stride.

Then, with one lap to go, Birhanu Balew made his move. The Bahraini runner came around the outside, taking the lead as the bell rang, and suddenly a race that had, until that point, been a test of patience became a straight fight between two men. Gulveer stayed on his shoulder.

For the next few metres, there was nowhere to hide. Balew pushed, Gulveer answered. Balew held the inside, Gulveer remained within striking distance. The Indian had survived every acceleration thrown at him and now had one final question to answer: could he find enough for the finish?

With 250 metres remaining, Balew found something extra. The gap began to open, and Gulveer chased, his body leaning into the effort, legs still turning after 24 and three-quarter laps of the track.

But Balew had one more gear. The Ethiopia-born runner sprinted to the finish in 28:27.51, arms spread wide, with Gulveer taking silver in 28:29.38. The Indian stopped almost immediately, dropped to his knees, bent forward and kissed the track. Then he got up and sprinted out of the stadium.

He will be back on Saturday for the 1,500m heats — the second of the three events he will run in Nagoya. “I won a bronze medal last time (in Hangzhou). So coming into these Games, the plan was to change the colour of the medal,” Gulveer said.



Gulveer Singh finished with a time of 28:28.38 and became the first Indian to win two Asiad medals in the 10,000m event. PTI

Fine margins

For Gulveer, the silver was both a reward for the work that had brought him here and a reminder of how fine the margins are at this level. Scott Simmons, his coach, believed that the Indian's best chance of winning lay in turning the race into a quicker affair. “The only way that Gulveer had a chance for gold was, honestly, if it was a 27-minute race,” Simmons said.

The reasoning was straightforward. Balew, the Diamond League 5,000m champion, had demonstrated his finishing speed at the highest level, including a commanding performance in Belgium. Even Gulveer knew what he was up against. “His finish is strong. He is faster than me. But I will try to challenge him,” he said. A faster race, Simmons felt, might have given Gulveer a better opportunity to challenge Balew over the final lap. Instead, the Indian had to rely on his finishing speed against a runner who had more in reserve. “He finished very well in 57 seconds,” Simmons said, referring to Gulveer's final lap. “Yeah. But (Balew's was) 55 seconds.”

Could Gulveer have taken the initiative and pushed the

India's 10,000M medalists (Men)

NAME	YEAR	TIME
Tarlok Singh	1962	30:21.4
Hari Chand	1978	30:07.7
	SILVER	
Shivnath Singh	1974	30:51.61
Kartik Kumar	2023	28:15.38
Gulveer Singh	2026	28:28.38
	BRONZE	
Gurbachan Singh	1951	34:58.7
Gulab Chand	1998	29:10.53
Gulveer Singh	2023	28:17.21

pace towards a 27-minute finish? Simmons was reluctant to suggest that it would have changed the outcome, particularly with the Indian still scheduled to run the 1,500m and 5,000m.

“He has a big menu for the rest of the week,” Simmons said. “And even then... You never know. This is a man who ran under 59 minutes for the half marathon. I mean, Gulveer ran very well under 60 minutes, but he is not at the same level at this point.”

The two seconds that separated them over the final lap were the difference between gold and

silver. But Gulveer's ability to stay in contention against a runner of Balew's calibre reflected how far he has come.

At the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou, Gulveer had won bronze in the 10,000m, having only begun competing in athletics in 2019. Since then, he has rewritten the Indian national records in both the 5,000m and 10,000m, clocking 12:59.77 and 27:00.22 respectively. He went on to win both events at the 2025 Asian Athletics Championships before adding a silver in the 10,000m and a bronze in the 5,000m at the 2026 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

He will be back on Saturday for the 1,500m heats — the second of the three events he will run in Nagoya

Those performances have changed the expectations surrounding him. He is no longer simply an Indian runner trying to keep pace with the leading athletes in Asia. He has become one of the men expected to challenge them, with the national records and international medals to back up those ambitions.

Gulveer, though, resisted making any bold claims. “I have not set any target as such. I haven't kept a point for me to reach. I just want to keep improving, climb up the ladder one step at a time and not lose any rhythm,” he said.

The silver in the 10,000m was the first of three tests in Nagoya. On Saturday, Gulveer will return to the track for the 1,500m heats, with the 5,000m still to come. The pursuit of a different colour of medal is not over.

POLE VAULT BRONZE

Before the crossbar, Baranica had to clear pole transport hurdle



Baranica Elangovan's 4.30 metre pole was 90 centimetres longer than what is allowed on most commercial airplanes. PTI

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 25

A FEW days before Baranica Elangovan was due to leave for Japan, there was still one question hanging over her Asian Games campaign: would her pole make it there?

On Friday, the 29-year-old cleared 4.15 metres to win bronze in the women's pole vault, becoming the first Indian to win an Asian Games medal in the event. But getting the equipment that would carry her over the bar to Nagoya had been a struggle of its own.

The 4.30m pole was hardly something she could simply check in with her luggage. More than six or seven airlines were approached, emails were sent, and the answer kept coming back the same: their regulations allowed equipment only up to 3.40 metres. Baranica's pole was 90 centimetres longer. “It was a big struggle,” said her coach Milber Bertrand Russell. “We tried more than six to seven airlines, we tried, sent emails. The problem was the length was too high.”

The Athletics Federation of India then stepped in. “They explained to the airline officials that this is sports equipment and we are going to the Asian Games to represent our country,” Russell said.

Eventually, Japan Airlines agreed.

The clearance came a few days before Baranica's departure. The poles would travel with her after all.

For pole vaulters, transporting their equipment is a familiar logistical headache. Thankfully for Baranica, the problem was solved before she left India. In Nagoya, she had another one to deal with: clearing the bar.

Her 4.15m clearance was below the 4.23m national record she set earlier this year, but it was enough to put her on the podium. She shared bronze with Kazakhstan's Polina Ivanova, who also cleared 4.15m. Japan's Misaki Morota won gold with a jump of 4.55m while Niu Chungue of China clinched silver after clearing 4.50m.

For Baranica, the medal carried the weight of a much longer struggle. She tore the ACL in her take-off leg in 2020 and spent years trying to rebuild her body and career. This year, she began finding her heights again, breaking the national record twice.

On Friday, she needed two attempts to jump over 4.15m. She could not get over 4.25m, but by then the medal was secure.

“I'm really happy that I was able to bring a medal for my country,” she said. “It's my dream, actually, to change it, rewrite history, and I did it today.”

The pole had arrived in time. Baranica had done the rest.

For Manpreet, bronze medal & redemption

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 25

SEVEN YEARS after she was first banned following a positive dope test, 36-year-old Manpreet Kaur won a shot put bronze, her first medal at the continental games. Manpreet's 17.17 metre throw was bettered by the other podium finishers, the Chinese duo of Song Jiyuan (19.40m) and Zhang Linru (18.14m), but winning the Asian Games medal was special because her 14-year-old daughter Jasnoor and husband-and-coach Karamjeet Singh were watching from the stands.

“The biggest delight is seeing my daughter and husband cheering for me from the stands,” Manpreet told *The Indian Express*.

Life has been one battle after another for Manpreet, but she took it in her stride to emerge as an Asian Games medalist in the winter of her career. The Haryana athlete became only the third Indian woman after Barbara Webster (1951) and Kiran Baliyan (2023) to win a medal in shot put at the Asian Games.

Her father passed away when she was just 12. “Losing my father at the age of 12 was tough for me. My mother has been paralysed since 2005,” Manpreet said.

A C-section delivery made it tough for her to return to competition. “Since it was a C-section, the recovery took time. On return to training, the main problem was that I could not do weight training for a long time. But my father-in-law, Bhupinder Singh, would always encourage me,” she said.

A technical input also worked for her. “Earlier, I used to throw with the glide technique but then my husband suggested that I try the rota-



Manpreet served a doping ban but has bounced back at 36. PTI

tional technique as my height is less. As I regained my upper body strength, it worked well for me,” Manpreet said.

Then came the dope ban. Manpreet blames it on contaminated supplements. “While contamination and other factors are there, an athlete cannot run from the responsibility. The ban was a tough phase for me but my mother-in-law Sukhwant Kaur would tell me to recite Sukhmani path (devotional recital) and it helped me mentally,” Manpreet said.

A young Manpreet grew up in Sahauli village, where her farming family was based. She started off as a sprinter. Her cousin Jagjeet Singh Randhawa is the one who inspired her to take up track and field.

Post 2014, Manpreet would cross the 17-metre mark and set the national record of 17.96 metres. She bettered the mark to 18.86 metres at the 2017 Asian Championships in Bhubaneswar. But following the doping ban, this mark was erased. But the bronze at the Asian Games has given her a lease of life. “The medal is a reward for not giving up despite the many hurdles,” she said.



Birhanu Balew mostly trains in Ethiopia year round. In the men's 10,000m final, his finishing kick was too good for Gulveer Singh. AP

Qatar was one of the earliest adopters of the practice when Somalia-born Mohamed Suleiman in the 1500m discipline became their first Olympic medallist at the 1992 Barcelona Olympics.

It started mainly at the 2006 Doha Asian Games where Kenya-born runners won the men's 800m, 1500m, 5,000m, 10,000m, 3000m steeplechase and marathon for Qatar and Bahrain. The practice in-

creased after 2006 and was at peak during the period of 2012 to 2016 where Bahrain got 18 athletes from Kenya, 17 from Ethiopia, 5 from Morocco and 2 from Nigeria.

It coincided with the improvement in medal tally as Bahrain went from nine athletics medals in 2010 Asian Games to 19 (9 gold) in 2014 Incheon edition, 26 (12 gold) in 2018 Jakarta edition, and 16 (10 gold) in 2023 Hangzhou edition.

Bahraini athletes who have won gold

Event	Athlete	Origin Country
Men's 10000m	Birhanu Balew	Ethiopia
Women's 10000m	Winfred Yavi	Kenya
Mixed 4*400m team	Multiple athletes	Nigeria

The uber rich Gulf countries tended to negotiate with the family of these athletes giving them a good lifestyle and a chance to compete at the top level. Like in the case of Balew, whose family is taken well care of and keeps switching between Bahrain and Ethiopia.

“Life has changed for me after I started competing for Bahrain. I drive a Corolla and have a new home. I train in Ethiopia mostly year round. I love Bahrain, my family keeps switching between Bahrain and Ethiopia,” Balew told the media after his 2026 Asian Games gold medal.

However, the bulk transfers in the period based purely on financial arrangements, resulted in World Athletics freezing the

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Gukesh keeps India in title race

World champ turns tables on Alexander Donchenko to subdue Germany

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 25

THERE WERE no icy stares across the board, no trademark strolls with hands buried casually in trouser pockets, and no quiet aura farming over a sip of water. For more than five agonising hours of the ninth round, D Gukesh was stripped of his usual unflappable swagger, consumed entirely by the suffocating heat of a lost position and an inspired Alexander Donchenko pushing his team of giant-slayers Germany toward another famous scalp.

With Nihal Sarin having already split the point, and neither R Praggnanandhaa nor Arjun Erigaisi ceding an inch of ground in their stubborn, deadlocked battles, India's gold-medal defence at the 2026 Chess Olympiad was slipping away by the second. What followed was daylight robbery from a 54-move Houdini act by the world champion that flipped certain defeat into a miraculous turnaround, snatching an improbable 2.5-1.5 victory from the jaws of defeat and keeping the champions alive in Samarkand. Germany have been the surprise package of this tournament.

Having pulled off two monumental upsets by toppling the top-seeded, mighty Americans and tournament

favourites Uzbekistan, the Germans have transformed into the most feared side.

For the better part of the round, they made sure defending champions India understood exactly why they have earned that fearsome reputation. Nihal was drafted back into the playing four following his two consecutive defeats and was immediately pressed hard by Frederik Svane. Nihal, however, eventually managed to neutralise the position, finding precise resources to steer the game into a threefold repetition draw.

On the top board, Praggnandhaa collided with Vincent Keymer, but the German No. 1 stood firm as a rock to deny the Indian prodigy any inroads. Candidates participant Matthias Bluebaum was equally unyielding on Board 2, successfully shutting the door even as Arjun Erigaisi tried every trick in the book to manufacture an edge.

Once again, it all boiled down to Gukesh and the world champion did not disappoint.

Gukesh and Olympiads are simply a match made in heaven. Across three editions spanning four years, from Mahabalipuram in 2022 and Budapest in 2024 to Samarkand in 2026, Gukesh has suffered just a solitary defeat. His infamous endgame heartbreak against Nodirbek Abdusattorov remains the only occasion he has ever conceded a full point on this stage.

Consistent form

In this edition, too, despite widespread chatter surrounding his patchy form and his tactical demotion from Board 1 to Board 4, Gukesh has consistently delivered when India



Gukesh flipped a certain defeat into victory against Germany's Donchenko. FIDE/FILE

needed him most. While facing relatively lower-rated opposition on the lower boards comes with the territory, it is Gukesh's clutch match-winning points that have single-handedly kept India's pursuit of gold alive.

Yet, India now have glaring vulnerabilities laid bare for the field to exploit. Arjun, usually the man who thrives in utter chaos over the board, has gone strangely quiet. The ruthless streak that saw him dismantle

the field on Board 3 in Budapest for an individual gold hasn't shown up in Samarkand. Ever since that opening-round ambush by Thailand's 2363-rated Prin Laohawirapap, the engine has sputtered and Arjun has scraped together just a solitary win across his next seven games.

Up on the top board, Praggnandhaa has been rock-solid and tough to crack, but even he, arguably India's most in-form player coming in, has

managed only two wins in eight rounds.

Throw in Nihal's slump, which has seen a bright start unravel into half a point in three games with two stinging defeats, and the pattern is impossible to miss. With the rest of the board struggling to finish games, the burden of getting points has fallen squarely on Gukesh.

Women beat Uzbeks

In the women's section, the

Indian team did their gold-medal credentials a world of good by powering past hosts Uzbekistan 3-1, courtesy of clinical wins from Divya Deshmukh and Vantika Agrawal on the middle boards.

Veteran Koneru Humpy's clash against Afruza Khamdamova on the top board ended in a steady draw.

On Board 4, the tournament's breakout star Savitha Shri B was pushed to the absolute brink by Guldona Karimova.

The high-flying teenager, however, showed nerves of steel to wriggle out of trouble and secure a draw, her first split point of the event after a blistering seven-match winning streak.

Once again, it was the star duo from Budapest which delivered when it mattered most. Vantika, armed with white pieces, punished a string of inaccuracies from Nilufarkhon Imomkuzieva to wrap up an emphatic 54-move victory. Beside her, Divya rolled up her sleeves for a marathon grind, methodically breaking down Gulrukhbegim Tokhirjonova's resistance to squeeze out a hard-fought win in 72 moves.

With just two rounds left in Samarkand, both Indian sides now occupy second place on the leaderboard.

For the women, the path to the top goes straight through leaders China in a virtual gold-medal decider. The men, meanwhile, square off against a tricky Uzbekistan B side.

While Srinath Narayanan's men are firm favourites to pick up match points there, they still need Armenia to take something off Uzbekistan's senior team to keep their destiny in their own hands.

ASIAN GAMES: TABLE TENNIS



Manush Shah (L) and Diya Chitale won mixed doubles medal. FILE

Diya dedicates Asiad bronze to late mentor

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 25

BEFORE THE bronze medal at Asian Games, came the grief of losing her mentor.

When Diya Chitale, 23, faced Indonesia's Almaira Nebuchadnezzar at Sky Hall five days ago, her mind was elsewhere. She had just been informed by India teammates about Peter Engel's passing away and was processing the loss. Diya, who won the mixed doubles table tennis bronze partnering Manush Shah, 25, was 12 when she started training with former India table tennis coach Engel in Germany. Over time, he became more than a mentor. She could talk to him about any problem in life.

While the young paddler was making a mark internationally, Engel — in his 70s — was not keeping well. He kept training Diya with the same passion, until his health got the better of him last week.

"Without him I would not have been where I am... I was devastated (when I came to know about Engel's demise)," Diya told *The Indian Express* from Toyota.

Her family and other coaches helped her come to terms with the loss. On Friday, she paid rich tribute to Engel with the Asian Games medal.

"He would have wanted that I not dwell on it (his death). This medal is for him; it would have made him happy," Diya said. The main challenge for Diya-Manush, going into the Asiad was finding time to practise together amid a gruelling calendar. With no India camp scheduled, Manush landed up in Mumbai — Diya's hometown — earlier this month. They trained at the Khar Gymkhana for four days to get in sync before leaving for Japan.

When Manush was not there, Diya honed her serve and return of serve solo for months. "Doubles is not only about you converting the points, but also creating opportunities for your partner to close out the points. Diya has to create that opportunity for Manush," her father Parag explained.

This strategy has worked well for the world No. 8 duo in the past, as evidenced by their global feats. They were the first Indian pair to enter a WTT Star Contender, in Brazil, and are the only Indians to have qualified for the season-ending WTT Finals (Hong Kong 2025).

The strategy also worked well in the initial two rounds of the Asian Games. Yet, Manush and Diya flipped it around in the quarterfinal.

They were up against Hong Kong's Wong Chung Ting and Doo Hoi Kem — a pair that had beaten them thrice in a row. The last two losses had been especially narrow, with Manush and Diya conceding the first two games and then going down fighting. They had to do the early running this time.

"We thoroughly studied the (previous) match alongside national head coach Massimo (Constantini)," Manush told this paper. "(There was) controlled aggression from my end and slightly more aggressive from Diya," he added.

The new plan worked. The Indians finished with a scoreline of 11-6, 13-15, 11-9, 11-5 against the world No. 4 combine. Manush and Diya sealed the country's second mixed doubles Asiad podium after Achanta Sharath Kamal-Manika Batra in 2018, and fourth overall.

Long-held promise

While Diya has overcome multiple setbacks, Manush has built on his long-held promise. A hyperactive kid as per mother Reena, Manush picked up the paddle in fourth standard but already possessed "extraordinary power".

"That's why I took all decisions very fast in his case. I taught him all the strokes in six months and told his father to get him an imported bat," his first coach Shailesh Gosain recalled. There was no looking back for the left-hander, who is now the nation's top-ranked singles player and the fulcrum of its men's doubles and mixed doubles fortunes.

Manush was seeded second alongside Manav in Aichi-Nagoya and they were the contingent's strongest TT medal hopes on paper. These hopes were dashed in a 3-1 defeat to Japan's tricky scratch-pair opponents Tomokazu Harimoto and Shinuzoka Hiroto. But Manush made the most of a relatively favourable draw earlier in mixed doubles.

Him and Diya will face sterner challenges in the future. They see the momentous medal as the beginning of "something big for Indian table tennis". As Diya put it, "This is just a tick on a list; the goal is Olympics."

Bad shoulder, a mental funk: Defending champs Sat-Chi exit

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, September 25

SQUARE ONE isn't exactly where Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty are at, in a linear way, after being ousted from the Asian Games in the first round. This is more like a Rubik's Cube square that's gone awry — it's uncertain how many turns of the cuboid would be needed to align their colour cubes.

Gold medal defenses aren't going too swell for India this Asian Games, across the board. Though that wasn't a pressure-point for Satwik-Chirag who have won gold at Hangzhou.

The Round of 32 loss to Thailand's World No.36 Pakkapon Teeratsakul and Peeratchai Sukhphun 21-12, 19-21, 21-14, was in tune with their previous two matches against these Thais — both three-setters.

Teeratsakul-Sukhphun only squeezed the pressure point triggering an old Achilles Heel, which flares up and breaks out like a nut-allergy. They were showered with flat shrapnel by the speedy Thais and their lifts

dangled at midcourt. So, Teeratsakul-Sukhphun smashed with elan, and the Indians plunged in defensive turmoil.

It happened around the middle of the mid-set, and Satwik wasn't in a physical condition to face the barrage. His attack was numb on the day, and that psychologically imperils his defensive confidence. Later, Chirag would say they got into a mental funk as well. And when doubts creep in, they don't play freely, don't strut like Hulk, opponents can kick the door ajar.

The second set seeded tentativeness in their brains, and it carried into the third. It really did not help that the Indians just couldn't attack (old shoulder issues), and were derailed against a pairing who couldn't be smacked to the backcourt.

It's the sort of imploding that has struck other pairs too. Chinese Liang Weikeng-Wang Chang might even get split by the coaches and made to play with other partners, after they were forced to cower by the Satwik-Chirag attack 48 hours ago.



Satwik-Chirag lost in the first round of the Asian Games. FILE

The day before that, Seo Seung-jae and Kim Won Ho collapsed against the Chinese the same way. Top pairs lose, when the schedule is as crazy as it is at Asiad, where badminton has to vacate to make way for padel.

But Satwik will have a tough time explaining, why he could summon the smashes in the first set, but faded off in the next two. Or why bad form hits without politely seeking permission to enter their game.

t just did. And the Thais were delirious to dump out the

defending champs.

Goliaths always look glum when felled, and Chirag who sent the last three returns from a frantic sitting position, was distraught even as Satwik looked stunned. But the energy was vamooring in the second set itself. All of last week through the team events and 10 days back enroute to winning China Masters, the Indians were getting dragged into decider.

It becomes a Rubik Cube puzzle because Satwik is still to decide on whether he will go in

for shoulder surgery, which could be 6-8 months in very nervy rehab, because those are complicated comebacks.

The duo have shown up at every team event — 2 Asiad medals and 2 Thomas Cup medals for India. And the shoulder overuse is more painful than anyone can imagine. It hurts Satwik mentally too, when he can't be at a 100 percent. But the surgery dilemma is agonizing for him. On days he wins — like at the China Masters — he will wonder if he should get on the surgeon's table.

On freaky Fridays of first round exits or World Championships quarters, it's easy to blame the shoulder, yet not know if that's what betrayed his game. It doesn't help that they have ticked those boxes before, and there's a constant decision of how much to push.

LA qualification starts Labour Day, May 1st of 2027. Sport is always at the mercy of muscle-health, including the brain muscle, so Satwik and Team Satwik-Chirag have a think slammed on them.

Medals come in three colours, the Rubik Cube comes in 6 different directions of crossroads.

India's badminton gold will need to come from the other Shetty. Or Sen — who doesn't have an easy draw either.

Other pairs advance

It could've been a double whammy for Indian doubles, who have been handed tough early draws. World Championships bronze medallists ran into a Hong Kong puzzle of their own — as Hiu Yan Tsang and Lok Lok Lui attacked the Indians in a mirror image of how Treesa-Gayatri slay giants — angled attacks. The 21-16, 16-21, 21-16 was one right scare for the Indians, but they stayed calm treating every shuttle on merit and not making it look monstrous in their heads. They play World No.3 Fukushima and Matsumoto next.

The biggest doubles win however belonged to mixed doubles as Tanisha Crasto and Dhruv Kapila packed off tough Malaysian World No.10 Shevon Jemie Lai-Sun Huat Goh, 22-20, 24-20 to reach quarterfinals.

{ INDIA VS WI }

Captain Gill, the cadet among ODI generals, making his mark

Sandip G
Thiruvananthapuram, September 25

IN HIS retreat to the dugout after a lengthy shift in the nets, Shubman Gill hears a scream that echoes in the arena and stops him. He turns back to see spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule, who wants a word with him. As soon as the chat ends, Yashasvi Jaiswal ambles to him, padded up, and wants him to watch him for a few minutes. Gill obliges, patiently watches him and flashes a thumbs up. Ambles in head coach Gautam Gambhir; he wants him to have a pitch-peep.

It's at least half an hour before Gill resumes his dugout trudge. Briskly, he unfastens his pads and gear, wipes the sweat off his brows and strides again to survey the nets. His days and nets, since becoming the captain in Tests and ODIs, have been markedly busier than those days when he was merely a batsman. He has to be in the game — and the nets — all the time. But Gill is not fussy, rather he has quietly worn the weight

of variegated responsibilities.

Here is a paradox, too. Gill walks like any other cricketer on the field, without a smouldering ego, without the sudden urgency that the sight of a captain instigates in his troops, without the artificial seriousness of an old-school captain, his demeanour and personality unaltered by captaincy. Maybe it's the Gen Z vibe — and he is India's first of them. Maybe, he still feels like a cadet among the generals. It's no more evident than when he plays in an ODI game.

Legends of game

Legends of the game lurk around him. Two of them — Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli — are arguably the finest ever captains of their country. Ravindra Jadeja has featured in nearly thrice as many games as he had. KL Rahul and Kuldeep Yadav made their debut half a decade before he had. Weave in Hardik Pandya and Jasprit Bumrah, he could feel genuinely overawed when he steps onto the dressing room, or when he marshals them on the field.

Yet, their aura doesn't crush



Shubman Gill. FILE/CREIMAS

him. He draws his line in the sand. He seeks opinions and suggestions, but the decisions are his. He stands by them, not defiantly but firmly. Like he defended his decision to enforce follow-on, not emotionally or staunchly, but with a cold-eyed

conviction. He readily admits his mistakes, sometimes shoulders the responsibility of a collective failure on himself, as he did during the ODI defeats in England. With the microphone in hand in the press conference, he talks all that is necessary. Words chosen with such judiciousness that those would not be misconstrued. He doesn't drag or meander. He doesn't lay the charm offensive, or deviate from awkward topics with wit or humour. He is matter-of-fact, un-intimate, yet he is not detached.

Slowly, he is spinning the Gill brand of leadership. The essence is hard to define in words, but brings the Gen Z characteristics of being intense without looking stern, aggressive without being belligerent, composed without seeming laid-back, assertive but not overbearing. It's equally important to not perceive him, both his tactics and persona, through the moulds of his predecessors.

He would not micromanage like MS Dhoni would; he would not wear his heart on the sleeve like Kohli would; he wouldn't

exude the unreal cool of Rohit. He would rather be himself, or put in his own words, "take the best out of every captain he has played under." "You can take qualities from Rohit bhai or even Mahi (MS Dhoni) bhai, Virat (Kohli) bhai, Hardik (Pandya) bhai, all of them," he had once said. Since he has played most of his career under Rohit, some of the latter's affinities could subconsciously enter his style.

He is not obsessed with building a distinct style of captain either. "The more you play, the more experience you get. I think your personal style is more visible to the people," he said last year. Or rather, he lets the world judge him they want him, and not the way he wants them to. He has flaws, like all captains have at all stages of their careers. He would blunder and slip-up, but that's part of growth.

But it is easy to forget in the onslaught of fixtures that he is still a nascent captain, he is not as well-worn a cricketer as some of his predecessors when he became the leader. He is not an accidental captain, but a "project captain", where someone is

groomed into a captain. Then, great players often have captaincy forced upon them at some point in their career, whatever their leadership qualities.

Judgments on him, especially in the ODIs, should take into consideration the milieu where it is barely played. Gill was only 55-games-old when he was assigned the responsibility. In contrast, Kohli had 178 ODIs under his belt, when he took over from Dhoni. Rohit's count was more than 200-plus games. Unlike in their years, bilateral series are running dry, triangular tournaments are non-existent, making it tough to remain grooved into the format. In seven years, Gill logged in only 67 games; Kohli played 64 in 2011 and 2012 combined.

Ironically, Gill's first true judgement day would be an ODI tournament, the World Cup next year. No result, apart from a title triumph, would be considered a success. But Gill doesn't seem to be daunted by the challenges thrown at him. And he is imperceptibly building a world of his own.